

How to Convince a Common Man - The One Thing the Techno-Fascist Right Was Smarter About Than the New Left

Preface

I originally didn't want to finish this essay series. I started it on the brink of the last U.S. election, and somewhere in the run-up to November I went fed up with politics as a whole. Partly because I had already predicted, and was later proven right, that Trump would be voted back into power, as I laid out in [*Trump, Trumpism & Transactionalism - And How We Traded Short-Term Lies for Long-Term Loss \(120 pages\)*](#). And partly because I had already written over 1200 pages on politics across my career, and I was tired of watching the same failure repeat itself in slow motion: the American left and left as a whole, for all its talk, remains largely incapable of wielding real power or building lasting representation for the working class it claims to "represent". There are exceptions. Bernie Sanders. Zohran Mamdani. Or Mette Frederiksen (Although she is from Europe, Denmark's Social Democrats and currently in power as Prime Minister). But they are exceptions, few and far between, and exceptions are not a strategy. But the larger reason is this: here in Europe, we are facing existential threats to both our diplomatic and military security and I've come to believe that the underlying dysfunction eroding European politics is, at its root, the same one corroding the American left. What starts as an American story about a party losing its own working class turns out, on closer inspection, to be a European story too (though definitely in different flavors, but still made from the same ingredients). Hence my decision to finish this essay series.

So before anything else, let me state plainly what politics is really about, because everything that follows depends on it. If you want the long version, the 2,500-year history of the most prolific political thinkers across the globe, I've already written it in my [*What even is Politics? \(49 pages\)*](#) essay. But for brevity's sake, the short version is this: **politics is about power**. And the left, at this moment at least, is largely incapable of wielding it.

Two ideas hold this essay series together, and I want to name them up front rather than bury them in footnotes. The first is Thomas Piketty's account of the *Brahmin left* and the *merchant right*, the great realignment in which the educated class drifted left while the working class drifted right, inverting a century of political common sense. The second is Barbara and John Ehrenreich's concept of the *professional-managerial class*, the stratum of credentialed, white-collar professionals whose interests, culture, and politics diverge sharply from the working class they often claim to represent. Together, these two ideas explain most of what confuses people about the modern left: why it talks like it represents the powerless while governing like it represents the powerful, and why it keeps losing the very people it claims to speak for.

There is a way out, and it isn't mine. It belongs to the political scientist [Adolph L. Reed Jr.](#), who has called for a "**socialism for grown-ups**" - a politics that cares about winning power and materially improving people's lives, rather than performing virtue for an audience that already agrees with you. I think that's the correct standard, and I intend to hold the modern left to it throughout this series.

One more thing before we start. This essay is partially a continuation of my previous documentary, [Why Fascism Stems From Ordinary People, Not Monsters \(77 pages\)](#), which could be thought of as a companion article, and not a mandatory read. So, when I use the word **modern left or new left or woke left**, I don't mean it as an insult. I mean something specific: a **consciousness-first politics**, one that treats the awakening of a correct awareness as the precondition for everything else, before solidarity, before coalition, before power itself can be built. And here also lies the problem. Solidarity, coalition, and the plain business of engaging with people who disagree with you all get pushed to the far side of a conversion experience that has to happen before politics can even begin. Meanwhile, people who vote for the right and people who vote for the left alike are living with real struggles that never get represented, let alone followed through, in courts, in laws, or in daily life. That's the definition I'll be working with, and I'll defend it at length.

People who know me know that for me, children come first. Not as an abstraction, not as a rhetorical trump card, but as a genuine standard I try to hold every political position against. I hold that standard as close to a moral bedrock as I have. So when I criticize a politics, left or right, for treating children as instruments of adults rather than as people whose actual wellbeing has to come first, that isn't a culture-war or class-war reflex. This paragraph is the one place in this whole series where I'm not just describing a mechanism. I'm telling you where I actually stand, personally. It won't carry over into how I treat the rest of the material here. The rest of this series stays in the register of analysis, not personal conviction. And if, for whatever reason, you might be interested in my personal convictions, please be advised to read [Why I Am Not a Communist](#). Nonetheless if I were to describe my convictions in one sentence:

5000 years of civilization. 5000 years of civilization, and there are still some fucked-up folks out there - and, more dreadfully, even in positions of Real Power - who think murdering infants & children can be somehow justified.

For further notes, read my article: [Nietzsche Killed God. We Murdered Hope While the Children Wore Their Best Clothes.](#) or my documentaries about [Gaza Genocide \(58 pages\)](#) or [Russo-Ukrainian War \(86 pages\)](#).

But now, back to the essays: None of what follows is settled ground. The education divide can be read more than one way. And nothing in this series denies that racial or cultural or structural injustice is real. What I am arguing is narrower and, I think, harder to dismiss: a left built almost entirely around consciousness rather than power has not

managed to win a governing majority, and it keeps losing the very people it claims to speak for.

With that on the table, let's begin.

Abstract

The [How to Convince a Common Man - The Only One Thing the Techno-Fascist-Right Was Smarter About Than the New Left \(152 pages\)](#), focuses on what wokeism or the new left is, where it comes from, and what it means for left politics going forward. In Part 1 of that series, I established the core definition: new or modern or woke left is a post-materialist, consciousness-first style of politics that presupposes the awakening of a correct consciousness as the prerequisite for political solidarity and political action. Drawing on [Musa Al-Gharbi's](#) empirical research in [We Have Never Been Woke](#), I showed that the primary carriers of wokeism are symbolic capitalists, the stratum of the Professional Managerial Class (PMC) whose work involves the production and manipulation of discourse, rhetoric, and cultural meaning, in fields like establishment, media, art, entertainment, and law. These awakenings erupt cyclically during periods of elite overproduction, when the credentialed class expands faster than the institutions meant to absorb it.

In Part 2, I traced the historical genealogy of this consciousness-first template from its origins in American evangelical Protestant revivalism, through its secularization in the consciousness-raising movements of the 1960s and 1970s, through the rise of identity politics and intersectionality, and into its institutional capture through universities, corporations, and the expanding professional managerial class. That genealogy also established an important distinction: classical Marxism, at least as envisioned by Marx and Engels, was (in simple terms) not woke. Marx's theory of class conflict was predicated on the idea that the working class already acts in its own interest, that class conflict is already inevitable, and that the duty of revolutionary leaders was to steer already existing social forces toward emancipation rather than to awaken a passive mass to a new consciousness. Marxism was supposed to be a tool for the working class, grounded in the objective conditions of production and organization. For further reference please read my: [How Did Marx Understand the World? \(33 pages\)](#) and [How Capitalism Conquered the World? \(52 pages\)](#).

In Part 3, I turn from genealogy to diagnosis: is wokeism actually exhausting itself, and what comes next? I trace how the pandemic and its aftermath hardened a class divide between the "laptop left" and the working majority, then argue that AI-driven job displacement is collapsing the credential hedge that once made white-collar professions feel safer than the humanities, threatening to produce a Fifth Awakening across a much wider class terrain. I also examine whether the right has its own equivalent to wokeism (arguing that neoreaction shares its structural root in elite overproduction but not its consciousness-first character), and look at the return of class

politics on both left and right, using Zohran Mamdani's 2025 NYC win as a case study showing both the promise and the limits of redirecting overproduced symbolic-capitalist energy toward material politics.

In Part 4, the final installment (which is still being written), I turn from diagnosis to strategy: what does a genuinely post-woke left politics actually require? I argue the answer is not agnostic tolerance of the woke tendency, treating it as a harmless quirk to be quietly out-organized while focusing purely on economics, but its outright rejection. Titled "The Culture War is the Class War," this essay makes the case that class and culture cannot be treated as separable terrains, that "not caring" about cultural questions is itself a losing strategy that cedes the left's public image to its least representative faction, and lays out what a working-class-oriented left actually needs to look like in practice if it wants to escape the consciousness-first template traced across the first three parts.

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Part 1 - The Genealogy of Wokeism

Can We Finally Define What “Wokeism” Is?

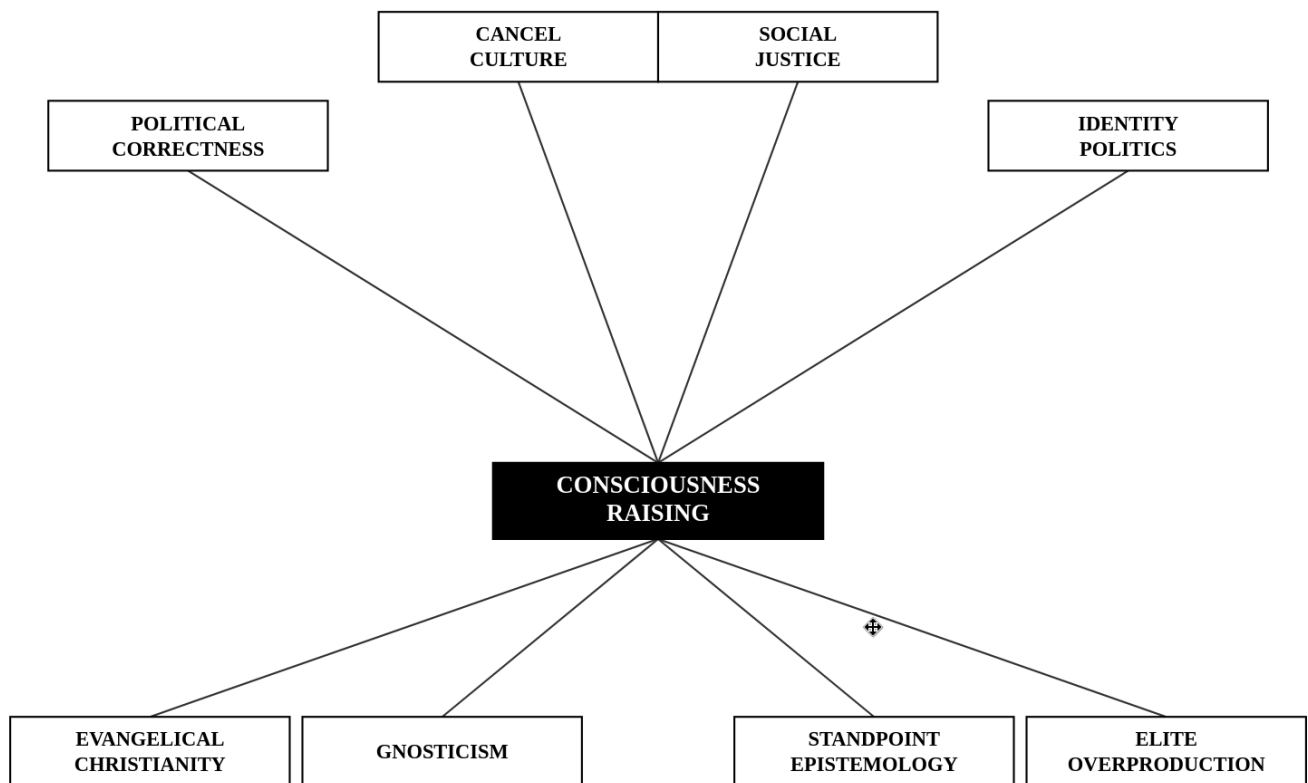
The last thing most progressives think we need is another male writer complaining about “wokeism.” Why not talk about more important things? Wokeness is one of those things that many people *think* they already understand and can recognize when they see it, but if asked to define it, they often struggle to pin down a coherent definition. This lack of clarity often allows defenders of wokeism to dismiss critiques of it as confused moral panics and causes people with different understandings of what wokeism is to talk past each other. Wokeism has become somewhat of a *floating signifier*. It can mean different things to different people, with many people throwing the term around as a pejorative in highly inconsistent ways. However, many people at an intuitive level have a general understanding of what wokeism is and the things associated with it, but don’t have the vocabulary and historical detail to describe it in a way that is consistent or coherent.

For those on the right, wokeness seems to mean anything from political correctness and identity politics all the way to socialism and communism, or quite simply any form of social justice they don’t like. For those on the left, “wokeism” is nothing but a right-wing boogeyman based on conspiracies and moral panics aimed at distracting people from real issues. I too used to hold this opinion. It tends to be the case that those who are most stubbornly opposed to acknowledging that wokeism is, in fact, a problem happen to be the very people who embody that problem most. Often, many people are oblivious to the phenomenon of wokeness because it’s the water they swim in, normalized in their habitat to the point where they don’t see how it makes many people outside that habitat cringe. There are also some who acknowledge that “wokeness” is a real phenomenon but are unclear why it is a problem, likely because they have not experienced or witnessed real-life encounters with it, or because they just see it as an overblown issue. Then there are those on the “anti-woke” left, or the more agnostic post-woke left, who are more likely to take the problem of wokeness seriously and view it as a hindrance to the success of leftist and socialist movements.

Yet even the few people on the left who acknowledge that wokeism is “a problem” rarely define it in a clear and consistent way. Often, those who try to understand phenomena related to “wokeism” refrain from using the word “woke” out of a fear of “conceding to the right,” choosing various alternative terms or distancing themselves by associating it with “liberal” politics. However, not all liberals embody the characteristics commonly associated with wokeism.

Wokeism appears across the political spectrum. Even if the liberal progressive manifestation of wokeism happens to be the most common manifestation of it, there are also far-left variants of wokeism and various right-wing manifestations of it as well. **What unites them isn’t political content but a shared style: the demand that people “awaken” to a particular consciousness before they can participate in political action.** This essay focuses primarily on the liberal-left progressive manifestation of wokeism, as it’s been by far

the most pervasive form of wokeism in liberal-leftist spaces more broadly, and because its capture of progressive movements should be of particular concern to people left-of-center seeking meaningful socio-economic change.



What This Essay Is Not

This essay is not a complaint about equality, equity, inclusion, or any particular egalitarian progressive principles in and of themselves, but a critique of a **political style**. Wokeism is not synonymous with progressivism, and it is not “Marxism.” As I will show in the Part 2 essay, classical Marxism, for all its faults, was not “woke” in the ways that parts of the contemporary left are. The inability of most critics of wokeism to provide a clear and consistent definition has been a major obstacle to understanding the phenomenon, a problem this essay aims to address.

I have always found the muddled language and inconsistent reasoning within discourses on wokeism very frustrating. Although I had long perceived that there was something wrong with the woke approach to politics, many people I encountered would stay in denial about it. After reading numerous books, researching various historical patterns, and connecting a few dots, I realized that wokeism may not be as difficult to define after all. This is precisely what this essay aims to do: to finally pin down the definition of wokeism. This piece defines wokeism and clarifies its mechanism, demonstrating the explanatory power of a precise definition. In Part 2, I trace wokeism’s genealogy: its origins in American evangelical Protestantism and its evolution throughout history into the phenomenon we recognize today.

Throughout this Part 1 essay, I show how wokeism isn’t just a culture-war spectacle, but a highly consequential phenomenon rooted in deep socio-economic transformations that have

radically changed the ways in which class conflict operates, and the expressions of left and right politics. Before elaborating on why I believe my definition of wokeism fills a major gap in the discourse when it comes to understanding wokeism, it is important to first address the elephant in the room when it comes to wokeism, which is that the word “woke” has its origins in Black American communities. However, as you will see, this etymology tells us very little about the broader, actually existing macro-phenomenon that words like “wokeism,” “wokeness,” and “woke” represent.

The Etymology of Wokeism

The word “woke” itself has its origins in Black American communities, typically traced back to Marcus Garvey’s 1923 rallying cry “Wake up Ethiopia! Wake up Africa!” and blues musician Lead Belly’s 1938 warning to “stay woke” about racist violence in the Jim Crow South. By the mid-20th century, “woke” carried dual meanings within the African American community: vigilance against threats from white supremacy and broader awareness of political injustices. In the 21st century, the term was popularized by Erykah Badu’s 2008 song “Master Teacher” and gained significant traction on social media around 2012, becoming closely associated with the Black Lives Matter movement following the shootings of Trayvon Martin and Michael Brown. By 2017, the Oxford English Dictionary formally added “woke,” defining it as “alert to racial or social discrimination and injustice.” Around 2019, the term began being used pejoratively by critics.

But this common historical account doesn’t go far enough. It looks solely at the word itself, not the recurring substantive themes that define the essence of “wokeism” as a phenomenon. Whether wokeism has its origins in radical Black vernacular is beside the point; that tells us little about what “wokeism” as a style of politics is, and how it has evolved.

The etymology does give us a clue: *the emphasis on awakening*. The language of “getting woke” or “waking up” is the common thread, emblematic of a style of politics with very deep roots. The language of “awakening” and “waking people up” is key to understanding the essence of what wokeism is: the preconception that **political and social transformation begins with consciousness transformation**, that the key to changing the world is changing minds, or more precisely, awakening them to the correct understanding of reality.

Defining Wokeism

The key to pinning down a **consistent definition** of wokeism is in the word itself, **woke**. This is the fundamental thread that ties together the tendencies people often associate with wokeism (language policing, callout culture, identity politics, pronounification, virtue signaling and post-materialist politics, etc.). I discuss this in detail in the later section of this essay on “*The Connection Between Wokeism, Political Correctness, and Cancel Culture*.” For now, I will outline the definition of wokeism clearly as follows, because I know many people are too lazy to read full articles and instead use LLMs to summarize.

I define Wokeism as a political mentality that presupposes that *awakening* people to a correct consciousness is the precondition for both political solidarity and

sociopolitical change. At its core, **the woke mode** of thinking assumes that political change requires a mass **awakening** to a morally correct form of **consciousness**, one that is assumed to be the *right way to think*, whereby people “wake up” to this *new sensibility* or demonstrate that they have already been awakened and sufficiently embrace what are deemed to be politically correct positions of the day, according to the dominant discourses and habitat that this breed of woke consciousness emerges from. The fundamental assumption of *woke thinking* is that if enough people become *awakened* to the ideas deemed politically correct, society could radically transform. If people simply *come to their senses*, the world will change accordingly. It is a consciousness-first approach to politics rooted in the belief that thinking the correct thoughts is what drives radical political change.

The *woke consciousness-first approach* reverses the traditional labor movement’s class-first approach to political solidarity and coalition building. Instead of meeting people where they are and forming alliances despite disagreement, the woke approach demands that the public first conform to a set of ideas that the woke people in question have sanctioned as politically *correct* before it will recognize them as allies. Because it assumes that the transformation of minds must precede the transformation of material conditions, wokeism channels most of its energy into **pseudo-political** activity: the cultivation of a politically correct consciousness through language management, cultural production, and the policing of discourse, rather than the building of coalitions based on **shared class interests** and **common goals**. This makes woke movements prone to self-marginalization (what I have elsewhere termed “**self-contained opposition**”) and incapable of doing **real politics**, which, in a *pluralist* society, requires diverse groups to come together and make decisions despite intractable disagreements. This is why there is, inadvertently, an **anti-political** tendency inherent in the woke mentality, which is the ironic tragedy of woke activity, given that woke people often appear to be hyper-political by trying to politicize everything. It is for this reason that woke “politics” tends to be associated more with **social justice activism** and **culture wars** rather than political reformers, let alone revolutionaries.

Instead of building solidarity through shared struggle based on material interests and common goals, the woke approach to politics tries **to change things by first changing people. It focuses on changing the way people think and talk** rather than working with people **as they are**, accepting the inevitability of disagreement, and advancing a politics based on what people have **in common**. This is where wokeism’s reputation for **intolerance** to disagreement stems from. However, even among its less annoying advocates, who genuinely believe in advancing their causes (and might not even see themselves as “woke” in a pejorative sense), you can see how **woke presuppositions** often still shape the ways in which many activists, intellectuals, and media pundits think of political activity. The woke approach to political action is still predicated on getting people to either *convert* to a certain way of thinking and speaking or *conform* to “the cause” by giving it tacit support. The implicit assumption is that once enough “awareness” of the cause is raised and once enough **people think and talk in the proper, politically correct way**, then this **cultural revolution** will somehow manifest into a **political** one.

Those possessed by the woke mentality don't always think these things at an explicit conscious level, but their implicit preconceptions of how political progress ought to come about are reflected in their priorities and tendencies. They say actions speak louder than words, but for the woke people, the most important actions **are words**. Even if some of them say that "praxis" matters more than theory, woke people, in practice, tend to **prioritize consciousness-raising over coalition-building**, while typically **presuming that they already have the correct political ideas** and that the next task is to propagate them to the lay masses.

The way in which the "woke" mind envisions political change is often reflected right in the type of language they use. Those operating under the woke conception of politics often consider the purpose of protests to be something like **raising awareness**. Yet, **this is not at all how the political left used to think of protests**. Back when the political left was centered on class politics, political demands were thought to be achieved through the assertion of *class power*. The basis of class power is the ability to collectively weaponize labor power by *stopping production* and building leverage to force demands upon the state. Of course, in a democracy, a major goal of the political left is to have a government in power that represents working-class interests. If a left-wing government was in power, the way to make sure that they don't betray their promises is to mobilize the collective power that the laboring classes have in the economy. The ultimate source of class power is the ability to shut down production, not to "raise awareness." It is, of course, useful to raise awareness insofar as it brings more people to join the cause (or at least not making people be actively against it); however, this is not the same as the woke fixation on "raising awareness", which is usually rooted in professional-managerial class sensibilities.

The tendency for woke people to **prioritize shared consciousness** (expressed through the performative use of correct language, positions, and the signaling of allegiance to the causes of the day) over mutual class interests or concrete goals is reflected in the highly *ideologized* way they think about politics. Woke people left of center tend to think of politics as primarily an ideological battle between left versus right, in which anything "right-wing" is considered bad, and "moving things to the left" is the primary goal. This consciousness-first logic is reflected in the way that progressive leftists will completely dismiss the idea of working with any people who exhibit "right-wing" beliefs, **even if they have mutual class interests** or could agree on specific political issues (like opposing wars, healthcare). The priorities of woke people are evident when looking at what left-leaning politicians and pundits are most likely to get "cancelled" for. Nobody gets ostracized by the woke left for having disagreements on economic policy, and left-wing politicians (like the Squad) routinely get away with abandoning economic promises (like Medicare for All) or for being cowardly on Israel (Bernie Sanders). Yet when it comes to going against the dominant progressive line on issues of immigration, trans issues, or identity politics, then suddenly the woke vampires are out for blood.

Despite distinguishing themselves as more radical than liberals, woke leftists tend to rally behind liberal progressive politicians, who may exhibit a more *progressive consciousness*

despite conflicting economic agendas, because **woke leftists are more defined by their hatred of conservatives** (who are further away from them at the level of consciousness) than they are by concrete socio-economic goals. This is why a woke leftist is more likely to trust a liberal elite politician or Ivy League professor who signals they are progressive on social issues than they would a working-class conservative. Even when these types of people do recognize the need to appeal to working-class Trump supporters, they tend to imagine it occurring by “turning them left” rather than simply getting them to agree to a set of economic policies while disagreeing on social policies. This makes woke people prone to **ideological gerrymandering** and turns them into pawns of the Democratic Party, as it is easier for the Democrats to pay lip service to what woke people want to hear and use woke language, even if they don’t do anything.

Much of the modern left, which has uncritically absorbed this PMC conception of politics, has forgotten this crucial component of how political power works. It has instead viewed the working class as a passive “mass” that determines its political views depending on how much propaganda it passively absorbs from either political side. Leftists who implicitly hold this view thus think that winning over the working class is simply a question of having better “propaganda” than the right and that the left must counter the propaganda of the right. This is why woke leftists see any single leftist self-criticism and acknowledgement of right-wing critiques of the left as “capitulating to the right,” helping the *enemy*. Since similarity of *political consciousness* matters more than mutual class interests or shared political goals, the woke mind thinks of politics in terms of **friend-enemy distinctions**, but in a post-materialist way, as lines are drawn based on shared political **attitudes** and politically sanctioned **language** rather than mutual economic interests or shared policy goals.

Although the contemporary version of woke politics is most visible in liberal progressive institutions, *the underlying woke mentality* is not exclusive to liberals or leftists. Whenever politics is organized around prior conversion of consciousness, moral purification, and the policing of heresy within the group, it can attach itself to many different moral contents. This essay focuses on the modern progressive manifestation, not because the form is exclusive to the left, but because left-liberal wokeism is the type of wokeism that became most **institutionally dominant**.

This is also a large part of why a significant portion of American society sees Trump's MAGA movement as more “anti-establishment” compared to the liberals and leftists (yes, leftists, not just liberals), who have become associated with out-of-touch cultural **elitism**. Many leftists and liberals still have a hard time wrapping their heads around this phenomenon, but if they understood the **genealogy of wokeism**, they would be better able to make sense of why similar tendencies have been occurring throughout the Western world. The drift of working-class voters to right-wing populists has occurred in elections throughout many countries in the West, and even if they might use different language to articulate it, this realignment is highly related to the **macro phenomenon** of “wokeism.” However, in this essay, I will focus primarily on America because, as I will show in **Part 2** of this essay **trilogy** on the history of wokeism, the phenomenon that millions of people colloquially describe as

wokeism has origins that go far back in American history. But before one can trace the genealogy of wokeism as a style/mode of political thinking (which I will do in detail in the **Part 2** essay, tracing the origins of wokeism to the rise of Evangelical Christianity and “born-again Christians”), it is essential to understand the socio-economic conditions and class dynamics that drive wokeism. This is crucial to understanding who exactly the “woke” people are, where they come from, and why they act as they do.

Who Are the Woke People, and Where Did They Come From?

Rather than solely focusing on wokeism as an ideological phenomenon (e.g., the “woke mind virus”), a materialist lens is crucial to understanding who **exactly the woke** people are and what **environment** they tend to emerge from. In this section, I will unpack how wokeism tends to emerge from a particular stratum of society we can call “symbolic capitalists,” which is directly related to, but not identical with, the professional managerial class. It could be viewed as a distinct subgroup within the broader professional managerial class. It is crucial not to mistake this group as a class in a strict economic sense, but rather a group within the broader social hierarchy that includes many people who want to become **more than an average** worker (top 20% of society). More importantly, in their quest to climb that social hierarchy, those who aspire to become symbolic capitalists undergo a unique form of **socialization**, obtaining the necessary credentials through university and learning to be subjects well-suited for careers in professional-managerial-class industries. While the most important concept that will be explained here is that of the **symbolic capitalists** (a term which I borrow from Musa Al-Gharbi, whose book we will summarize shortly in this essay), I believe it is crucial to first unpack the notion of the **professional managerial class**, which tends to be the more commonly used term to categorize the type of people who exhibit “woke” behaviors.



The Professional Managerial Class and the Symbolic Capitalists

The main propagators of wokeism and the people most likely to exhibit woke thinking are those who are part of (or aspire to be part of) the “Professional Managerial Class” (the PMC). The PMC has been theorized in slightly different, but largely complementary ways in works such as Catherine Liu’s *Virtue Hoarders*, Barbara Ehrenreich’s *Fear of Falling*, **Michael Lind’s *The New Class War***, **Thomas Frank’s *Listen Liberal***, Christopher Lasch’s *The Revolt of the Elites*, and David McKerracher’s *Underground Theory Volume 1*. However, for clarity, the PMC could be defined simply as follows. The **professional** in the professional-managerial class refers to the white-collar component of PMC labor, whereas the **managerial** component refers to the fact that many aspire to become managers of some kind and expect to move up the ladder within the top 20% of the population. The origins of the terms white collar and blue collar have to do with the fact that people in blue-collar manual labor who work with their hands tend to sweat at their workplace, and can’t wear white, whereas those who work in white-collar industries work with their mouths and can afford to wear nicer clothing. The more important thing here is that the distinction between white and blue-collar work is ultimately about the **division between manual and intellectual labor**.

The category of the “PMC” has been subject to a lot of intellectual debate, as it does not exactly constitute a “class” in the clear economic sense because its members are economically heterogeneous, ranging from wealthy elites to precarious workers like adjunct professors, though they are unified by shared cultural values and political behaviors. However, what actually matters most about the PMC is how this stratum of society differs from the rest of society in a sociological sense. The PMC is technically closer to the working

class economically than it is to the capitalist class in the sense that its members earn most of their money from wage labor, rather than from owning the means of production. What distinguishes the PMC from, say, a small business owner, a farmer, and a blue-collar manual laborer is primarily their different socialization, habitat, and proximity to power and social hierarchies. A person who is part of the PMC (or strives for a PMC career) typically has a college degree and aspires to get a white-collar job or a position in *management*, essentially to become *higher status* than blue-collar labor, who has less *prestige* and *social power*.

But aren't students working class? Technically speaking, yes, they often are, especially when they work low-paid jobs and study just to get by. However, students who are workers are a very different type. At universities, students are *socialized* to become *PMC aspirants*, even if they do not become part of the PMC until later. They come to university with the expectation of eventually becoming **something more than ordinary workers**. University students go into debt just to get a college degree, even if it is one with less "practical value," because having any degree does still increase the chances of employment and higher pay than if one had no degree at all.

Furthermore, this sociological difference has become especially significant politically, as holding a [university education has become an even bigger predictor of voting patterns than income has](#), with workers without college degrees and people in blue-collar industries increasingly more likely to vote for right-wing populist parties, while people with a university education in white-collar jobs are more likely to vote for liberal-centrist or center-left parties.

This educational transformation is particularly significant given the massive expansion of higher education. In 1940, only 4.6% of the U.S. adult population had a bachelor's degree or higher. By 2022, that figure increased dramatically to 37.6% of adults aged 25 and over holding a bachelor's degree or more.^[1] This new education divide created very different socializations between college-educated workers aspiring to PMC white-collar professions and workers without college degrees.^[2]

It is not a coincidence that the primary carriers of woke politics tend to come from the PMC. The PMC-educated professionals who manage but don't own capital are perfectly positioned to benefit from consciousness politics. They possess the cultural capital to navigate woke discourse, the institutional positions to enforce it, and the class interest to prefer consciousness change over material redistribution.

However, the PMC is not a monolith, as it includes the STEM (Science, Technology, Engineering, and Math) and FIRE (Financial Independence, Retire Early) industries, in which people do not necessarily exhibit the same kind of clear voting habits or behavioral stereotypes that come to mind when you think of a liberal or a leftist. The primary drivers of wokeism are not the PMC as a whole, but rather a particular substratum adjacent to the professional-managerial world whose **social power comes from producing and managing symbols: academia, media, publishing, arts, entertainment, nonprofits/NGOs, HR, DEI, policy, the credential and narrative industries**. In other words, the sectors that shape what counts as legitimate knowledge, moral status, and respectable speech, whose work is

not mainly the production of physical goods and services, but rather in **the production of information, intelligence, rhetoric, images, narratives, data, interpretations, and norms**. This is the stratum of society most involved in the production and reproduction of discourse, culture, and ideology. These are the “knowledge professionals” who make their living through nonmanual labor focused on the production and manipulation of symbolic data, rhetoric, ideas, and art and entertainment. The type of people we are talking about tends to include academics, university students, journalists, media pundits, and people in general who operate within the white-collar “symbolic economy”, spanning industries such as media, academia, art, entertainment, education, law, public policy, and more. Another recently popularized label for describing this social stratum is the “**MANGO**” **class**, referring to those concentrated in **media**, the **academy**, and **arts**, and **activist** NGOs, that is, the discourse-shaping professional milieus of the symbolic economy from which many of these tendencies tend to emerge. However, my preferred term for describing these people in the symbolic/knowledge economy is Musa Al-Gharbi’s concept of the “symbolic capitalists.”

"A rising intellectual star."—David Brooks, *New York Times*

MUSA AL-GHARBI

WE HAVE

NEVER

BEEEN

WOKKE

**THE CULTURAL CONTRADICTIONS
OF A NEW ELITE**

The Symbolic Capitalists

By far the most sophisticated scholarly work on the socio-economic underpinnings of wokeism comes from **American sociologist Musa Al-Gharbi** in his book *We Have Never Been Woke: The Cultural Contradictions of a New Elite* (2024). Al-Gharbi's book provides a rigorous materialist theory of wokeism, with crucial empirical grounding for understanding when and why the phenomena often associated with "wokeness" erupted. My analysis of wokeism draws heavily from Al-Gharbi's analysis while simultaneously aiming to fill a practical gap in the discourse when it comes to wokeism's definition. In the next few sections, **I will essentially be summarizing some of the most important insights from Al-Gharbi's book**, which will be very useful for contextualizing many of the points I make in this essay, and it makes up the foundation of my understanding of wokeism. As we will see, my theory **builds on** and **complements** Al-Gharbi's research by articulating a *consistent* conceptual definition of wokeism that ties everything together in a way that makes *wokeism* as a style recognizable and distinguishable from other modes of socio-political activity.

Al-Gharbi's core thesis in *We Have Never Been Woke* rests on identifying a new elite class that he terms "symbolic capitalists." Drawing on Pierre Bourdieu's concept of symbolic capital (prestige, honor, recognition, and cultural authority), Al-Gharbi defines **symbolic capitalists** as professionals whose work involves the production and manipulation of data, rhetoric, social perceptions, organizational structures, art, and entertainment. The social categories of the symbolic capitalists and the PMC overlap, and both can be used to describe essentially the same group of people; however, the category of symbolic capitalists is a more specific elite formation that cuts across conventional class lines. This stratum of society includes academics, journalists, consultants, lawyers, tech workers, and those in finance and media. Their power derives not from ownership of the means of production in the traditional Marxist sense, but from their control over the production of meaning, legitimacy, and cultural authority.

Most importantly, as it pertains to this analysis, the tendencies associated with what we call wokeism are most prevalent among this new **Symbolic Capitalist** elite, **and those who aspire to become part of it.** ^[3] Al-Gharbi marshals considerable evidence demonstrating that the Americans most likely to hold "woke" views are not the genuinely marginalized and disadvantaged, but rather highly educated, relatively affluent white liberals. A 2021 poll confirms that the "woke" are most likely to be young college graduates living in cities with household incomes above \$75,000 per year who vote Democrat. ^[4] By 2020, this group "tended to provide more 'woke' responses to racial questions than the average Black or Hispanic person" and "perceived much more racism against minorities than most minorities, themselves, reported experiencing." The irony is striking: those who most loudly proclaim solidarity with the oppressed are themselves among society's winners.

This does not mean symbolic capitalists are cynical manipulators. Al-Gharbi emphasizes that they are often "true believers" in their social justice commitments. However, these sincere beliefs "are rarely translated into behavioral changes or reallocations of material resources." Their political style is fundamentally post-materialist: they prioritize symbols, rhetoric, and cultural recognition over the material, "bread and butter" concerns of working-class people.

This explains the persistent gap between their progressive rhetoric and their actual lifestyles, which remain premised on exploitation (underpaid domestic workers, Amazon warehouse laborers, gig economy drivers) and exclusion (NIMBY housing policies, exclusive private schools, assortative mating patterns that concentrate wealth).

Wokeism Beyond the Professional Managerial Class

While woke discourses tend to be driven by symbolic capitalists and those most likely to support it tend to be mostly among the professional managerial class more broadly, it is crucial to recognize that woke thinking is not confined to that class. While wokeism is highly correlated with one's socio-economic status and the environment in which one was socialized, there are many exceptions. People are not always determined by their environment; they are capable of changing how they act by being more self-critical of their own behaviors and ideologies. Hence, the importance of understanding what exactly "acting woke" means politically: it allows individuals across class positions to recognize this pattern in their own thinking and choose differently.

None of this means that everyone who adopts woke discourse is themselves a symbolic capitalist. Woke sensibilities, discourses, and the latest iterations of culturally progressive social norms are generated and refined within elite institutions, universities, prestige media, HR departments, and the symbolic industries, but they radiate outward through the same channels that distribute all elite culture: social media, entertainment, advertising, and the credentialing pipeline that spreads to people within symbolic capitalist spaces, who either passively absorb it, enthusiastically embrace it, or reluctantly conform to it just to be polite and avoid any unnecessary trouble. A factory worker who defends progressive language norms on Facebook is not a symbolic capitalist; she is a consumer of symbolic capitalist culture, absorbing the moral vocabulary that saturates the information environment. This is why the objection "I am working class and I do not think woke is a problem" misses the point. The question is not whether working-class people can adopt woke consciousness, of course they can, just as working-class people have always adopted the cultural styles of their social betters. The symbolic capitalists are the transmission vector, not the entire audience. They curate, credential, and enforce the discourse; everyone else merely receives it.

Totemic Capital: Victimhood as Status Currency



In tandem with post-materialist politics, another tendency in the Awakening that Musa Al-Gharbi dissects is what he calls “totemic capital.” He uses this term to refer to the phenomenon in woke-captured spaces whereby marginalized identities have become valuable commodities, and leftist language has played a paradoxical role in the status competition among symbolic capitalists looking to mark their territory over increasingly scarce opportunities in symbolic capitalist PMC industries. Totemic capital refers to the epistemic and moral authority afforded to individuals on the basis of bearing a historically marginalized identity (Black, LGBTQ, disabled, female). Possessing such a “totem” grants the bearer moral superiority (perceived as more ethical and worthy of power), epistemic authority (held to possess special knowledge or insight), cultural cachet (perceived as more interesting, exotic, or authentic), and material benefits (access to special funding, hiring initiatives, and mentoring programs).

This creates powerful incentives for elites to acquire these totems, sometimes through fraudulent means. Al-Gharbi documents numerous cases of ethnic fraud: white women posing as Black, Native American, or Latina to advance their careers in academia and activism.^[5] Even elites from minority groups engage in this status game by collapsing distinctions (the multiracial or immigrant-origin child of professionals presenting simply as “Black” to claim underdog status). The system rewards those who can most effectively perform victimhood, which is not the genuinely disadvantaged but rather elite individuals who understand how to narrate adversity in ways that resonate with other elites.

The rise of “victimhood culture” among symbolic capitalists represents a fundamental shift in moral frameworks. Rather than cultures of honor (where status derives from reputation defended through direct confrontation) or dignity (where status is inherent and unaffected by others’ treatment), victimhood culture locates moral authority in suffering. Appeals are made to third parties (HR departments, social media mobs) rather than through direct confrontation. Individuals paint themselves as weak, vulnerable, and damaged to attract

support. Personal slights are tied to historical injustices. This maximizes opportunities for status competition, as every interaction becomes a potential occasion for demonstrating one's victimization and, therefore, one's moral superiority.

Here, wokeism's obsession with subjective experience is also what links it to modern identity politics and vulgarized forms of **standpoint epistemology**. Standpoint epistemology is basically the idea that one's social position grants privileged access to truth about oppression. In its woke form, this often gets flattened into the assumption that the more marginalized one is, the more epistemically authoritative one's perspective becomes, while those deemed privileged are expected to treat their own perceptions as inherently suspect. The result is not serious structural analysis, but a politics of moral deference in which social position substitutes for argument, and consciousness-policing substitutes for democratic persuasion.

The liberal-progressive/new leftist form of wokeism is probably the most well-known form of wokeism that is easiest to discern. This is seen in the obsession with enforcing the latest politically correct terminology through call-out culture, renaming streets, tearing down statues, creating college campus safe spaces, token DEI initiatives, and performative privilege-checking rituals. This kind of progressive wokeism is most notoriously embodied in figures like Robin DiAngelo and Ibram X. Kendi, promoting a vision of racial justice that is almost entirely about personal consciousness. They think that racism is perpetuated by individuals failing to confront their racial biases and that people just need to be taught to "not be racist." It is the white people's "white fragility" that supposedly makes them unwilling to care about the concerns of Black people, not the fact that they are too busy trying to care for themselves and their families. This ignores all the structural and material conditions that reinforce racial inequality. The solution, then, is a series of corporate diversity seminars, self-flagellation, and ritualistic declarations of privilege. All of this is more about personal atonement, the acceptance of politically correct viewpoints, or the performative awareness of systemic problems rather than actual political solutions.

This is the institutionalized form of wokeism that tends to dominate institutions because it accommodates elite aspirations without threatening existing structures. However, wokeism takes hold in both "moderate" liberal spaces and "extreme" radical-left spaces. As much as some leftists like to underplay it, anyone who has spoken to enough leftists knows that wokeism exists in the "real leftist" spaces too, not just "the Libs."



Leftist vs Liberal Wokeism

While leftists are often quick to differentiate themselves from liberals to the general public, these terms are often used interchangeably, and many perceive wokeism to be a broadly left-wing phenomenon. This is because wokeism manifests in similar ways within leftists and liberals. Why? **Because the dominant voices that represent liberals and leftists are cut from the same cloth:** the professional managerial class (PMC), particularly the **symbolic capitalists**, those who work in the symbolic industries described above.

While leftists claim to speak for “the working class” or the most “marginalized,” liberals speak more in terms of “the middle class” and make appeals to social mobility, representation, and the ability for people of marginalized groups to move up the social hierarchy. This difference between liberal and left-wing wokeism is worth mentioning, even though it is often difficult for the average person to discern a “liberal” from a “leftist” because they both exhibit similar woke dispositions. In either case, their own class composition is often reflected in their rhetoric and political solutions, such as the framing of the 99% vs. the top 1%, which conveniently leaves out the rest of the top 20%, which many of them (consciously or unconsciously) want to become part of or already are. This is why wokeism is constantly in tension with the contradictory desires of social climbing and moral righteousness.

The reality that symbolic capitalists are often part of, or **implicitly aspire to be part of**, the top 20% is why the populist right often targets these individuals as part of the “liberal elite,” while the left focuses on billionaires and millionaires. Both populist narratives speak to a rational kernel of truth: one targets the top 1%, while the other applies to a stratum within the top 20%. But “real leftists” are clearly not part of the ‘liberal elite.’ Insofar as “real leftists” exist in significant numbers in the United States, the answer is no. Jimmy Kimmel, Jimmy Fallon, Stephen Colbert, and Hollywood are not out here promoting communism and socialism, at least not in a serious way.

Clearly, then, there is a distinction to be made between liberal and left wokeism, even though they tend to overlap in many ways. So what differentiates left and liberal wokeism? The line can be quite blurry. Part of why the general public often cannot discern the difference is due to the very similar behavioral tendencies and proclivities exhibited by leftists and liberals, and the fact that 9 times out of 10, the leftist is more likely to side with a liberal politician over a conservative one. That is because, sociologically speaking, many voices on the political left are often angry liberals who have been radicalized due to failing to become part of the Professional Managerial Class, so instead they become symbolic capitalists for the left.

Those who make up the **voices of mainstream Liberalism** (in media, academia, and politics) often tend to be those who have **successfully integrated** into the professional managerial class. While not all of them are necessarily “limousine liberals” or globalist elites working at Davos or the World Economic Forum, many are often on the privileged end of the symbolic capitalist stratum, and live a relatively novel cosmopolitan lifestyle that allows them to move fluidly between global cities, travel to various countries, become exposed to different cuisines and cultures, and possess the privilege of higher social mobility than workers without college degrees. Meanwhile, workers without college degrees and people in “lower-skill” blue-collar industries in general have to compete with a large supply of migrant laborers willing to work for cheaper, who will experience their wage as an increase in their relative standard of living while the native-born worker will experience it as stagnation. Liberals and leftists in the symbolic capitalist PMC tend to be very oblivious to such disparities.

The leftist partisan, in contrast to the guilty liberal professional, is usually a temporarily embittered professional who is resentful because of the lack of employment prospects that their university education promised them. The prototypical woke leftist is often someone who goes to university with the expectation of becoming part of the PMC and is either yet to reap the rewards promised by their degree (the students, who make up the shock troops of leftist protests), or is a fallen professional who started off as an elite aspirant aiming to become part of the PMC, yet is struggling due to being laid off or chronically underpaid. While the liberal sensibility is often characterized by *guilt* (often genuine due to their own privilege in the system, and also a performative gesture as a form of social currency), the leftist is often characterized by *resentment*.

Elite Overproduction: The Economics of Wokeism

Perhaps Al-Gharbi’s most important contribution is his theory that the contemporary “Great Awakening” is not a unique event but rather the *fourth* such awakening in the past century.^[6] Each of these cycles, he argues, was driven by the same fundamental mechanism: “**elite overproduction.**” This phenomenon has been studied by social scientists such as Peter Turchin and other theorists who draw on the school of “elite theory.” Elite overproduction occurs when there are more educated elite aspirants than available positions; the resulting socioeconomic insecurity generates intense status competition that manifests as moral crusading.

What Changed Since 2010?



Those who defend against accusations of wokeism often tend to respond by either acting as if nothing changed since 2010 or admitting that something did change, and insisting that these changes are good, and that people who critique them are suspect. In his book, Al-Gharbi provides extensive empirical documentation of the Fourth Awakening's scope and speed. An analysis of millions of news articles shows a major rise in terms related to prejudice (racism, sexism, homophobia, transphobia) starting in the early 2010s. Scholarly databases and Google nGrams reveal a dramatic and simultaneous increase in research on these topics after 2011. Cultural outputs became overtly political, with film and television showing a quadrupled share of nonwhite leads and a doubled share of female leads approaching demographic parity.^[7] The Democratic Party shifted its platform aggressively leftward after 2012, consolidating symbolic capitalists as its core constituency.

The most dramatic shifts occurred among highly educated white liberals, who underwent what can only be described as a mass conversion experience. Polling data shows this group's attitudes on race, gender, and sexuality changed more rapidly and more dramatically than any other demographic. They became, in effect, more "woke" than the minorities they claimed to speak for. The institutional capture was equally swift: universities, corporations, media organizations, and government agencies adopted DEI frameworks, mandatory trainings, and speech codes at unprecedented speed. What Al-Gharbi calls "social justice sinecures" proliferated, creating well-paid bureaucratic jobs in diversity and human resources that served to absorb the overproduced elite.^[8]

This is all just empirical sociological evidence for things many people have already known intuitively for a while. However, the most novel insight in Al-Gharbi's analysis is that this was not the first "great awakening" and the phenomena associated with "wokeism" are older than we think they are. The pattern of elite overproduction leading to spikes in wokeism is not actually new. **Al-Gharbi documents four such "awakening" cycles: the 1920s-1930s, the 1960s-1970s, the late 1980s through mid-1990s, and the post-2010 period.** Each erupted when elite overproduction reached a critical threshold, and each subsided when the

overproduced elites were absorbed into new institutional positions. In what follows, I will provide a brief summary of **the four great Awakenings** that Musa Al-Gharbi identifies in his book, illustrating how consistent this pattern has been, and why the post-2010 period is not as unprecedented as many assume.

The First Awakening (1920s–1930s)



According to Al-Gharbi, the first great “awakening” cycle coincided with the initial consolidation of the symbolic professions themselves. Between 1920 and 1930, the share of Americans with a bachelor’s degree doubled (from 2.3 percent to 4.9 percent), while those possessing a master’s tripled and those with a PhD quadrupled. The share of young adults enrolled in higher education in 1930 was nearly 50 percent higher than at the outset of the previous decade.^[9] During the economic boom of the 1920s, these graduating cohorts were smoothly absorbed into the professional positions that had been set aside for people like them. Then the Great Depression hit. Suddenly, aspiring elites who had felt entitled to secure, respected, and well-paying professional jobs faced deeply uncertain futures, compounded by the looming prospect of conscription as war appeared to be breaking out in Europe again. The anxiety and looming socioeconomic humiliation quickly curdled into rage against the existing order. Students attached themselves to various protest movements: the New Negro movement for civil rights, feminism, Socialist and Communist organizing, early gay rights advocacy, and especially antiwar activism. Yet despite the radical rhetoric, the core demands of these student protesters were largely self-oriented: more financial aid from universities, job guarantees upon graduating, greater campus freedoms, and avoidance of the draft. By the 1932 election, student radicalism had grown so pronounced that large numbers supported the Socialist candidate Norman Thomas over Franklin Roosevelt, whom they dismissed as a liberal establishment candidate. Yet by FDR’s 1936 reelection, the same

constituency had become one of his strongest bases of support. What changed was not their ideology but their material conditions: the New Deal's massive expansion of government bureaucracy, investments in science, and infrastructure programs created precisely the secure professional positions that elite aspirants had been demanding. Once absorbed into these new institutional roles, the "radicals" of the 1930s settled into comfortable professional lives and eventually became the very establishment that the next generation of protesters would rebel against in the 1960s.

It should be noted that, unlike the more recent Awakenings, the symbolic capitalists of the Great Depression era were far more genuinely in solidarity with the working class than their liberal-left counterparts today. The labor movement itself had deep roots stretching back well before Marx was writing, and the radicalism of the 1930s intersected with a living tradition of working-class organization, trade unionism, and socialist politics that was not reducible to elite status competition. **However, the elite aspirants who gravitated to leftist causes during this period of overproduction represented something sociologically distinct from that broader labor movement.** This sociological distinction was visible not only in universities and political circles, but in the symbolic industries themselves.

During the Depression years, a notable current of **Communist** and fellow-traveling sentiment emerged in **Hollywood**, where Communist and Communist-*sympathizing* writers, actors, and directors increasingly treated film as a vehicle for anti-capitalist critique and ideological messaging.^[10] This is significant because it shows that, in America, socialism and communism often found especially fertile ground **among educated cultural producers within the spheres of art, media, and entertainment, rather than among workers themselves.** The Hollywood left was, in this sense, a distinctly symbolic-capitalist phenomenon. And precisely because these actors operated within the industries of cultural production, they were especially **inclined** towards a **consciousness-first conception of politics**, one that placed disproportionate faith in propaganda, narrative, and the remaking of public consciousness rather than in the slower and harder work of organizing workers where they actually were.

The Left Side of the Screen

Communist and Left-Wing
Ideology in Hollywood,
1929–2009

Bob Herzberg



The fact that much radical-left activity in first-world countries took forms that were completely antithetical to Karl Marx's predictions is partly due to the major class transformations in **advanced industrial capitalism during the 20th century**. In advanced industrial capitalist societies like the United States and Britain, where the bureaucratic **managerial revolution**

had already produced a substantial professional stratum, elite overproduction generated a new, particular *form* of radicalism: socialists and communists from **privileged backgrounds** who struggled to sell their radical visions to the very working class they claimed to represent, and from whom they were sociologically quite distant. George Orwell captured this dynamic with characteristic precision in *The Road to Wigan Pier*, writing toward the tail end of the first Great Awakening:

“The first thing that must strike any observer is that Socialism in its developed form is a theory confined entirely to the middle class. The typical Socialist is not, as tremulous old ladies imagine, a ferocious-looking working man with greasy overalls and a raucous voice. He is either a youthful snob-Bolshevik who in five years’ time will have been converted to Roman Catholicism; or, still more typically, a prim little man with a white-collar job, usually a secret teetotaller, and often with vegetarian leanings, with a history of Nonconformity behind him, and, above all, with a social position that he has no intention of forfeiting.... Sometimes I look at a Socialist—the intellectual, tract-writing type of Socialist, with his pullover, his fuzzy hair, and his Marxian quotation—and wonder what the devil his motive really is. It is often difficult to believe that it is love of anybody, especially of the working class, from whom he is of all people the furthest removed.”^[11]

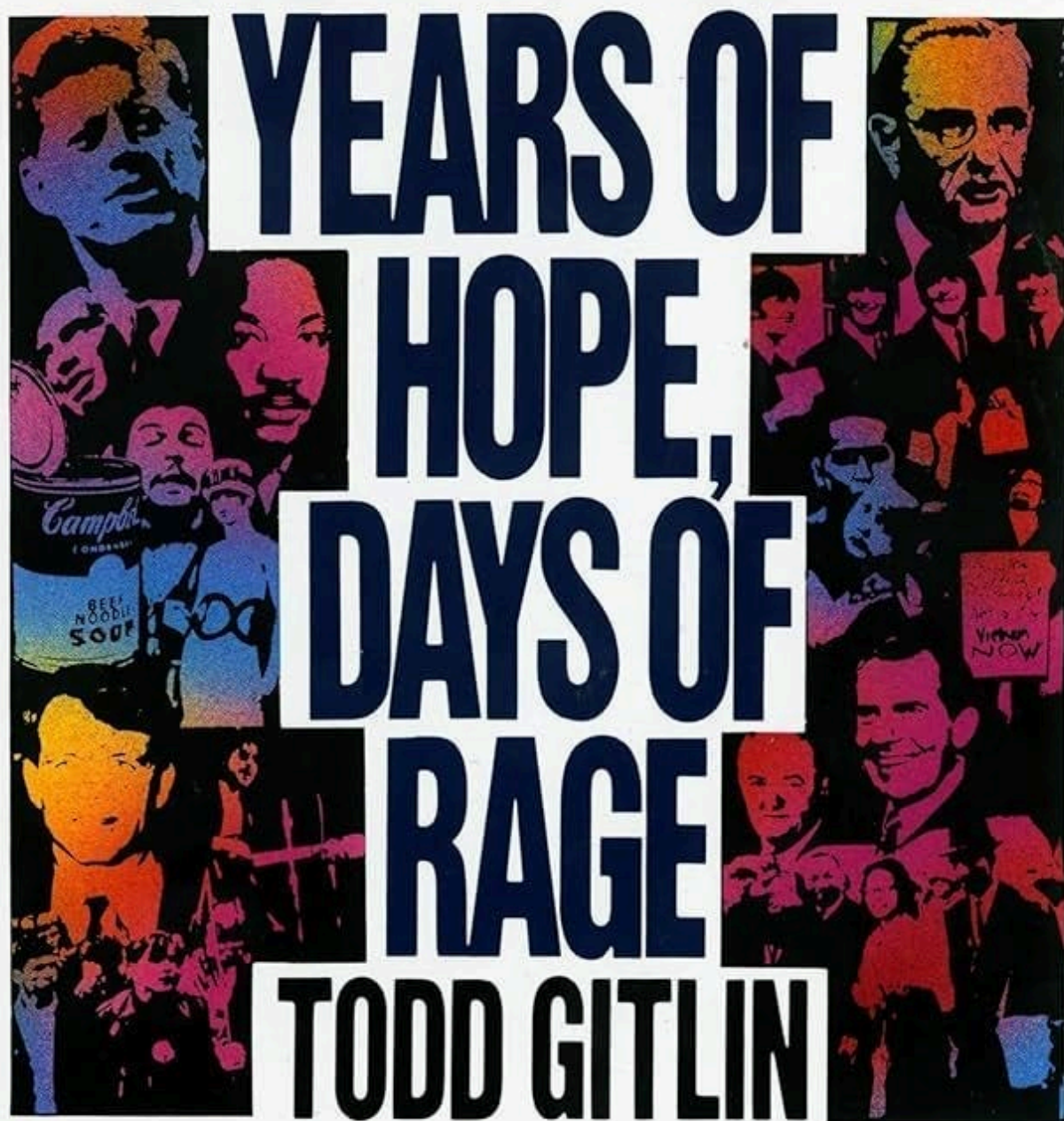
The passage could have been written yesterday about the contemporary liberal-left. Yet the crucial difference is that in Orwell’s time, this middle-class socialism existed alongside, and often in tension with, a **genuine mass labor movement** that had real organizational power in the economy. Today, that broader labor infrastructure has largely been dismantled, which means that when elite overproduction generates a new Awakening, there is no countervailing working-class movement to anchor it in material demands. With the decline of the labor movement, the symbolic capitalists now, in effect, completely dominate the left, and the radicalism they produce is correspondingly more detached from working-class life than it was even in Orwell’s day.

The Second Awakening (1960s–1970s)

THE NATIONAL BESTSELLER

"COMPELLING... AMBITIOUS... IMPORTANT." — *THE NEW YORK TIMES BOOK REVIEW*

THE SIXTIES



REVISED AND WITH A NEW PREFACE BY THE AUTHOR

The second awakening cycle is the one most people think of when they imagine student radicalism, yet Al-Gharbi's account of what actually triggered it challenges the conventional narrative considerably. Through the early 1960s, on-campus student activism was not particularly pronounced. Most students were focused on getting degrees and securing the still-plentiful opportunities of the post-World War II economy. The civil rights movement had been ongoing for years, but it was primarily organized *outside* the campus through sit-ins, freedom rides, and voter registration drives, not through college student mobilization.

What changed everything was a combination of the Vietnam draft expansion and an economic downturn. After the 1964 Gulf of Tonkin Resolution escalated the conflict, monthly draft calls doubled by the end of 1965, but college students remained exempt so long as they were enrolled full-time in good standing. Then the Johnson administration changed the rules: college enrollment would no longer provide an automatic deferral. Students would now have to take the Selective Service Qualification Test, and only those scoring above a particular cutoff would be guaranteed exemption. **It was precisely at this point, when middle-class students' plans to avoid the fighting by enrolling in college began to fall through, that the nationwide student protest movement erupted.** The driver was not the Vietnam War itself, which had been ongoing for half a decade with little student resistance. The driver was not the civil rights movement, which had begun to lose momentum by this time. Rather, the simultaneous draft threat and economic squeeze on professional opportunities (the share of professional-managerial jobs per college graduate had been falling consistently since 1958, and by 1969, salaries had begun declining for degree holders at all levels and across fields)^[12] transformed previously apolitical students into self-proclaimed revolutionaries. As with the first Awakening, the movement subsided once the material pressures eased. Nixon ended conscription, the economy recovered, and by the mid-1970s, polls showed a major drop in the percentage of students interested in politics or activism and a sharp increase in those whose primary goal was securing a good job and a comfortable salary. The "radicals" of the 1960s, just like those of the 1930s, were absorbed into the professional establishment and went on with their careers.

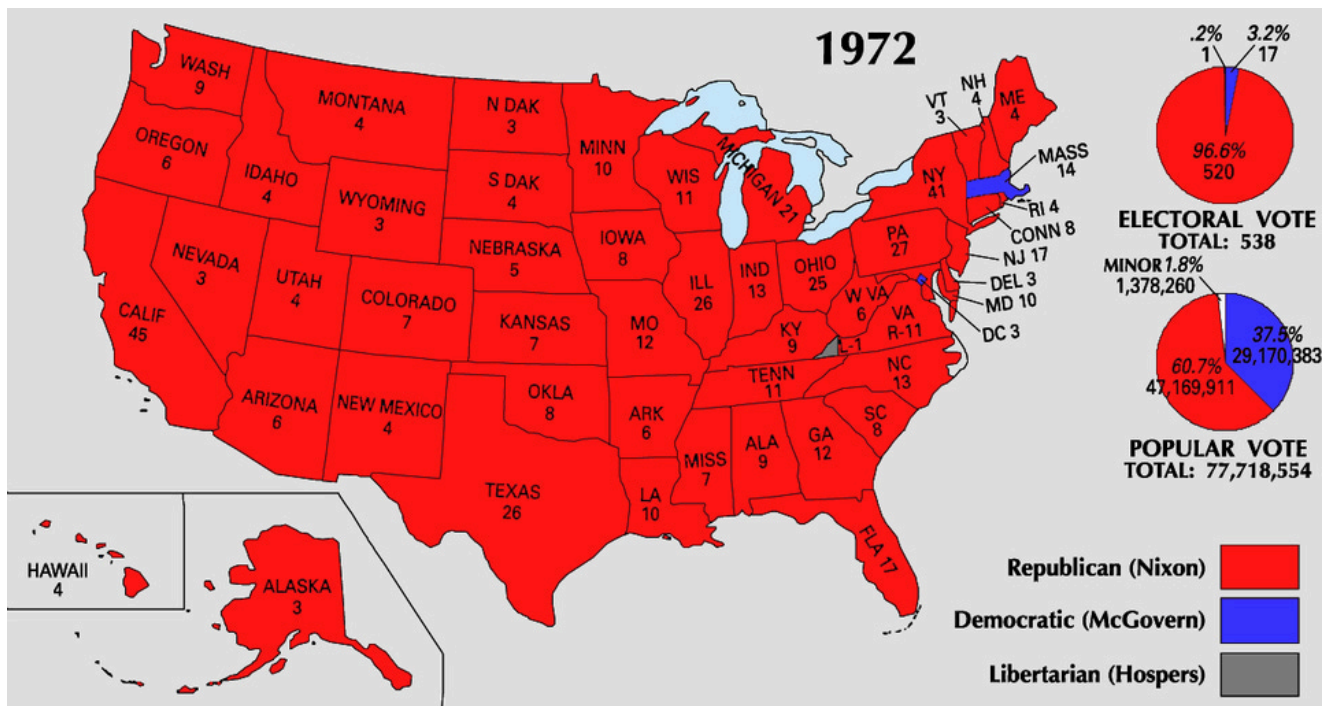
The Civil Rights Movement Was Not "Woke"



A crucial point often obscured by the mythology surrounding the 1960s is that the civil rights movement was fundamentally separate from the elite student radicalism described above. The New Left student movements and 60s counter-culture during this second great awakening are **notto be confused with** the Civil Rights movement. People often make the mistake of retroactively lumping together all these movements together because many of them happened to converge at a certain time; however, the civil rights movement began far earlier. As political scientist Robert Putnam has shown, gains for African Americans began around 1860, before any of the Great Awakenings and indeed before the Civil War itself. After the war, Black progress proceeded steadily through the next century: a consistent closing of gaps between Blacks and whites, a steady increase in rights and protections, significant Black institution-building and political organization, and growing interracial solidarity despite persistent campaigns to halt this progress.^[13] This progress was rooted in the material reality of the labor movement: Black workers organizing within trade unions, the Great Migration bringing millions of African Americans from the stagnant Jim Crow South into northern industrial economies where a growing Black middle class could develop, and the New Negro movement building Black cultural and political institutions from the ground up. It was this long arc of incremental, materially grounded progress, sustained over decades through organized collective action, that eventually crystallized into the landmark achievements of the civil rights era. **Critically, Al-Gharbi demonstrates that the civil rights movement notched most of its major legislative and institutional successes before the Second Great Awakening began.** The movement was not a product of the 1960s student radicalism.

From the mid-1960s through the present, the racial story in America has largely been one of stagnation and decline. Black-white income disparities in 2016 were roughly identical to what they were in 1968. Gaps in wealth and home ownership between Blacks and whites have actually *grown larger* than they were in 1968. Rates of incarceration among African Americans, and racial disparities in incarceration rates, while declining, remain higher than they were in 1960.^[14] As a recent National Bureau of Economic Research paper by economist Erik Hurst and coauthors shows, the growing centrality of the symbolic professions played a central role in halting racial progress. As the significance of the knowledge economy rose dramatically from the late 1960s onward, overt prejudice-based discrimination in most job markets declined, but skill- and education-based discrimination increased dramatically, as did the returns on having the “correct” credentials. Because education was (and continues to be) unevenly distributed, the practical effects of these new “meritocratic” forms of exclusion have been comparable to overt racial discrimination in many respects. **In short, the century from 1860 through 1960 was defined by steady and broad-based gains in racial equality, driven by organized labor and political struggle. Every Awakening since has coincided with the stalling or reversal of that progress, not its acceleration.** This is perhaps the most damning indictment of the consciousness-first approach to politics: the era in which symbolic capitalists have had the most cultural power is precisely the era in which material progress for the groups they claim to champion has ground to a halt.

Wokeism vs The Silent Majority

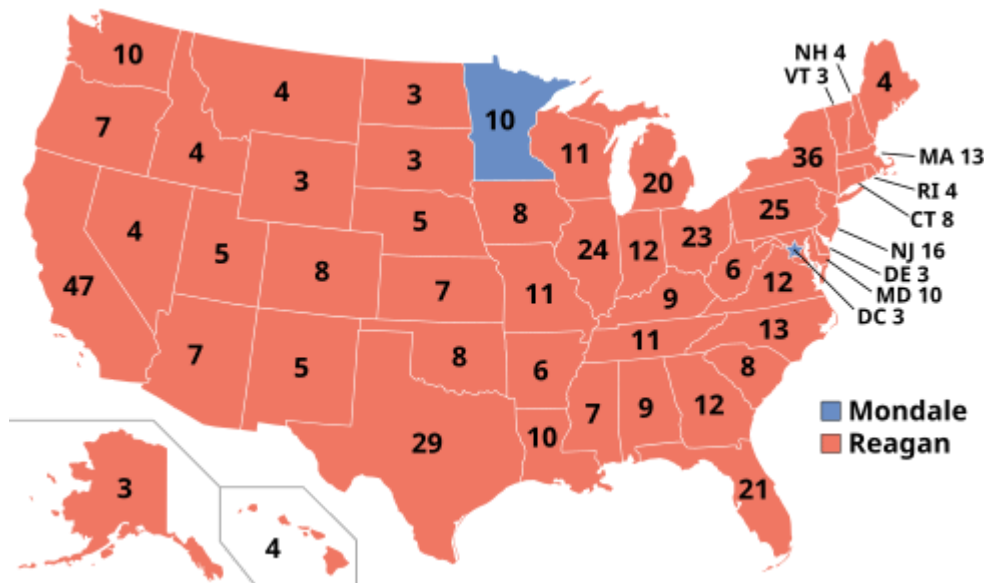


Awakenings often appear larger, more culturally dominant, and more widely supported than the actual distribution of popular opinion warrants. The energy of student movements, the proliferation of protest, the rapid institutional adoption of new language and norms, all of this creates the impression of a society in the midst of genuine mass transformation. Yet this impression is, in large part, an artifact of who controls the mechanisms of cultural production.

Because symbolic capitalists occupy the commanding heights of media, academia, art, and entertainment, the narratives they generate saturate the information environment in ways that systematically crowd out competing perspectives. The result is an echo chamber that mistakes its own volume for a consensus. This lack of self-awareness is also why sustained, coherent criticism of the woke mentality remains so scarce in mainstream discourse, and why the arguments advanced in this essay, alongside those of Musa Al-Gharbi, are still not understood by people in the symbolic capitalist bubble. The apparatus through which such ideas would need to travel to reach broad audiences is largely controlled by the very class whose assumptions are being challenged.

The clearest evidence that these Awakenings do not represent popular majorities lies in the persistent and dramatic disconnect between their cultural visibility and actual electoral outcomes. During the Second Awakening, George McGovern and his campaign believed they could translate the energy of the student movement and the counterculture into a governing coalition. The media attention was enormous; the sense of a generation in revolt, palpable. Yet Richard Nixon defeated McGovern in one of the most lopsided landslides in American presidential history, carrying forty-nine of fifty states and winning over sixty percent of the popular vote. The silent majority had been there all along, largely invisible to the symbolic capitalists who had convinced themselves that the cultural ferment of universities and prestige media represented the direction of the country as a whole.

A strikingly similar dynamic unfolded in France with the May 1968 uprising, which generated such an atmosphere of revolutionary possibility that de Gaulle himself, believing the situation ungovernable, temporarily left the country. The imagery was extraordinary: barricades in Paris, mass strikes, the Fifth Republic appearing to teeter. Yet just weeks later, in the June 1968 legislative elections called in the immediate aftermath of the uprising, de Gaulle's party won a sweeping parliamentary supermajority, one of the largest in French republican history. The working class that the student vanguard claimed to represent had largely declined to follow their lead. What May 68 demonstrated, and what the McGovern campaign confirmed across the Atlantic, is that the intensity of a symbolic capitalist awakening bears little relationship to its depth of popular support. The loudness of the movement is a function of who controls the megaphone, not of how many people are listening. It was precisely this gap between the apparent radicalism of the cultural moment and the underlying conservatism of popular sentiment that gave rise to the concept of the silent majority, the broad mass of ordinary people who do not align with the transgressive politics of the symbolic capitalist class, but who also lack the institutional voice to make their disagreement audible.



Popular reaction to wokeism would manifest in a similar but different way following the **Third Awakening** of the 1980s. Though symbolic capitalists had not yet achieved the institutional consolidation they would reach in later decades, their cultural presence was sufficient to generate another awakening cycle, one that produced its own swift and decisive reaction. Ronald Reagan won his 1984 re-election with a margin comparable to Nixon's, carrying forty-nine states, as working-class and middle-class voters rejected the cultural politics associated with the liberal-left establishment. Still to this day, Reagan's resounding re-election victory is not well understood by liberals and leftists. Many still don't acknowledge that the rise of Reagan and conservatism more broadly was, in part, **a reaction to the excesses of both the late 60s counterculture and a culture-war backlash to the third great Awakening** of the 80s. It was this dual dynamic of **awakening and reaction** (woke overreach followed by populist backlash) that defined the political rhythms of the Third Awakening, a period of history that tends to be underexamined compared to the 60s and 70s.

The Third Awakening and The 80s Culture Wars



The third cycle was, by most measures, the shortest and smallest of the four, lasting only about half the duration of the others. Al-Gharbi suggests this may be because the crisis that elites faced was less severe, and they were appeased more quickly. Nonetheless, the underlying mechanism was identical. Throughout the 1980s, Republican-led austerity gutted university budgets, forcing schools to raise tuition and reduce student aid. Aspiring symbolic capitalists were increasingly forced to go into significant debt just to secure their professional credentials. To stay solvent, universities turned to recruiting international students, who would pay full tuition and who, after graduation, were often willing to accept significantly lower salaries for high-skill work than their American-born competitors, giving employers every incentive to prefer them. Then came a series of economic shocks: the savings and loan crisis (1986–1995), a stock market mini-crash in 1989, and a subsequent recession. Meanwhile, a wave of corporate mergers and restructuring, guided by consulting firms like McKinsey, eliminated enormous numbers of middle-management jobs and other formerly secure positions that aspiring professionals had been counting on. The real earnings of college graduates dropped consistently through the late 1980s, although the divide between

college-educated and non-college-educated workers *grew* because everyone else was faring even worse.^[15]

As with every previous cycle, frustrated symbolic capitalists channeled their economic anxieties into a new wave of radicalism, ostensibly in the name of racial equality, feminism, gay rights, and environmentalism. But what distinguished the Third Awakening culturally was the degree to which it became institutionalized within the academy itself. This was the era of the “postmodern turn” and the “postcolonial turn” in the humanities and social sciences, in which entire disciplines were reorganized around the project of “decolonizing” curricula, deconstructing Western canons, and replacing universalist frameworks with particularist ones rooted in identity and “lived experience.” Critical Race Theory (CRT) emerged during this period out of the Critical Legal Studies movement, as legal scholars attempted to explain why racial inequalities remained so pronounced despite the civil rights victories of the 1960s, and why the country had swung so sharply to the right under Ronald Reagan. Third-wave feminism took shape and the concept of “intersectionality,” coined by Kimberlé Crenshaw in 1989, gained traction, building on the Combahee River Collective’s earlier theory of identity politics, which we will discuss more in Part 2 of the Essay. The debates around “identity politics,” the idea that words can be regarded as a form of violence, speech codes on college campuses, and the policing of “offensive” language all became fixtures of academic and institutional life during this decade. Central to this era was the evolution of the term “**politically correct.**” Political correctness has a revealing history that illuminates its connection to wokeism and the obsession with consciousness-policing.

#1 NATIONAL BESTSELLER

THE CLOSING *of the* AMERICAN MIND

*How Higher Education Has Failed Democracy and
Impoverished the Souls of Today's Students*



WITH A FOREWORD BY SAUL BELLOW AND
A NEW AFTERWORD BY ANDREW FERGUSON

ALLAN BLOOM

An unparalleled reflection on today's intellectual and moral climate...

That rarest of documents, a genuinely profound book "

—The New York Times Book Review

As Al-Gharbi documents, **the phrase “politically correct” originated in U.S. Communist circles in the 1930s.** “At the time, it was used both in a positive way, to denote someone who was genuinely committed to ‘the cause,’ and sometimes in a negative way, to refer to someone who was overly zealous, compliant, or dogmatic.”^[16] The term “politically incorrect” was later adopted by Black Power and New Left movements of the 1960s and 1970s to describe people who were out of step with movement orthodoxy (“problematic” in today’s parlance). In the 1980s, it migrated into feminist circles during the “sex wars” of that era, where one faction used “politically correct” somewhat literally to boast that their politics were correct, while their opponents associated the term with rigidity and closed-mindedness. Over that decade, “political correctness came to be associated with a certain approach to “culturally left” politics more broadly: hailed by advocates as a necessary evolution of the quest for social justice and criticized by its detractors as being needlessly alienating and esoteric, and too focused on symbols over substance.”

The crucial insight here is that the schism over “political correctness” began as an internal dispute within the left itself, between those who saw it as a necessary evolution of social justice politics and those who saw it as needlessly alienating, esoteric, and too focused on symbols over substance. It was only **after this internal leftist dispute** had become visible that the political right seized the term, weaponizing it as a catch-all slur against anything left-of-center. Therefore, the reaction to political correctness didn’t emerge out of nowhere as “moral panic” concocted by the political right. Rather, it was a real tendency that did indeed first emerge on the left, and as more left-wing people began to bring it into mainstream institutions, the reactionary right was on the defensive and capitalized on wokeism’s own contradictions.

Indeed, the right-wing “culture wars” of the late 1980s and 1990s were not spontaneous eruptions of reactionary sentiment. They were, in large part, a **response** to the institutional capture that symbolic capitalists had achieved within academia, media, and the nonprofit sector during the preceding decades. Allan Bloom’s 1987 bestseller *The Closing of the American Mind* crystallized the conservative critique: that the postmodern and relativist turn in the humanities had degraded the intellectual mission of the university, replacing rigorous inquiry with ideological conformity. Christopher Lasch, writing from a heterodox left perspective, would later develop a parallel critique in *The Revolt of the Elites and the Betrayal of Democracy* (1995), arguing that the cosmopolitan professional class had seceded from the common life of the nation, abandoning the democratic culture of the middle and working classes in favor of a self-referential elite moralism. These were not identical arguments, but they converged on the same basic observation: **the symbolic capitalists who dominated the production of culture and knowledge had become deeply alienated from the broader public, and they were using their institutional power to impose a worldview that most ordinary people found foreign, condescending, and disconnected from their material concerns.**

Furthermore, the perception that academia and mainstream media had been captured by liberal and left-wing symbolic capitalists produced a concrete institutional response from the

right. As Al-Gharbi documents, in the aftermath of the Second Awakening, many on the right had already concluded that academia was a lost cause and sought to build an alternative intellectual ecosystem, beginning with think tanks like the Heritage Foundation (1973) and the Cato Institute (1977). In the wake of the Third Awakening, the conviction deepened that a right-aligned intellectual sphere alone was insufficient, and moves were made to establish right-aligned *media*: first through the explosive growth of conservative talk radio, most prominently Rush Limbaugh, whose show became nationally syndicated in 1988 and quickly attracted an audience of millions, and later culminating with the 1996 establishment of Fox News. These institutions were born directly out of the culture wars, and their business model was premised on sowing mistrust in mainstream symbolic capitalist institutions. To the extent that mainstream symbolic capitalists actually did approximate the right-wing caricatures of them during the Third Awakening, they produced and empowered their own gravediggers.^[17]

And yet, as with every preceding cycle, the Third Awakening died out once the material conditions improved. By 1993, incomes for bachelor's degree holders began rising sharply again, while incomes for most others remained stagnant or declined.^[18] As their own fortunes improved, symbolic capitalists' social justice concerns receded into the background. The debates about political correctness faded from the front pages, identity politics retreated to the margins of academic life, and **the Third Awakening died out as this generation eagerly embraced Bill Clinton**, his worldview, and his agenda. But the right-wing media infrastructure that the culture wars had produced, the talk radio ecosystem, Fox News, and the think tank network, did not disappear with the Awakening. It persisted, and it would prove to be waiting and ready when the Fourth Awakening arrived.



Action Precedes Reaction: What Liberals and Leftists Don't Get about Culture Wars

Recognizing this cyclical pattern is important because leftists and progressives tend to make several key analytical errors when looking back at these culture wars and comparing them to the present. The first error is **misunderstanding the conservative backlash**. When right-wing backlash occurs, whether it is the rise of conservative talk radio and Fox News in the 1990s or the MAGA movement today, leftists typically assume it is a reaction against material progress or genuine gains made by marginalized groups. Al-Gharbi demonstrates that this is demonstrably false. These periods of Awakening rarely result in any actual redistribution of wealth or material gains for the truly disadvantaged. The backlash to wokeism is not simply a “reaction against progress.” **It is a reaction against the alienating, militant, and condescending ways that symbolic capitalists attempt to censor and shame anyone who disagrees with the latest iteration of their moral vocabulary.** The conservative who resents being called a bigot for holding the same views that were considered mainstream five years ago is not necessarily defending oppression; he is reacting to an elite moral program that demands ideological conformity while delivering nothing tangible to his life. This does not mean that all conservative backlash is legitimate or that the grievances it channels are always well-directed, but it does mean that dismissing it as mere bigotry or “reaction against progress” fundamentally misdiagnoses the problem. The backlash is, in large part, a predictable response to being lectured and policed by people whose material interests are not aligned with yours and whose “radicalism” evaporates the moment their own career prospects improve.

The most common error leftists make in their understanding of reactionary movements is **ignoring the self-serving, intra-elite nature of woke progressive movements**. Leftists often romanticize these cultural Awakenings as grassroots uprisings of the oppressed, as if the culture wars were fought between the forces of liberation and the forces of reaction. In reality, as the pattern across all four cycles makes clear, these movements are driven overwhelmingly by highly educated, relatively affluent professionals who leverage social justice discourse to compete for status and power within their own elite circles. Anti-woke reactions, even if weaponized by elite conservative businessmen, aren't simply elite attempts to shut down grassroots movements. Reactionary movements capitalize on **pre-existing** animosity that many **ordinary people**, often the furthest thing from elites, have towards the agendas and attitudes of woke symbolic capitalists. Popular waves of reactionary sentiments following awakening cycles can represent a **revolt against the revolt of the elites**, in which the silent majority rejects the cultural agendas of the liberal symbolic capitalist elites at the ballot box.

By fixating on niche, symbolic issues (renaming buildings, policing language, enforcing the latest terminological conventions) woke symbolic capitalists alienate working-class people and ethnic minorities who are more concerned with concrete, material “kitchen sink” issues: wages, housing, healthcare, the cost of living, and whether their children will have better opportunities than they did. **The culture wars are not a battle between the powerful and**

the powerless; they are, in large part, an intra-elite status competition that the rest of the population is forced to endure. Recognizing this does not require dismissing every cause these movements champion, many of which are legitimate. It requires recognizing that the *form* in which those causes are pursued, the consciousness-first, language-policing, heresy-hunting form, is itself a product of elite class dynamics rather than a natural or inevitable expression of the struggle for justice.

The Fourth Awakening (2011-2020s)



Now, before we return to my definition of wokeism **as a mode**, it's crucial that we finish describing the most recent cycle of wokeism that Al-Gharbi outlines in his book, *The Fourth Awakening*, which **deserves immediate attention because it defines the current landscape**. *The Fourth Awakening* (post-2010) follows the same pattern of **elite overproduction**. The 2008 financial crisis produced elite overproduction on a massive scale, and the painfully slow job recoveries that followed only intensified it: between 2000 and 2015, the United States added twenty-two million workers with at least a bachelor's degree, but only about ten million jobs that required a college degree.^[19] The resulting competition for shrinking opportunities ignited the fourth cycle. Crucially, Al-Gharbi demonstrates that this awakening began *before* Trayvon Martin, before [#MeToo](#), before Trump. He pinpoints the origin to September 2011 with the Occupy Wall Street movement, which, contrary to popular mythology, was never a working-class movement. Seventy-six percent of participants had a bachelor's degree or higher, and a majority of the rest were enrolled in college.^[20] According to this view, although it spoke in the name of the working class, Occupy Wall Street was a movement driven by elite aspirants of the top 20% rebelling against the top 1%, who they saw as responsible for the lost professional opportunities they

were promised. Later, as the economy slowly recovered but with not enough jobs to fill a generation of people who expected far more out of their degree, symbolic capitalists gradually shifted their focus from Wall Street to identity politics, but the underlying class dynamics remained unchanged.

The Missing Piece: What My Theory Adds

Al-Gharbi's materialist analysis brilliantly explains *when* Awakenings occur (during periods of elite overproduction), *why* they occur (status competition among symbolic capitalists), and *who* participates in them (highly educated, relatively affluent professionals). He demonstrates that the contemporary Great Awakening was driven not by moral progress or technological change, but by the material conditions of elite oversupply following the 2008 financial crisis. This is an essential foundation for any serious critique of wokeism.

Al-Gharbi identifies “post-materialist politics” and the obsession with changing symbols and culture rather than material change as a core characteristic of wokeism, which overlaps quite well with my definition. However, Al-Gharbi explicitly refrains from giving a single, straight definition of what wokeism actually *is*. This is not a fault in his analysis; it is a deliberate methodological choice. He demonstrates that we can still measure the tendencies of wokeism and the factors that drive them without distilling the phenomenon of wokeism to a fixed **essence**. He points out that fixed definitions can be a rhetorical trap that can prompt critics to myopically look for any contradictions in the definition to discredit the entire theory. This is an important point, as there are plenty of terms, such as “love” and “justice,” that are notoriously hard to define consistently, yet no one would seriously claim that these words are “meaningless.”

While Al-Gharbi's decision not to provide a clear-cut definition of wokeism's essence makes sense and is intellectually defensible, it nonetheless leaves crucial questions unanswered that may carry significant practical importance in helping people understand and identify wokeism in everyday life. If someone accepts Al-Gharbi's entire analysis and then asks, “But what exactly defines the woke mentality? What makes certain forms of socio-political activity woke? Why do some left-wing people often get described as woke while others do not? How would I recognize wokeness when I see it? How do I stop *acting woke*?” Many people who can *perceive* the phenomenon of wokeism at an intuitive level often *can't put their finger on it* and thus can't explain it to those who are too oblivious or too stubborn to recognize the problem. This practical clarity is precisely the gap that I believe still needs to be filled.

My essay provides **the missing piece**: a concrete definition of wokeism that we can give whenever someone questions what wokeism even means and asks you to define what you are critiquing. Dismissing critics of wokeism for not consistently defining what wokeism *is* has been an all-too-common tactic that people (often woke people themselves) deploy to avoid engaging with the substance of the critique. If critics cannot provide a clear, consistent definition of what it means to **act woke** and what **distinguishes wokeism from other forms of political activity**, they appear to be attacking a phantom.

To reiterate the definition once again: **Wokeism is a consciousness-first approach to political activity that presupposes that the *awakening* of a correct consciousness is the prerequisite for political solidarity and that changing social attitudes (by changing culture) is the prerequisite for political change.** This definition explains not only the liberal-progressive variant that Al-Gharbi analyzes, but also right-wing forms of woke politics and the presence of woke dynamics even among self-identified “class-conscious” Marxists. The *form* of woke politics (consciousness-first, awakening-dependent) travels independently of its *content*. Furthermore, in Part 2, I will sketch out a historical *genealogy* of wokeism as a phenomenon, tracing its origins back to the rise of American Evangelism and showing that it is a tendency not exclusive to the left or the right. But first, I want to demonstrate the practical explanatory value of this definition of wokeism in elucidating some of the most common tendencies that often come up when people discuss wokeism and what ties them all together.

The Connection Between Wokeism, Political Correctness, and Cancel Culture

I believe my definition of wokeism accurately captures the common denominator that ties together phenomena of cancel culture, political correctness, and identity politics. These things are often treated like separate issues, with some people taking issue with one of these things but not the others; however, many people can intuitively tell that these things are somehow interconnected but can’t articulate how. This is where my definition of wokeism (a consciousness-first approach to political activity that prioritizes ***shared sensibilities*** as the prerequisite for political alliances rather than mutual class interests and shared policy goals) comes in handy.

Wokeism treats political activity as an effort to “change minds” and suppress “bad ideas” rather than to form alliances based on shared interests. If enough people adopt the “correct” views, then justice, equity, and fairness will naturally follow. Of course, this is not how history works. This is why wokeism *inevitably leads to the policing of language and ideas*. If you believe that the key to liberation is ensuring everyone has the *right* consciousness, then the logical next step is to control what people *think* and say. This explains why wokeism manifests in speech codes, cancel culture, and the obsession with rooting out heretics: the lack of people who possess a certain notion of a “correct consciousness,” or the deviation from that prescribed consciousness within the in-group, is seen as the main barrier to the actualization of justice. What connects political correctness, cancel culture, and call-out culture is that they’re all manifestations of consciousness-policing.

Wokeism is an anti-democratic current that wants to re-create the demos in its own image. At its core, woke politics is bent on ideological conformity, but because it’s impossible to get everyone to actually agree, the best it can achieve is getting enough people to pretend they agree by enforcing *politically correct* speech codes. Because wokeism is fundamentally centered around consciousness and hostile to disagreement, when it fails to win enough voluntary converts to its worldview, it retreats from mass politics and obsesses over

enforcing politically correct language codes. Political correctness is the linguistic dimension of consciousness policing. If you believe that awakening to the right consciousness is the prerequisite for political solidarity, then language becomes crucial, not just as a means of communication but as evidence of one's awakened state. The obsession with terminology, with constantly updating the "correct" words to use, makes perfect sense within this framework. Language doesn't just describe reality; it shapes consciousness. Therefore, controlling language becomes a means of controlling thought, and controlling thought becomes a means of achieving political change.

NATIONAL BESTSELLER

The
**CULTURE OF
NARCISSISM**

American Life
in An Age
of Diminishing
Expectations

Christopher Lasch

Woke politics is powered by a simple premise: society changes only after people “wake up” into the correct consciousness. History becomes a seminar. Politics becomes pedagogy, and in the case of most woke politics, it is pedagogy on behalf of “the oppressed” rather than any kind of concrete working-class movement with concrete goals. If enough minds can be purified, the world will follow. This is where a distinctly narcissistic temptation creeps in, not narcissism as a clinical disorder, but narcissism as a political posture. A woke person with this posture thinks: the main problem is that the world does not conform to my moral worldview, my understanding of reality, my interpretation of harm, and therefore the central task of justice is to “re-educate” everyone and change the social atmosphere until it does. In older democratic politics, you fought opponents over wages, laws, and power. With the woke style, you end up fighting the public itself, people’s common sense, their “problematic” jokes, their “socially conditioned” patriarchal white heteronormative intuitions, etc. They end up wanting to “kill all normies” as Angela Nagle described it in her book of the same title back in 2017, shortly before she got doxxed, harassed, and canceled from the left for her *leftist case against open borders* (2018).

Another reason why there is an inherently narcissistic dimension to wokeism is that a huge portion of contemporary social justice discourse interprets conflict through the lens of *stigmatization*. If people are suffering, the primary explanation is that they are being invalidated, misrecognized, or symbolically harmed by norms and language. The cure is therefore not only legal equality or material security, but a total renovation of the moral environment: new speech rules, new educational scripts, new rituals of public affirmation. Disagreement is no longer treated as disagreement. It is treated as a pathology. It becomes “phobia,” “violence,” or “harm.”

Notice what happens here. Tolerance is demoted. Acceptance is demanded. In liberal life, you do not have to accept your neighbor’s metaphysics to coexist with them. You only have to respect their rights. Conservatives and liberals do not accept each other’s moral universes, but they tolerate each other as fellow citizens. Yet the woke moral style often treats mere tolerance as insufficient, even suspect. It wants the dissenters not merely restrained, but converted. The goal is not peaceful coexistence under shared rules. The goal is a world in which the rules themselves become a machine for producing the correct inner sentiments.

This helps explain the obsession with symbols and status rituals. Awards, representation, language policing, mandated trainings, public confessions, the performance of “allyship,” the staging of moral innocence. These are not sideshows. They are what “consciousness-first politics” looks like when it becomes institutionalized. It is easier to engineer recognition than to build coalitions. It is easier to manage symbols than to redistribute power. And it is easier to treat dissent as moral deficiency than to negotiate with it. The deeper irony is that this style of politics is often sold as compassion, while it smuggles in a kind of moral solipsism. It asks the public to treat one framework as unquestionable, one vocabulary as mandatory, one interpretation of reality as the price of entry into decency. That is not persuasion. It is *catechesis*.

Typical Examples of Wokeism

One of the more obvious examples of woke discourse that many people are familiar with is the **pronounification of gender**, the attempt to make a particular metaphysics of gender not merely tolerated, but publicly enacted through compulsory linguistic ritual. For a long time, many people were willing to treat sexuality and even unusual gender expression as matters of private liberty: live how you want, do not be harassed, equality under the law, etc.

Pronoun discourse shifts the terrain. It asks the public not only to leave people alone, but **to speak as if contested ideological frameworks and theories of gender are already settled**, and to treat noncompliance as moral injury. In practice, this expands into a whole ecosystem of “inclusive language,” from normalizing phrases like “assigned at birth,” to institutional templates that pressure people to announce pronouns, to the deliberate replacement of ordinary words like “mother” or “woman” with bureaucratic abstractions like “birthing person” or “people with uteruses.” Whether one agrees with these innovations or not, they illustrate the woke impulse perfectly: political progress is imagined **primarily as a mass re-education of common sense**, carried out through language management, HR policy, and symbolic compliance, rather than persuasion and democratic bargaining.

This is also why the pronoun issue became such a flashpoint. Woke discourse increasingly treats tolerance as insufficient, and pushes toward mandatory affirmation, enforced through stigma terms like “phobia,” which often come to mean not hatred or mistreatment, but dissent from the approved vocabulary. The result is predictable. A politics that might have remained a straightforward question of civil rights becomes a struggle over compelled speech, institutional policing, and the remaking of everyday language. It spreads fastest in precisely the spaces most saturated with symbolic power, universities, media, nonprofits, white-collar workplaces, where changing language is easier than changing material reality, and where moral status is accumulated through visible performance. People are free to advocate these norms in a liberal society, and people are equally free to resist them, but once the demand becomes “you must say the words, and you must mean them,” backlash is no longer mysterious. It is the foreseeable reaction to a politics that tries to engineer belief through linguistic compliance, then acts shocked when “normies” refuse to convert.

Are Identity Politics Always Woke?

Before anyone hits me with the “class reductionist” charge, let me be clear. I am not saying race, sex, gender, or “cultural” issues are unimportant, and I am not saying that all expressions of identity politics are inherently woke. None of what I am saying denies the reality of racial injustice, and none of it implies that any politics dealing with race, gender, or anything outside of class politics is automatically “woke.” What matters is the approach. As I argue in greater detail in Part 2, the Civil Rights Movement, at its core, was not a woke phenomenon, precisely because it was oriented toward concrete political goals and concrete institutional victories, desegregation, integration, anti-discrimination law, equal political rights, and enforcement through the state. It was not premised on the fantasy that you can eliminate racism by converting every individual soul into a non-racist overnight. Its goal was

to end discrimination through law and power, not to perfect the inner moral state of the entire population. It also intersected with class dynamics and institutional capacity, including the way New Deal era changes and the emergence of a Black middle-class cadre helped create the leverage required to impose demands on the state. In other words, it treated **racism** as a *political* and structural problem, which would wither away gradually through changes in social relations between blacks and whites, not as an ideological sin to be cured through socially engineering the minds of the masses.

The same distinction applies to **gender politics**. **Feminism** is not inherently woke, and women's issues are not inherently *consciousness politics*. The first-wave struggles for basic legal rights, and later battles over equal citizenship, workplace access, divorce, and reproductive rights, were political fights over power and policy. Even when feminists used structural language like *patriarchy*, the practical orientation, at its best, was toward changing material arrangements and institutional relations, not simply hunting down bad attitudes. You can disagree with particular demands or outcomes, but the form of politics is recognizably political. It is about winning rights, securing protections, and altering conditions that shape dependence and vulnerability. That is categorically different from a politics that treats misogyny as the master key, then makes the eradication of *sexist attitudes* the primary battlefield, with *culture* as the main terrain and *discourse* as the main weapon.

This distinction becomes especially clear in the discourse surrounding **Indigenous politics** in North America, especially Canada. Just like how in the United States the people most obsessed with “deconstructing whiteness” and “abolishing the police” during BLM were usually privileged white upper-middle class students, it is typical to find white activist types in Canada with a peculiar fetishization of Indigenous issues, shouting [#Landback](#), calling other white people settlers, and posturing about how Canada and the US are illegitimate countries because they are founded on “stolen land.” When it comes to these sorts of issues, the lighter, liberal form of wokeism tends to manifest in the form of white guilt, privilege checking, and obsession with land acknowledgements. Whereas the more “radical” leftist manifestation of wokeism often comes in the form of calls for “decolonization” and a flirtation with third worldism, a pseudo-radicalism defined less by constructive political goals and more by hatred of “the West” and a fetishization of anti-colonial struggles abroad.

Here too, the difference between a political approach to these issues worth taking seriously versus a woke one does not lie in whether Indigenous issues are acknowledged as real, but in how they are approached and what is prioritized. In its woke form, Indigenous politics is often reduced to symbolic gestures and moral signaling: land acknowledgments treated as political substitutes, the renaming of streets and institutions, ritualized declarations of Canada as a “settler colonial” state, and abstract calls to “decolonize” that remain largely detached from concrete political strategy. These practices create the appearance of radicalism while leaving the underlying material conditions of Indigenous communities largely untouched.

A **materialist approach**, by contrast, begins from the concrete realities that actually structure Indigenous life: persistent lack of clean drinking water, inadequate housing and

infrastructure, limited access to healthcare, and the absence of genuine sovereignty over land and local governance, including meaningful consent when development projects are imposed on territories where Indigenous people already live. **What distinguishes the woke mode of politics is not that it is merely co-opted by elites after the fact, but that it is structurally predisposed toward symbolic politics from the outset.** Because it is driven primarily by professional-managerial actors whose political engagement is oriented around moral performance and symbolic capital, it predictably elevates semiotic victories over the slow, conflictual work of winning material gains. In doing so, it treats correct consciousness as a prerequisite for political solidarity rather than as a possible outcome of collective struggle. The result is a politics that fragments potential coalitions, substitutes moral purity for strategy, and ultimately undermines the very material demands it claims to advance.

This is where you can see how movements with legitimate goals can drift into a woke mode once the emphasis shifts from structures to symbol. The focus often moves from legislation to *language, representation*, and the purification of *discourse* in media, education, workplaces, and everyday speech. That is when “liberation” starts looking less like building coalitions to win institutional change, and more like an endless project of *consciousness management*. The results are predictable. People learn the speech codes, they perform compliance, and resentment accumulates, especially when all of the virtue signaling and symbolic victories do virtually nothing to address the declining standard of the ordinary working majority.

Was Woke “Co-opted”? The “Elite Capture” Excuse

It is a popular argument among progressives that identity politics and phrases like “stay woke” went from originally being an authentic form of “grassroots radical politics” to being “co-opted” by corporations and liberal politicians. The kind of people who make this argument blame the failure of woke identity politics on the “elite capture” of what could have ostensibly been radical emancipatory movements had they not been “co-opted” by liberal capitalists who dilute “the cause” to symbolic token gestures. These critiques of “co-optation” tend to be shallow because they do not grapple with the problems of the **woke mode of politics** itself and the reality that these “awakenings,” including the “radical leftist” manifestations (not just the “liberal” kind), **were already driven by elite overproduction**, before they were “co-opted.” The hard pill to swallow is that woke progressive identity movements were always **already captured by elites to begin with**, that is, disgruntled PMC symbolic capitalist elites and elite aspirants. It is a mistake to think that there ever existed a “real movement” of radical identity politics from the ground up that could have “succeeded” if only it hadn’t been captured by elites at the top. It is equally delusional for leftists to think that they can help resurrect this imagined “real movement” by distancing whatever they deem to be “real leftism” from status quo-liberalism. In reality, these socio-cultural movements undermine themselves *politically* due to being based in a **woke mode** driven by a stratum of symbolic capitalists whose interests and socialization naturally orient them towards this kind of politics. A consciousness-first politics, driven by people trained to work in the knowledge

economy whose careers are centered on the distribution of symbols and discourse, easily lends itself to performance-based politics over real material change.

Wokeism's Anti-Political Character

Woke politics tends to focus on **changing culture** rather than changing material conditions because the pioneers of woke politics tend to be the “cultural elites” whose careers involve the production of *discourse* and text-based and/or visual media. This is why Musa Al-Gharbi's concept of the “symbolic capitalists” is so useful. This group of symbolic capitalists, whose careers are dependent on the funding of actual capitalists and/or the state, control the commanding heights of cultural production, universities, media, HR departments, nonprofits, but lacks the power to significantly transform economic relations, unlike big capitalists and the full-time laborers who do physical work. Thus, it should not be a surprise that symbolic capitalists are disproportionately drawn to symbolic solutions. They tend to imagine that changing language and representation is the same thing as changing the world, because in their own domain, language and representation *are* power. They police speech because speech is their terrain. They moralize discourse because moralized discourse is how status is allocated in their milieu. They believe that **changing the way we talk about things** will lead to changes in the way we do things, because their jobs literally revolve around making “the way we talk” a lever of control. The problem is that this produces a politics that can win cultural compliance without delivering material change. It can force people to speak correctly without giving them higher wages, cheaper rent, union power, or any institutional capacity at all. And when symbolic victories substitute for structural ones, you get the exact backlash pattern we keep seeing: outward conformity, inner resentment, and an eventual revolt against the people perceived as enforcing the codes.

But **changing how people talk does not automatically change how people live**, and it certainly does not automatically build the durable coalitions required to win power. Backlash emerges not necessarily as backlash against progress as such, but rather against an elite moral program that demands ideological conformity while delivering little tangible improvement. Even for marginalized groups that progressive identity politics are supposed to benefit, woke “politics” rarely manifests in successful political change, because **real politics** would have to involve coalitions of different groups coming together to make decisions **despite disagreement**, rather than form a consensus by converting everyone to “the right way” of thinking. To be clear, this is not a claim that woke people believe every last individual must be converted before progress is possible; no serious person holds such a literal position. The argument is rather that they operate as though consciousness conformity must reach some sufficient threshold before political solidarity can be forged, a presupposition that is betrayed by their persistent prioritization of discourse management over the kind of broad coalition building that durable political change actually requires. For this reason, it is no coincidence that this sort of woke politicking tends to be associated more with the term *social justice* than with radical *politics*.

From Hyperpolarization to Depoliticization

Wokeism tends toward depoliticization despite appearing hyperpolitical. At its core, wokeism is an anti-political worldview. Politics, in its true sense, is about the *polis*, the political community one is a citizen of, and in a liberal society in which who governs the polis is determined by elections, one must work with the *demos*, which will always be marked by a significant degree of pluralism and contradiction. But wokeism reduces politics to a matter of thought and belief, of who is pure and who is impure, rather than who holds power and how that power can be contested.

Sheldon Wolin's distinction between politics and the political helps make this precise. Politics, in his account, is the ceaseless contestation among organized and unequal powers over access to public resources, the normal churn of institutions, parties, and managed conflict. The political, by contrast, is episodic and rare: it is the moment when a plural demos, composed of different classes, cultures, interests, and temperaments, nonetheless produces a lived experience of commonality, a shared public world in which collective power is used for the general well-being. That is what makes wokeism anti-political in the deepest sense. It breaks the preconditions of commonality by converting disagreement into moral pathology and by making belonging conditional on an approved consciousness. In this sense, wokeism is not "too political." It is politics without the political, a permanent frenzy of contestation that cannot generate a common world.

Seen through this lens, wokeism is **anti-political** not because it lacks intensity, but because it lacks the capacity for commonality. This is why wokeism so often becomes self-marginalizing: it does not seek to act with the polis as it is, but to bypass politics by trying to recreate the demos in its image. Instead of building politics based on what people have in common, **wokeism treats commonality as an obstacle**, seen in the constant contempt for "heteronormativity" and the obsession with transgressing norms, taboos, and customs. Wokeism is about cultivating or enforcing uniformity rather than finding commonality that already exists. When there is a failure to come together to make decisions based on common goals in spite of intractable disagreements, the remaining form of action often becomes what my late intellectual mentor Asad Haider called "**dismissal**". Dismissal is the depoliticizing process whereby politics implodes into moralized ejection, denouncing, ostracizing, stripping status, pressuring employers, and forcing resignations as a substitute for building power in the polis.^[21] Therefore, wokeism is self-marginalizing and culturally maximalist but politically suicidal. It can reshape norms, language, and status hierarchies faster than it can win durable institutional or material victories. Dismissal is what politics looks like after the political has died: a public world cannot be built across differences, so the only remaining form of collective action is the policing of membership and the removal of impure actors. The fixation on ideological purity serves a specific function within systems of power: it transforms political struggle into a moral crusade, effectively neutralizing any threat to existing material arrangements. This is the paradox of woke politics. Those who espouse it sometimes do so opportunistically, out of fear, or out of a genuine belief that they are part of a great awakening.

Even in its most radical manifestations, woke politics usually amounts to **self-contained opposition**. It dismisses and excludes people who don't have the "correct ideas" either because they have not yet been "awakened," are unwilling to accept them, or are rendered incapable of understanding them due to their different "lived experiences" or backgrounds. The particularist anti-solidaristic nature of woke politics renders it incapable of becoming successful mass politics because appealing to a mass of people requires navigating a plurality of different viewpoints. Instead of mass politics led by big-tent organizations, the woke method leads to swarms of individual micro-groups segregated into safe spaces.

This is why wokeism, despite its fanatically hyper-political posturing, ultimately **retreats from politics** by trying to change the world by changing the culture of society without building coalitions and trying to win people over first. Many people on the left are still caught in a highly right-wing "friend-enemy" conception of politics, whereas a more deliberative understanding of politics would be the coming together of diverse groups within the polis to negotiate shared interests and agree on a **decision in spite of irreconcilable disagreements**. Wokeism fails on both counts. Its intolerance of ideological diversity makes it incapable of the strategic alliances and coalitional work that even anti-establishment mass politics requires.

Now that the fundamentals of the theory of wokeism are established (the definition of wokeism, who the woke people are, the socio-economic conditions that drive wokeism, etc.), the Part 2 essay will be a bit more historical, tracing the genealogy of wokeism as far back as **the First and Second Great Awakenings (1730s and 1740s, 1790 to the 1840s)**, and how the woke mode later evolved into the modern "progressive" form of wokeism many recognize today. In doing so, we will look at the following questions: why does wokeism appear to be particularly so much more intense in America than in other places? The answer, as Part 2 will show, lies not in Marxism, not in postmodernism, and not in any foreign import, but in one of the oldest and most deeply rooted American traditions there is: **Protestant Christianity**. That genealogy is the subject of **Part 2** in this essay trilogy.

Part 2 - The Evangelical Origins of Wokeness

A Recap of Part 1 & My Theory of Wokeism

This essay traces the historical genealogy of wokeism, the consciousness-first political style that has become one of the most contentious and poorly understood phenomena in contemporary politics. In the [Part one essay](#), I established the definition: wokeism is a style of politics that presupposes that the awakening of a correct consciousness is the prerequisite for political solidarity and political action. Wokeism tends to manifest most in liberal-leftist politics these days, but it is not exclusive to it, and not all leftists are "woke." It is a mode of political thinking rather than a coherent ideological doctrine, and the **woke mentality** is not defined by any inherent ideological content, whether progressive or conservative.

The core component of wokeism is a particular disposition and approach to going about politics. “Woke” approaches to political thinking, activism, and social change operate under the assumption that people must **wake up** to what is deemed to be the politically correct views at a particular time for social justice to be actualized. This is why they are so obsessed with cultural hegemony, propaganda, ideology, and discourse, because the woke people tend to be convinced that people **not thinking the right way or using the right language is the core barrier to the change they want to see. Rather than building movements by meeting people halfway where they are at, the woke mentality assumes that people must be re-educated and awakened to conform to a set of correct ideas.** Wokeism envisions political change as a process of consciousness raising: a *cultural* revolution that later manifests into a political one. It prioritizes shared consciousness and etiquette over shared class interests, and presupposes that mass awakening to a new sensibility must occur before change is possible.

I then demonstrated how this definition captures the common denominator that ties together the phenomena most often associated with wokeism: political correctness, cancel culture, call-out culture, and identity politics. These are all manifestations of consciousness policing. If the key to justice is ensuring that everyone has the correct consciousness, the logical next step is controlling what people think and say. Wokeism inevitably leads to the policing of language and ideas, because the lack of a “correct consciousness” or the deviation from it within the in-group are seen as the main barriers to justice. I also argued that wokeism is fundamentally anti-political in character: it reduces politics to a matter of who thinks correctly and who does not, rather than engaging with the messy, pluralist work of building coalitions across deep disagreements to contest power and win material gains.

Part 1 also identified *who* the woke people are and where they come from. Drawing heavily on sociologist Musa Al-Gharbi’s 2024 book *We Have Never Been Woke*, I showed that the primary carriers of wokeism are not the genuinely marginalized and disadvantaged, but rather those whom Al-Gharbi calls “symbolic capitalists”: the stratum of the Professional Managerial Class (PMC) whose work involves the production and manipulation of discourse, rhetoric, and cultural meaning, including academics, journalists, media pundits, HR professionals, and those in arts and entertainment. Their political style is fundamentally post-materialist: they prioritize symbols, rhetoric, and cultural recognition over the material “bread and butter” concerns of working-class people. In woke-captured spaces, marginalized identities become valuable commodities, what Al-Gharbi calls “totemic capital,” in which victimhood functions as a form of status currency in the competition for scarce professional opportunities. Al-Gharbi’s materialist analysis explains *when* and *why* awakenings occur. My definition provides the missing piece: a concrete articulation of *what* wokeism actually is and how to recognize it.

What remains is the historical question: where does this consciousness-first template come from? How did a style of politics organized around awakening, conversion, and the policing of belief become so deeply embedded in American political culture? The answer, as this essay will show, lies not in Marxism, not in postmodernism, and not in any foreign import, but

in one of the oldest and most characteristically American traditions: evangelical Protestant revivalism.

1. Genealogy I: The Protestant Origins of Wokeism



a. The First and Second Great Awakenings

While the word “woke” may have originated in African American vernacular, the sociological phenomenon of **wokeism**, the consciousness-first approach to socio-political thinking defined above, can be traced back to American Evangelism. To understand wokeism’s genealogy, we must begin with the First and Second Great Awakenings, the Protestant revivals that established the template for American moral reform.

The First Great Awakening (1730s-1750s) introduced something radically new to American religious life: the idea that genuine transformation required not just intellectual acceptance of doctrine but a personal, emotional “awakening.” Calvinist theologian Jonathan Edwards and itinerant preacher George Whitefield, two of the movement’s most influential figures, did not just preach theology; they sought to produce an inner tremor, a “new birth” that would fundamentally transform the individual.

The Second Great Awakening (1790s-1840s) built on these foundations while adding elements crucial for understanding contemporary wokeism. Unlike the First Awakening, which remained largely Calvinist, the Second witnessed a movement toward ideas of universal salvation and religious free will. Anyone could choose to accept grace rather than being predetermined for salvation or damnation.

Most significantly, the Second Great Awakening placed increased emphasis on “good works” and human agency in salvation, which helped spur the era’s numerous social reform movements: temperance, women’s rights, and abolitionism, among others. The camp meetings that characterized this revival featured simple, lively preaching that deeply affected participants, often producing strong emotional responses considered evidence of genuine conversion.



Now it is important to not confuse the great awakenings with “right-wing wokeism.” While Evangelical Christians tend to overwhelmingly lean to the right today, the Protestant revivals of the first and second great awakenings were not explicitly right or left wing. In many ways, they were quite progressive for their time and focused a lot on social justice. The First Great Awakening broke down traditional religious hierarchies by suggesting that individuals could have direct spiritual experiences without clerical mediation. Women, African Americans, Native Americans, even children were sometimes permitted to exhort when ministers recognized the Holy Spirit upon them. The democratization of Christianity that occurred with the great awakenings is also a big part of what made evangelicalism **uniquely American**.

Born-Again Christians: What Made Evangelicals Different

As historian Mark Noll documents in *The Rise of Evangelicalism*, the movement crystallized in 18th-century Britain and the American colonies out of the convergence of English Puritanism, continental Pietism, and High Church Anglican spirituality, defined above all by what historian David Bebbington identifies as its four core commitments: conversionism, **biblicism**, **activism**, and **crucicentrism**.^[22]

One of the things that made Evangelicals profoundly different from Catholics is the expectation to be a “born-again” Christian. In Catholicism, one can be initiated into the faith through baptism, participate in the sacraments, and belong to the Church without undergoing any dramatic personal transformation. For Evangelicals, this is not enough. The individual must undergo a personal “awakening” and arrive at the absolutely correct internal belief themselves. Mere observance, mere ritual, mere inheritance of the faith from one’s parents counts for nothing without the inner experience of conversion.

Modern wokeism operates on a parallel consciousness-first premise. It is a consciousness-first style of politics that assumes people must individually “wake up” to the correct political ideas as a strict prerequisite for solidarity, rather than building coalitions based on shared material interests. You cannot simply be a good person, support the right policies, or show up to the right protests. You must demonstrate that you have undergone the correct internal transformation.

The crucial link is the “born again” experience: **awakening and the demonstration of belief are treated as the most important conditions of being an Evangelical.** Salvation becomes legible through an inner transformation that must be narrated, recognized, and affirmed. You are not simply initiated into a community by inheritance or ritual. You are expected to testify that you have been changed. This is the template that wokeism inherits in secular form: conversion before coalition, awakening before action. Woke policing rituals often echo many of the puritanical tendencies of evangelical purification. First, you’re told you have unconscious bias, original sin. Then you need to become aware of it, awakening. You might have to share your journey or check your privilege publicly, testimony. You need ongoing training to maintain your awareness and discipleship.

God’s Plan: Literalism & The Democratization of Authority

The structural condition that produces these parallels did not begin with American Evangelicalism. It has its origins in the Protestant Reformation, which, when Luther established that the individual’s relationship to scripture supersedes the authority of institutional tradition, set in motion a logic whose consequences neither Luther nor his immediate successors fully anticipated. Once the principle was established that one’s personal interpretation of biblical text and one’s direct relationship with God matters more than the accumulated doctrinal tradition preserved by an authoritative clerical structure, there was no principled stopping point.

The result, unfolding over centuries, was a proliferation of competing Protestant denominations, each convinced of the correctness of its reading and none possessing an institution capable of adjudicating between them: Lutheranism, Calvinism, Presbyterianism, the Baptist tradition, and eventually, in America, Evangelicalism, Mormonism, and a wide range of increasingly fringe sects. The fragmentation was not a failure of the Reformation project. It was its structural consequence, the predictable outcome of removing the interpretive institution that Catholic and Orthodox Christianity had preserved through their more authoritative clerical structures and emphasis on doctrinal tradition over individual interpretation. American Evangelicalism represents the furthest development of this logic on American soil, the point at which the democratization of interpretive authority reaches its most radical expression.

But the democratization of interpretive authority carries a consequence that rarely gets named directly. When the accumulated weight of a clerical tradition is displaced in favor of direct, unmediated encounter with scripture, the text must bear the full weight of moral authority without any buffer, and this is precisely what produces **literalism** as the structural

companion of democratization rather than as a separate tendency. A word stripped of its interpretive tradition is a word whose surface meaning becomes its total meaning. The history of revivalist Evangelicalism makes this dynamic visible in ways that are sometimes striking.

Where Catholic and Orthodox theology treat the Church itself as the mediating authority between believer and text, centuries of accumulated doctrinal interpretation have shaped how passages are read, often understanding Old Testament covenant language as referring to the spiritual community of the Church rather than any literal geographic territory. Revivalist Evangelical Christianity tends to read the same passages as direct, concrete predictions about modern geopolitical events: **the modern state of Israel, Jewish people physically occupying the biblical land, and the unfolding of apocalyptic prophecy in real time.** The interpretive tradition that would complicate or spiritualize these readings has been bypassed in favor of the surface meaning taken as total meaning. The same literalism extends into the Evangelical understanding of divine providence. Because God is understood to be literally shaping every event according to a discernible and partly legible plan, prayer functions as a mechanism that produces literal outcomes rather than an act of orientation toward mystery. For many Evangelical communities, the correct belief is not merely the condition of one's own salvation but is understood to be actively efficacious in the world. Prayer works because God literally responds to it. **The apocalypse** is not simply awaited but in some sense accelerated by the accumulation of correct belief among the faithful. The right consciousness does not merely describe what is coming; it participates in bringing it about. This is a structure of thinking that the essay's later sections will find reproduced almost exactly in woke discourse, where changing the language is understood not merely to reflect a changed reality but to help constitute one. This is quite different from the Catholic and Orthodox sensibility, in which God may work in ways that remain opaque to human interpretation, and in which history is not presumed to be a readable script.

The consequences of this distinction become most visible on something like **climate change**. Many Evangelical communities, reading **apocalyptic** prophecy literally and understanding the transformation of the natural world as part of *God's unfolding will*, tend toward acceptance and discernment rather than intervention. If what is happening is literally **God's plan** being enacted, resisting it sits uneasily with the theological framework. **Both recent popes, by contrast, have treated climate change as a moral emergency demanding urgent human intervention**, which follows naturally from a tradition that does not presume the world's unfolding to be a transparent expression of divine intention. The Catholic Church has historically understood itself as an active institutional presence in the world precisely because it does not assume that what is already happening is simply God's will being done. The paradox is worth sitting with: the most radically democratized, anti-authority tendency within Christianity is also among the most literalist. Removing the interpretive institution does not free the believer from rigid readings. It tends to make those readings more variable and harder to correct.

This same dynamic helps explain why the internal diversity of interpretation that emerges in these movements is not necessarily a sign of intellectual vitality but of structural fragility. When any believer can read the text directly and claim authority for their reading, the result can be a proliferation of incompatible literalisms, each resistant to correction because no institution exists to adjudicate between them. The democratization of authority does not automatically liberate ideas. In the absence of mediating structures, it tends to degrade them as they pass through individuals without the conceptual guardrails that institutional interpretation would ordinarily provide.

The same pattern tends to produce characteristic forms of literalism throughout woke discourse. A racially charged joke is not merely offensive or crude; it is treated as literally enacting the harm it depicts. An aesthetic historically associated with fascism is not merely troubling or worth examining critically; it can be read as literally *being* fascism. Both the literalism and the consciousness-first thinking that wokeism shares with revivalist Evangelicalism are partly downstream of the same structural condition: the absence of any authority capable of preserving the nuanced, mediated interpretation of doctrine that a stable institutional tradition would ordinarily provide. In the case of wokeism, however, the consciousness-first orientation carries an additional and distinct driver.

As shown in Part 1, it emerges predominantly from symbolic capitalist industries, academia, media, art, and entertainment, whose professional lives literally revolve around the production and manipulation of symbols and discourse. People whose careers are built on the power of language and representation will naturally tend to see symbolic change as the primary lever of social transformation. Yet the absence of any central authoritative gatekeeper binding a single coherent woke ideology means that the frameworks these industries produce get taken up in contradictory and often extreme ways, varying enormously depending on how individuals choose to interpret the ideas they have been awakened to. This is precisely why defenders of wokeism can so readily move the goalposts whenever the movement is criticized. Ludicrous or extreme expressions of woke politics get dismissed as strawmen, and the defense invariably takes the form of insisting that the critics have misunderstood what gender theory, degrowth, feminism, or Marxist class consciousness *really* means. But this appeal to the true or original meaning is structurally hollow, because there is no coherent doctrine or institutional authority capable of legitimizing the intellectual's claim to know what the ideology in question genuinely requires. The serious gender theorist, the committed ecosocialist, the principled Marxist who insists that the woke distortions of their frameworks are not representative face a problem that is not merely rhetorical but structural: without an authoritative institution capable of drawing and enforcing a boundary between legitimate and illegitimate interpretation, their claim to the correct reading carries no more weight than anyone else's. What remains is an evolving body of politically correct language and narratives that keep getting adopted and reinterpreted by different people for different reasons, sometimes for status competition, sometimes out of genuine conviction, and often both at once.

These structural parallels between Evangelicalism and wokeism are significant, but they **should not be pushed into a simple equivalence.**

Wokeism is NOT a “Secular Religion”

It is tempting to make the argument that modern wokeism is simply evangelicalism without God. While evangelical revivalism was certainly an antecedent for the template of the woke mode of consciousness-first politics, it would be an oversimplification to say that wokeism is merely evangelical Christianity in secularized form. While modern wokeism (as shown in the Part 1 Essay) emerged through elite overproduction within the PMC and symbolic capitalists, the first and second Great Awakenings were much more so **genuinely bottom-up mass mobilizations.**

They spread through itinerant preaching, lay participation, voluntary association, and grassroots energy that could not be fully controlled from above. Whatever their ideological limits, Evangelical Christians were capable of producing thick, popular forms of community: people gathered physically, sang together, confessed together, organized together, and built durable local networks. In other words, revivalism did not only demand a certain consciousness, it also provided a social ecology that could bind ordinary people into a movement. This binding function is one of the core components of what defines religion from any other system of belief, and it is not an accident that the word “religion” itself is believed to originate from the Latin [*religare*](#), meaning “to bind.”

This matters because it clarifies the precise claim of this essay. My thesis is not “wokeism is Christianity in secularized form.” The point is that Wokeism resembles a mentality and approach to societal change that is deeply-rooted in American culture rather than germinating from foreign imports brought by “neo-Marxist” intellectuals infiltrating American universities. Rather, modern wokeism tends to take a particularly intense expression in America, particularly due to its Evangelical protestant heritage. **Wokeism is as American as apple pie**, and it’s steeped deep into America’s Protestant Heritage. As we will see, modern progressive wokeism has far more in common with Evangelicalism than it does with Marxist materialism. The Great Awakenings are an early mass instance of that pattern, even if their organizational sociology was very different from the symbolic-capitalist variant that dominates elite institutions today.

And this is where modern progressive wokeism quietly flips the revival logic into something colder. Evangelical revivalism, even at its most fanatical, is still typically **conversionist**. It assumes the unawakened can be awakened, and it organizes itself around the attempt to persuade, recruit, and bring outsiders in. The movement is harsh in its moral categories, but it is outward-facing. It wants growth, it wants expansion, it wants to win souls.

Contemporary elite-progressive wokeism, by contrast, **is far more policing-centered than conversion-centered.** This is because unlike Evangelical Christianity, which tries to convert people by appealing to **universal truths** that are *legitimized* by a **pre-existing theological doctrine** (the Christian Bible), modern Wokeism explicitly tries to go against **common**

sense while lacking the traditional legitimacy and doctrinal coherence capable of advancing its narratives.

Modern woke narratives tend to only carry legitimacy within symbolic capitalist institutions that woke people inhabit, but woke people are very bad at selling these narratives to normies outside the symbolic capitalist matrix. The wokes take their narratives and presuppositions **as a given** and often hardly even question them enough to fully understand why they believe them. As a result, when woke people get questioned on their ideological biases regarding issues like gender or race, they tend to resort to circular reasoning and/or appeal to authority (credentials, academic expertise, etc.) without patiently explaining the logic of their narratives to the people who have not already been exposed to them.

Thus, due to the inherently *anti-social* and self-referential tendencies of modern woke ideology, woke people often give up on trying to convince people outside their own bubble and end up spending much of their energy on surveilling the language, ideas, and behaviors of other people within their woke symbolic capitalist orbit. Recall the Part 1 essay's discussion of Musa Al-Gharbi's book which showed that wokeism emerges in part as a drive for status competition between struggling symbolic capitalist aspirants during cycles of elite overproduction.

When considering this, it's not hard to see why woke "communities" so often implode into cancel culture as woke people turn against each other due to **status competition** over diminishing slices of symbolic capitalist power in the guise of moral debates over social sanctions, virtue signaling, and principled displays of correct consciousness. Consequently, modern wokeism ends up functioning more like an **internal disciplinary regime** rather than a missionary movement. It produces far fewer genuine converts because it often does not treat persuasion as the point. It treats compliance as the point. This is why it can dominate institutions while remaining socially brittle.

But contemporary wokeism represents **revival without redemption**. Christianity, for all its emphasis on sin and judgment, places grace and forgiveness near the center. Wokeism, by contrast, generates condemnation without much space for forgiveness, producing perpetual guilt and anxiety without a stable path back into fellowship.

Cancel culture, in turn, is the enforcement mechanism for consciousness conformity. It's the contemporary equivalent of church discipline or, more accurately, excommunication. When someone violates the orthodoxies of woke consciousness, by using the wrong language, expressing the wrong ideas, or failing to demonstrate sufficient commitment to the cause, they must be cast out.

Consider the ritualistic nature of a typical cancellation: the initial accusation (testimony against the sinner), the pile-on (congregation affirming the sin), the demanded apology (confession), and the debate over whether the apology is sufficient (judgment on the sincerity of repentance). Even the language used, "problematic," "harmful," "violence," is itself evidence of this enchanted relationship to the word, in which terminology does not merely describe a wrong but enacts one. This is the direct inheritance of evangelical

literalism: **once interpretive mediation is removed and words carry full moral weight on their own, policing what people say and policing what people think become the same activity.**

This also helps explain why the popular line “wokeism is a religion” is both true and misleading. It is true in the sense that it has a moral cosmology, a language of sin and impurity, and a demand for public proof of righteousness. But it is misleading because it lacks the very thing that makes a religion socially powerful, a shared way of life anchored in durable institutions and collective ritual. Revival Christianity, for all its excesses, built churches, congregations, mutual aid, embodied practices, and a concrete metaphysical horizon that could stabilize the believer. Progressive wokeism often offers the moral urgency of religion without the communal glue of religion. It generates fervor without durable fellowship, and it generates condemnation faster than it generates forgiveness.

The result is a peculiar paradox. A consciousness-first movement that lacks binding communal practices will increasingly substitute symbolic compliance for real solidarity. That substitution is one of the reasons modern woke politics is so easy for elite institutions to absorb, professionalize, and weaponize.

Yet the deeper point is that this revival template can be filled with very different political contents, sometimes producing real moral progress, other times producing coercive crusades.

There is, however, another difference between wokeism and evangelical Christianity that points toward an even older genealogy. Evangelical revivalism, for all its emphasis on personal awakening, is still steeped in appeals to *universal* truths: scripture, divine law, a moral order that applies to everyone regardless of who they are. Contemporary wokeism tends to move in the opposite direction. Rather than grounding itself in universals, it appeals to the subjective experience of particular identity groups, a framework scholars call *standpoint epistemology*. Knowledge is treated not as something accessible to all through reason or revelation, but as something that depends on where you stand in a hierarchy of oppression. This is why woke discourse so often goes against common sense: its claims are not meant to be validated by ordinary experience but by the privileged perceptions of those who have been properly initiated into the correct theoretical frameworks. Or by marginalized groups whose experience of alienation from the dominant culture is supposed to make them uniquely positioned to access certain truths concealed by “the dominant ideology.” For this reason, one can argue that **modern wokeism is even more like Gnosticism than it is like Evangelicalism.**

b. Wokeism as Modern Gnosticism

Gnosticism refers to a family of religious movements that emerged in the first centuries of the Common Era, drawing on early Christian, Jewish, and pagan sources. The word comes from the Greek *gnosis*, meaning “knowledge.” Gnostics believed that the material world was not the creation of a benevolent God but the product of a flawed or malevolent lesser deity, a

демиург, who trapped divine sparks in matter. The visible world was therefore a kind of prison or illusion, and salvation came not through faith, ritual, or good works, but through acquiring a secret spiritual knowledge that revealed the world's true nature. Orthodox Christianity condemned Gnosticism as heresy precisely because it divided believers into two castes: the ordinary faithful, who could only see the surface of things, and the “knowers,” who had been initiated into a deeper, hidden reality. It is this epistemic structure, not the specific theological content, that makes the Gnostic analogy useful for understanding wokeism.

Gnosticism matters here not because wokeism is secretly an ancient heresy revived, but because it captures a recurring epistemic temptation: the belief that politics begins with privileged perception. Gnosticism drew a hard line between those who live in appearances and those who possess special knowledge, a deeper awareness that reveals the world's true structure. Much of woke discourse adopts the same posture. Reality is framed as hidden by ideology, language is treated as a veil, and moral truth is reserved for those who have undergone the proper initiation into the right way of seeing.

Once politics is built on this premise, consciousness becomes the precondition of legitimacy. The primary task is not to organize around shared interests but to awaken the unseeing, and to cleanse the community of those whose perception is deemed corrupted. That is why woke politics so easily turns disagreement into moral failure, and why it treats dissent less as a normal feature of coalition building than as evidence that someone has not yet been awakened, or has been politically conditioned by the wrong ideologies. It transforms politics into an epistemic sorting mechanism, separating the “initiated” from the “uninitiated,” and calling that separation justice.

In contemporary woke discourses, this Gnostic posture takes a specific form. Power structures are portrayed as all-powerful, invisible forces, *patriarchy*, *white supremacy*, *heteropatriarchy*, that permeate every institution and interaction but can only be perceived after one has been awakened to the correct critical theories. Before initiation, you are complicit in these structures without even knowing it. After initiation, you can finally “see” what was always there. This understanding of reality then gets projected onto how woke people approach structural change. Because the structures of oppression are framed as *social constructs*, the assumption follows that they can be deconstructed and reconstructed through the right language and the right consciousness. “We just made these structures up, so we can change them again.” The appeal is seductive, but it rests on a conflation: **the fact that something is socially constructed does not mean it is infinitely malleable or that it yields to discursive intervention alone.**

This Gnostic logic is visible in the everyday language of woke discourse. Phrases like “educate yourself” and “it is not my job to explain this to you” function as epistemic gatekeeping, treating political knowledge not as something advocates should be persuading people of, but as hidden wisdom the uninitiated must earn access to on their own. The very notion that disagreement stems from ignorance rather than genuine difference of

perspective, that the critic simply “does not get it,” is a Gnostic move dressed in progressive language. It forecloses debate by recasting it as a deficiency of perception.

Magical Thinking & Politics as Manifestation

What follows from this Gnostic posture is a kind of **magical thinking**. Once politics is reduced to consciousness, it becomes easy to imagine that the right thoughts, the right words, and the right symbols do not merely describe reality but actively conjure it. This is why many woke-minded people react to criticism as though naming a weakness already strengthens the enemy. An ideology stripped of interpretive mediation, like a text stripped of its tradition, can leave the individual with only the surface, and a surface taken with total seriousness tends to feel as though it constitutes reality rather than merely describing it.

It is a recurring feature of revivalist puritanism in its more radical forms, and one that woke consciousness reproduces in secular terms when it mistakes changing the discourse for changing the conditions. If a critique of the left happens to overlap with something the right also says, they often treat the acknowledgment itself as a form of capitulation. The possibility that the criticism might actually be true, and that one should learn from it, gets displaced by a quasi-magical fear that affirming it gives it force.

You see the same logic in anti-imperialist subcultures that insist they are nothing like liberal woke politics. Point out that American hegemony is not collapsing in the dramatic way they hoped, or that rival powers are not the emancipatory counterweight they imagine, and the response is often that you are helping empire by repeating imperial propaganda. But this confuses analysis with affirmation. It assumes that stating a balance of power helps sustain it, as though political reality bends to incantation. At that point **politics starts to resemble manifestation**, the fantasy that the correct consciousness can summon the correct world into being.

This also clarifies the deeper constructivist impulse of woke discourse. If social reality is thought to be constituted primarily through discourse, then changing discourse begins to look like changing reality itself. Masculinity and femininity are reduced to constructs, therefore they must be endlessly reconstructable. Gender is treated as wholly socially constructed, therefore identification is presumed capable of overriding the stubborn facts of sexed embodiment.

This is why hostility to biology is not incidental. Woke milieus are often allergic to any appeal to biological constraint, especially to evolutionary psychology, sex difference research, or even commonsense claims about embodiment, because such appeals interrupt the fantasy that consciousness can simply rewrite reality. It is not a mere coincidence that both Evangelicals and Woke people today tend to be hostile to evolutionary science and express a kind of magical thinking. This odd homology is downstream of the consciousness-first mode.

And it is no accident that this mentality finds such a natural home among symbolic capitalists. Precisely because their social power is rooted in the production and management

of symbols, language, prestige, and knowledge, it is deeply convenient for them to believe that changing symbols and minds is what changes the world. In their own professional terrain, discourse really does shape reputations, legitimacy, and access. That is why even very educated people can arrive at remarkably foolish conclusions here. Their intelligence does not protect them from the bias. It often rationalizes it. The more one's class position is bound up with symbolic power, the easier it becomes to mistake symbolic control for social transformation.

This also explains why postmodern and poststructuralist theorists are so attractive to woke-minded symbolic capitalists. It is a mistake to view thinkers like Foucault and Derrida as the originators of woke ideology; rather, the expansion of the PMC and the symbolic capitalist industries led wokeism in academia to gravitate toward these thinkers because their frameworks *legitimize* the consciousness-first worldview. Derrida's demonstration of the fluidity of meaning and language gets taken as proof that structures and meaning can be infinitely rewritten, deconstructed, and recentered. Foucault's analysis of power is used to delegitimize traditions, rationalize institutional changes, or simply tear things down by framing everything as a product of power relations. Judith Butler's argument that gender is a construct that is *performed* leads to the conclusion that people can be taught to perform differently: if people perform the way they do because of conditioning, then they can be reconditioned to be less sexist, less gender-binary, and so on.

Within this framework, the attempt to forge reality through language and consciousness becomes a legitimate path to progress. But the mode of thinking precedes the thinkers. These theorists are attractive to symbolic capitalist minds not because they invented a new politics, but because they provide intellectual legitimacy for a worldview that was already convenient: that the world changes through the production and revision of symbols, which happens to be exactly what symbolic capitalists do for a living.

This also clarifies why the Gnostic parallel is ultimately more precise than the evangelical one. Evangelical Christianity, for all its literalism and moral absolutism, is fundamentally generative. It builds churches, founds schools, creates thick communities, and actively seeks to expand through conversion. Its orientation is outward: it wants more people inside the fold, and it organizes its entire institutional life around growth, transmission, and the reproduction of a positive doctrinal vision across generations. Whatever one thinks of its theology, evangelicalism has been remarkably successful on its own terms precisely because it offers converts something to belong to, not merely something to reject. Modern progressive wokeism inverts this logic almost entirely. It is defined far more by what it opposes than by what it affirms: anti-colonial, anti-patriarchal, anti-capitalist, anti-Western, anti-heteronormative. Its characteristic intellectual operation is deconstruction, the dismantling of existing frameworks, traditions, and forms of social reproduction that are deemed complicit in structures of oppression. The "awakening" it offers is not an awakening to a positive vision of the good life but an awakening to the pervasiveness of hidden domination. Once awakened, the convert does not join a thick community with durable practices and a shared way of life. They adopt a posture of permanent critique, one that is

structurally incapable of generating the kinds of stable institutions and social bonds that sustain movements across generations. This is why wokeism depends so heavily on capturing existing institutions (universities, media, HR departments) rather than building its own. It lacks the generative capacity to create durable alternatives to the structures it deconstructs.

Gnosticism suffered from exactly the same structural limitation. It offered initiates a secret knowledge that the material world was a prison, but it provided no positive program for living within that world, no thick communal life, no durable institutional form capable of reproducing itself. Its orientation was entirely toward negation: the world is false, the body is a trap, the ruling powers are corrupt. Historical Gnosticism was marginalized and eventually extinguished with relative ease, not because its opponents were simply more ruthless, but because a movement organized around secret knowledge and the rejection of the material order lacks the social infrastructure required to sustain itself across generations. **It cannot build what it is constitutionally committed to deconstructing.** The same logic explains the cyclical pattern documented in Part 1: each Awakening erupts with intense energy, captures institutions for a period, and then dissipates once the material pressures ease, leaving remarkably little behind, because nothing durable was built. The evangelical megachurch outlasts the diversity office precisely because one is constructive and outward-facing while the other is deconstructive and inward-facing. A movement that can only spread by awakening people to how bad things are, without offering them a way of life worth reproducing, will always burn itself out.

With that side-analogy in place, we can return to the more historically decisive genealogy, the evangelical template of awakening, conversion, and moralized belonging that would later reappear in secular form.

Before tracing how the woke mode eventually took on a secular form, crystallizing during the 1960s with the rise of consciousness-raising movements and the New Left during the countercultural decade of the 60s, it is necessary to understand what it displaced: class politics, which based solidarity in mutual material interests rather than shared beliefs.

c. The Rise of Class Politics & Marxism

The nineteenth century transformed every dimension of political life. Industrial capitalism uprooted millions from agrarian communities, concentrated them in factories and cities, and subjected them to conditions, child labor, twelve-hour workdays, poverty wages, that made the Enlightenment promises of freedom and equality ring hollow. Out of this upheaval emerged class politics: the idea that solidarity is grounded not in shared belief or cultural identity but in the shared material interests of those who labor for a living.

Marxism was the most influential expression of this materialist politics, and what distinguished it from the many other socialist currents of the time was a specific claim about the direction of causality. **Material conditions determine consciousness, not the other way around.** You do not change society by changing how people think; you change how

people think by changing the material relations in which they live. The working class, in this framework, was not revolutionary because of who they were or what they believed, but because of their structural position in production. Concentrated in factories, collectively producing the wealth on which the entire system depended, workers possessed an organizational power that no previous exploited class had held. Their leverage was not moral or epistemic. It was structural.

And it is precisely this starting point that wokeism reverses.

Marx Was Not Woke

Contrary to the popular narratives of right-wing ideologues like James Lindsay and Jordan Peterson, who insist on blaming “cultural Marxism” for everything, Karl Marx was not woke. The more nuanced paleoconservative thinker Paul Gottfried made precisely this point in his article [“Marx Was Not Woke,”](#) and demonstrated how completely the New Left deviated from the old class-first left in his 2005 book *The Strange Death of Marxism*. Classical Marxism, in many ways, was the *opposite* of woke. Marxism is based on a materialist conception of social change, not an idealist, consciousness-first approach. A Marxist looks at racism and says: “This emerges from the economic need to justify slavery and divide workers.” A woke person looks at racism and says: “This emerges from wrong thoughts that need to be corrected through education.” A Marxist says: “Organize workers across racial lines to fight capital.” A woke person says: “Center the most marginalized voices and defer to their experience.” A Marxist says: “Material equality will lead to cultural change.” A woke person says: “Cultural change will lead to material equality.”

Wokeism is consciousness-first. Marxism is material-first. They are not the same thing; they are opposites. Marxism does not claim that the working class will rise up simply because they suddenly realize they are oppressed. The working class is not revolutionary because of who they are but because of their role in production, because they have the collective power to shut down the system and reshape it. It is about structure, not sentiment. Wokeism operates on the opposite premise: that people must be re-educated into the correct way of thinking before society can change. It places ideology before structure, thought before action.

The Wokeification of Marxism and “Class Consciousness”

Marxism, insofar as it actually has anything to do with the ideas of Marx and Engels, is the antithesis of wokeism. It grounds solidarity in mutual class interests, not in shared political consciousness. In fact, Marx and Engels did not even use the language of “left” and “right” to describe their political project. They framed their communist vision as a class struggle rooted in the objective structural conflict between the laboring classes and the property-owning classes.

However, for many socialists and communists today, Marxism has been more of a fan club for disaffected academics and student autodidacts than a political project that involves the working class. In many Marxist circles, the question of how to mobilize workers becomes

less important than the obsession with having the correct Marxist “take.” Entry into politics becomes a matter of theoretical credentialing. It is not “What coalition can we build?” but “Do you understand the doctrine?” In such cases, Marxism takes on the exact same social form as wokeism: belief first, coalition second, and power perpetually deferred. You end up with a subculture that is very confident in its analysis, very fluent in denunciation, and strangely incapable of building durable institutions. The Cultural Revolution (which I yet have to covered in-depth), and other episodes of hard-left moral crusading, show how quickly a putatively materialist politics can mutate into purity tests, public rituals of self-criticism, and ideological policing once *correct consciousness* becomes the real basis of legitimacy.

A common case of this “woke Marxism” manifests in the notion of “class consciousness,” which is interpreted and misused by many Marxist activists who are sociologically far removed from the working class they claim to speak for. Marx and Engels originally did not regard class consciousness as some magical spell that intellectuals bestow on the masses from above. They treated it as something that would naturally arise in response to the objective conditions and struggles of the working class, something that emerges organically when material pressures sharpen and collective life makes certain interests obvious. Intellectuals and political leaders could direct class consciousness toward particular political projects, but Marx did not imagine it was the job of some elite intellectual vanguard to cultivate it.

Yet **many Marxists in contemporary leftist activism treat class consciousness as a gnostic secret they must awaken the masses to**, rather than as something the working class naturally possesses through its objective life experiences under capitalism. We have all encountered the type: the prototypical self-identified Marxist with the Che Guevara T-shirt, whose habitat is typically college campuses and faculty lounges rather than factory floors, and who is convinced that the reason workers are not flocking to socialism is a “lack of class consciousness.” This often leads to the assumption that all that is needed to advance socialism is more propaganda. Repeat “capitalism is bad” loudly enough, and the masses will awaken, and organization will magically follow.

What this misses is that the barriers to working-class organizing are structural, not merely ideological. Union density has collapsed not because workers are too ignorant to recognize exploitation, but because the institutional and economic costs of organizing have become brutally high: capital mobility, globalization, a growing reserve army of labor, intensified replaceability, and real retaliation risks that make unionizing a dangerous bet for ordinary people.

Ironically, many New Leftists would champion the very policies and ideologies that inadvertently contributed to this crippling of working-class power. In the name of progressivism and internationalism, much of the left would end up championing globalization, mass migration, pressuring women into the workforce, and outsourcing family functions to specialist functions of the state and medical industry. In some cases, leftists would even embrace neoliberalism outright, as described in Johanna Bockman’s book *Markets in the Name of Socialism: The Left-Wing Origins of Neoliberalism*. The working

class is not “failing” to gallop toward communism because they lack the right consciousness. They often have not been presented with a viable political party, a convincing policy plan, and a feasible path to achieving it that would actually improve their lives. Ambivalence toward socialism and communism is not merely the result of brainwashing. It is rational skepticism born of historical experience with attempts at socialism that carried far more risk than reward.

The notion that the people must change first, that they must be taught class consciousness from a priestly class of Marxist intellectuals and leftist activists, is Marxism in a woke mode. Attempts to meet the actually existing working class where they are, without first re-educating them out of supposedly “bourgeois” or “reactionary” prejudices, get dismissed as “tailism,” a charge rooted in the presumption that working-class sentiments are illegitimate, confused, or morally tainted.

But in a liberal-democratic society, the legitimacy of a political movement is contingent upon its ability to secure broad public support. Any remotely successful political project will inevitably have to adapt to a broad constituency and to form coalitions with those who may disagree on many things while sharing certain goals. If the success of a political project requires the impossible goal of the majority of people adopting the political ideology of that project, rather than the other way around, its outcome will be self-marginalization at best or *totalitarian* at worst.

This is what makes the genealogy of class politics essential to our story. **Class politics represented the most serious historical alternative to consciousness-first politics.** Its decline did not simply leave a vacuum. It left a vacuum that was filled by the very template it had sought to replace: the revivalist logic of awakening, conversion, and moralized belonging, now dressed in secular clothing. Understanding how and why that decline happened is the subject of the next section.

2. Genealogy II: The Decline of Class Politics and The Rise of The New Left (1960s-1970s)

To understand the decline of class politics and the rise of the consciousness-first politics that replaced it, we need to look at structural transformations, not just the spread of ideas. Many people tend to get this part of history backwards by myopically looking at the academy rather than the real objective changes in the global economy that created the material conditions for the awakenings we discussed in the previous essay. Two developments in particular radically expanded the number of people aspiring to become symbolic capitalists: *the managerial revolution* and *the massive expansion of higher education*.

In his 1941 book *The Managerial Revolution*, James Burnham argued that capitalism was evolving not toward socialism, as Marxists had predicted, but toward a new form of society dominated by *managers*. Ownership was being separated from control. A new class of technical, organizational, and administrative personnel was becoming the real power holder in modern corporations and government bureaucracies, even as they did not own the means

of production in the classical sense. Burnham's thesis anticipated what Barbara and John Ehrenreich would later theorize in 1977 as the "Professional Managerial Class": a distinct social stratum defined not by ownership of capital but by its monopoly on credentialed expertise and its role in the reproduction of culture and social relations. This was the class that would eventually dominate left-wing institutions, and whose political style would reshape what "leftist" politics even meant.

The second transformation was the massive expansion of higher education in the postwar decades. The GI Bill of 1944 opened university doors to millions who would never have attended otherwise, and Cold War-era investment in education further swelled enrollment. In 1940, only 4.6% of American adults held a bachelor's degree. By the early twenty-first century, that figure had surpassed 37%. This expansion created a vastly larger class of people whose primary asset was their education and cultural sophistication, and whose professional lives revolved around the production and management of symbols, language, and knowledge. It also created the conditions for *elite overproduction*: when there are far more credentialed aspirants than positions available for them, the resulting insecurity generates the intense status competition that, as we discussed in Part 1, manifests as moral crusading.

These two structural shifts, the managerial revolution and the expansion of education, produced the class that would eventually fill the vacuum left by the decline of the Old Left. But to understand why that vacuum opened in the first place, we need to examine the crises that destroyed working-class politics as an organized force.

The PMC takeover of the Left did not happen overnight. It was, rather, the product of decades-long structural decomposition, a slow unraveling whose causes are less conspiratorial than commonly supposed. The temptation to attribute this transformation to CIA infiltration of progressive organizations, to academia's promotion of cultural Marxism, or to some coordinated campaign of ideological subversion is understandable; it is also wrong. These explanations, however satisfying to those who prefer a villain with a face, substitute narrative convenience for structural analysis.

The truth is more consequential, and more depressing. The Old Left did not lose *because* the New Left won. The *New Left emerged because the Old Left had already collapsed*, and into that vacuum rushed a politics shaped by very different class interests and cultural priorities.

Consider the mid-twentieth century conjuncture. In the 1950s, American labor still possessed genuine institutional power. Unions commanded mass membership, wielded real bargaining leverage, and pushed the Democratic Party toward redistributive commitments that would be unthinkable in the current moment. Socialists and Communists, despite their organizational weakness relative to European counterparts, maintained a *presence* within the labor movement that kept class politics visible, even if never hegemonic. That conjuncture dissolved under the pressure of three overlapping crises, each compounding the others.

The first was ideological, and it struck in two distinct phases. The Red Scares of the late 1940s and early 1950s did not merely target individual communists; they systematically dismantled the institutional infrastructure through which the Old Left had exercised influence in unions, universities, and media. It is important, however, not to mistake the Red Scare for the *cause* of communism's unpopularity. Communism was already deeply unpopular in America, because its collectivist, statist, and totalitarian ethos fundamentally conflicted with the American creed of Christian individualism and democratic liberalism. Atheist totalitarianism did not sit well with a country whose political culture was steeped in both religious voluntarism and liberal constitutionalism. As discussed in Part 1, communism in America tended to be more prevalent among symbolic capitalists than among workers, at least from the 1920s onward and especially in the post-Great Depression era. The Red Scare did not create anti-communist sentiment; it *capitalized* on it, and in doing so it damaged far more than communism itself. By associating anything that emphasized class struggle, socialism, or inequality with Soviet-style communism, the Red Scares delivered a blow to the labor movement as a whole, pressuring it to moderate and wed itself to status quo politics. People increasingly distanced themselves from class-based analysis to avoid being tarred with communist associations, and even those who were not communists were deterred from utilizing Marxism as an analytical tool due to the reputational risks it carried. The result was not merely the marginalization of communists but the marginalization of *class politics* as such.

This was the organizational blow, delivered before the deeper intellectual crisis had even begun. That crisis arrived with Khrushchev's secret speech of 1956, which exposed the full architecture of Stalinist repression: the gulags, the purges, the manufactured famines. The blow to left-wing intellectual morale was severe. Some drew the obvious anti-communist conclusion. Others clung to the hope that socialism might be reconstructed on more humane foundations, that the authoritarian aberration could be separated from the emancipatory project it had claimed to embody.

The Prague Spring of 1968 extinguished that hope. When Soviet tanks rolled through Czechoslovakia to crush what reformers called "socialism with a human face," even committed Marxists like Sartre were forced to reckon seriously with what this meant about the relationship between socialism and state power. By the end of the 1960s, the American left had lost both its institutional scaffolding and its intellectual confidence in the very idea of a systemic alternative to capitalism.

The second crisis was economic. The stagflation of the 1970s, the combination of inflation and unemployment that Keynesian theory had declared incompatible, exposed the limits of the postwar settlement. The OPEC oil shocks of 1973 and 1979 revealed the fragility of an industrial order built on cheap energy. More fundamentally, the profitability crisis of the 1970s demonstrated that the welfare state compromise, the arrangement by which capital accepted redistribution in exchange for social stability, had become untenable from the perspective of accumulation. The era of managed capitalism was over.

What replaced it was *neoliberalism*, and here the standard account requires a necessary correction. Neoliberalism was not simply imposed by the right against a resistant left. Left parties across the Western world embraced market reforms, selling them to their constituencies as modernization, as efficiency, as a more sophisticated liberation freed from the bureaucratic paternalism of the postwar state. This embrace was not purely opportunistic. The New Left's emphasis on individual autonomy, self-expression, and freedom from institutional constraint meshed naturally with market ideology's celebration of consumer sovereignty and personal choice. **Collective power was reframed as collectivist coercion; individual choice was reframed as freedom.** The Left lost not only the argument but the conceptual vocabulary through which a different argument might have been made.

The third crisis was structural: the globalization of production and the hypermobility of capital. The bargaining power of organized labor had always rested on a simple asymmetry: workers could withhold their labor, but they could not be easily replaced. That asymmetry dissolved as corporations gained the capacity to relocate production across national borders, disciplining American workers by pointing to cheaper labor in the global South. Capital became increasingly mobile; workers remained, by necessity, rooted to particular places. The mere threat of relocation, whether or not it was always carried out, was sufficient to break the credibility of collective action. The strategic question was no longer how to win a strike, but how to prevent the factory from simply leaving.

The consequences reshaped what working-class politics could even aspire to.

Workers who had once organized to demand democratic control of the workplace were reduced to negotiating over the conditions of their own dispensability. Union membership collapsed, not merely as a statistical fact but as an organizational reality that removed millions of workers from the only institutional form through which class power had historically been exercised. The gig economy that emerged in subsequent decades was not an accident of technological change; it was the perfected form of an employment relationship designed to atomize workers, to dissolve any collective identity that might generate shared political demands.

This is the structural context within which the cultural turn of the Left must be understood. When an increasingly credentialed left-wing intelligentsia, drawn disproportionately from the professional-managerial class, confronted the wreckage of the Old Left's organizational infrastructure, what remained available as a political terrain? The workplace, as a site of collective organization, had been effectively neutralized. *Socialism* carried the historical weight of Soviet atrocity. Material politics, in the sense of organized struggle over the distribution of economic power, appeared not merely difficult but structurally foreclosed. What remained was identity, representation, and the politics of recognition, a terrain that happened to correspond rather precisely to the professional and cultural capital of the class fraction now dominant within left institutions.

The 2008 financial crisis briefly interrupted this trajectory, demonstrating that material interests remained politically legible even within a PMC-dominated Left. The surprising

resonance of Bernie Sanders's campaigns represented a genuine, if incomplete, attempt to resurrect Old Left politics within the structures of the Democratic Party. But the attempt also revealed the structural obstacles to its realization. Sanders's movement was, in its composition, disproportionately college-educated and urban, and its eventual consolidation behind the Biden campaign destroyed precisely the working-class credibility that the project required.

What remains is the configuration we inhabit today: a Left structurally incapable of organizing workers, institutionally dominated by PMC sensibilities, and increasingly absorbed in cultural contestation while the class war proceeds on an entirely different terrain. **The problem is not that cultural politics is without significance. The problem is that when cultural struggle replaces rather than supplements material struggle, when the superstructure becomes the primary site of political investment precisely because the base has been conceded, a politics of liberation has already foreclosed the conditions of its own possibility.**

a. The Cultural Turn & The Counterculture

The 1960s witnessed a fundamental transformation in left politics, what scholars call the "cultural turn." The revivalist template traced in the previous section, with its emphasis on awakening, conversion, and moralized belonging, did not disappear with secularization. It reappeared in new forms. As class politics started to gradually decline from the 1960s onward, the vacuum was filled by "consciousness raising" movements and identity politics.

But we must be careful not to invert the causality here. **The cultural turn did not cause the decline of class politics. Rather, the weakening of class politics created the conditions in which consciousness-raising movements could flourish.** As the institutional bases of working-class solidarity eroded and class organizing became harder to sustain, moral and cultural frameworks became a more available basis for political mobilization, especially within the expanding college-educated strata. In that sense, the rise of consciousness politics was less the motor of the shift than one of its products, a substitute form of mobilization that grows in the vacuum class politics leaves behind.

Instead of organizing workers to demand higher wages, material politics, you organize students to examine their privilege, consciousness politics. Instead of building coalitions across differences to win concrete gains, you build affinity groups of the already-awakened.

The New Left

The New Left that emerged in the 1960s was fundamentally different from the Old Left. While the Old Left was organized around working-class politics that put working-class people at the center regardless of race or gender, the New Left was composed mainly of students, career activists, and people adjacent to the Professional Managerial Class in urban areas. Despite retaining some commitment to socialist politics, the New Left began to prioritize different issues: race, gender, sexuality, and cultural liberation, issues that sometimes intersected with class but often did not. As mutual class interests were no longer the focal point around which

different leftist movements could rally, New Left politics tried to unite various groups around more diffuse ideological categories: shared goals of “liberation,” freedom of self-expression, or victim-identity narratives of shared oppression. Into this vacuum, the New Left popularized secularized revival methods: consciousness-raising circles, self-interrogation, public witness, and the moralization of everyday life.

The Consciousness-Raising Movements of the 60s



Harvard University, Schlesinger Library on the History of Women in America, PC320769

The connection between wokeism and 1960s-70s consciousness-raising movements reveals a reincarnation of the Evangelical Protestant revival template in a secularized form. The women’s liberation movement explicitly adapted religious “awakening” concepts when developing their consciousness-raising (CR) groups and workshops. Activists like Kathie Sarachild explicitly modeled CR on the language of awakening, framing the process as one through which women would come to see reality as it truly is.

Conversion became awakening. Just as religious conversion involved passing from spiritual blindness to sight, CR groups promised passage from false consciousness to true awareness. You had to “wake up” to systemic oppression, experience that fundamental shift in worldview. **Testimony morphed into confession and critique.** Revival testimony, public declaration of conversion, transformed into personal narrative, public confession, and ongoing self-critique as proof of sincerity. In CR groups, women shared stories not just for

catharsis but as political acts, demonstrating awakened consciousness. This pattern surfaces today as apology posts, privilege acknowledgments, and cycles of denunciation and absolution. The performative aspect remained: you must publicly demonstrate your consciousness transformation.

Once politics is framed this way, **it becomes easy to imagine that transforming how people see, speak, and identify is not merely useful *preparation* for political change, but is thought to be *neccesary* for political change, and/or even constitutes political change itself.**

From the Factory to the Ivory Tower

What made this consciousness-raising template so consequential was its portability. The CR format, once developed in activist circles, could be transplanted into any institutional setting that required ideological formation. As class politics receded through the 1970s-90s, universities, NGOs, and HR departments became the primary venues for ideological formation. The training ground for public action shifted from union halls to seminar rooms. These venues rewarded formation, how people talk, present, and are assessed, more than organization. The belief-first sequence flourished: orientations, workshops, statements, rituals, enforcement procedures. Critical theory and postmodernism, emerging from academia, expanded oppressor/oppressed categories beyond economic terms to include colonial, sexual, racial, and gender oppression; power became the supreme category, society an arena of warring identity groups.

Many leftists today who consider themselves to be post-woke or agnostic on the question of wokeism often like to tell themselves that the problems associated with wokeness are just a problem with liberals or the “liberal left” but not the “real” socialist left. However, all it takes is to spend a little time in academia, Twitter, and “radical” leftist activist spaces to see that this sort of mainstream progressive wokeism often finds its way into “radical” leftist organizations, even Marxist ones. The prevalence of woke politics in radical left spaces is very much a **residue of the cultural turn** that occurred with the rise of **the New Left** in the 60s, and the collapse of the Old Left.

b. The Rise of Identity Politics and Race Consciousness

In my **Part 1** Genealogy of Wokeism essay, I already discussed why the Civil Rights movement was not “woke” in the sense I am using the term. Unfortunately, the same can’t be said about all race politics. When it comes to “identity politics,” it is important to distinguish the Civil Rights movement from the Black Power movement. I do not consider the Civil Rights movement to fall under the wokeism frame, due to its *universalist* character. The movement’s core was universal and material: equal citizenship under law, desegregation of public life, the vote with federal enforcement, due process, and access to the concrete goods of modern life, jobs, housing, schools, and transit. Its language was constitutional; its method was a mass, cross-class, interracial coalition; its instruments were church-linked

organizations, unions, boycotts, courts, and legislatures. Folding abolition or the Civil Rights movement into woke politics erases their universalist core and their institutional strategy.

But then you started getting the rise of the Black Power movement. Black Power saw various different political currents come and go during the tumultuous years of the 1970s. It involved groups like the original Black Panther Party, a group with a class-based agenda that focused on helping poor black communities by building clinics, breakfast programs, tenant unions, free schools, voter drives, and self-defense committees, autonomy in order to bargain better. After the collapse of the original Black Panther Party, you started to mostly get Black Nationalist movements that prioritized race over class. As scholars like Adolph Reed Jr. and Cedric Johnson have argued, this turn from class-universalist politics to race-particularist politics represented a retreat from the material agenda that had defined the most successful phases of the Black freedom struggle.

Black nationalist movements embodied the consciousness-first style of politics in a way that civil rights leaders like Martin Luther King and A. Philip Randolph **did not**. This is because black nationalism, in its essentialist forms, rested on a premise that is structurally identical to the woke template: the preconception that people of a particular color share a common **essence**, and therefore a common consciousness, that must be *awakened* as the basis of political solidarity. The same structural move appears in white nationalism, which imagines that white people across different countries and continents share a deeper political and cultural unity than blacks and whites of the same country, the same class, or even the same neighborhood. This is not to morally equate black and white nationalism; their historical contexts and power relations are vastly different. However, both embody a consciousness-first conception of politics that places the social construct of race as the basis of political solidarity, above more materially grounded variables like shared culture, environment, and class interests.

The critical analytical point here is the conflation of **color** with **culture**. Woke approaches to race, whether from the left or the right, frequently treat phenotypic categories as though they carry inherent cultural content. You see this in how some progressives talk about the appropriation of “black culture” or assert that “there is no white culture,” which has been met with the white identitarian reaction that tries to celebrate whiteness by associating it with “Western civilization,” lumping together the highly diverse cultures of American, European, and even Roman civilizations, even though these cultures would not have seen themselves as part of the same “white race.” Both moves commit the same error: **they conflate race with culture**, mistaking an abstract category based on colorism for the *real materiality* of lived cultural experience.

This distinction matters because it reveals why racial essentialism is consciousness-first politics **by structural necessity**, not merely by inclination. Culture has a genuine material basis. Ethiopians share a language, a territory, a history of institutions, a cuisine, and a way of life. Ethiopian nationalism, whatever one thinks of it, is grounded in something real. The same can be said of Irish nationalism, or even British nationalism, however contested its boundaries may be. But “black nationalism,” in the transnational sense that Marcus Garvey

envisioned when he sought to unite African countries with Black Americans, or “white nationalism” in the sense of a shared political identity among all people classified as white, are not grounded in any shared culture, language, territory, or way of life. They are grounded in nothing but color, a phenotypic abstraction.

And precisely because colorism has no material substrate capable of naturally generating solidarity in the way that a shared culture does, **the only way to make race-essentialist politics cohere is through consciousness-raising**. You have to *construct* the solidarity from the top down, because it does not emerge organically from people’s lived conditions. A black professor at Harvard and a black sharecropper in Mississippi do not share material interests by virtue of their skin color. A white investment banker in Manhattan and a white coal miner in Appalachia do not share a “culture” in any meaningful sense. To insist otherwise is to impose an ideological construct onto people whose actual lives contradict it, and that imposition requires precisely the kind of consciousness-first politics this essay has been tracing: awakening people to an identity they would not naturally organize around on the basis of their material circumstances alone.

This is why it is no coincidence that Marcus Garvey, one of the earliest figures associated with the language of “waking up” (his 1923 rallying cry “Wake up Ethiopia! Wake up Africa!”), was also a practitioner of race-essentialist politics. The language of awakening was not incidental to his project. It was structurally necessary, because the transnational racial solidarity he envisioned had no material foundation capable of sustaining itself without constant ideological cultivation. The politics could only work if enough people were *awakened* to a racial consciousness that overrode the far more concrete divisions of class, nationality, language, and actual culture.

The logical endpoint of this consciousness-first racial politics is revealing. When two movements both organize around racial purity and racial separation, even from opposite ends of the racial hierarchy, the structural convergence can produce strange alliances. Marcus Garvey, founder of the Universal Negro Improvement Association, secretly met with the Ku Klux Klan’s Imperial Wizard Edward Young Clarke in 1922, finding the Klan more “honest” about their racism than white liberals and seeking to negotiate shared goals of racial separation. In 1961, Nation of Islam officials met with KKK representatives in Atlanta to secure a nonaggression pact: the KKK agreed not to harass NOI members in exchange for the NOI’s commitment to oppose civil rights integration. The NOI even hosted American Nazi Party founder George Lincoln Rockwell at a 1961 rally in Washington, DC, where he donated \$20 and received applause, and then invited him to address their 1962 Savior’s Day convention in Chicago before over 12,000 attendees. These episodes are not historical curiosities.

They are the logical outcome of a politics organized around racial awakening rather than universal interests. When both sides define belonging by racial consciousness and reject the premise of a shared political community across racial lines, they end up agreeing on the fundamental point: separation. The content differs, but the *form* overlaps.

This also illustrates the **self-marginalizing** tendency that is inherent to consciousness-first politics, which I discussed at length in Part 1. Black nationalism, as a political project in a country where Black people are not the demographic majority, was structurally incapable of building the kind of broad coalition required to win durable political power. It could generate fervor, cultural pride, and a sense of solidarity within the in-group, but it could not, *by design*, expand beyond it. This is the same self-contained opposition that plagues all forms of woke politics: when a movement is predicated on enough people “waking up” to a certain consciousness, and when that group’s consciousness is defined in terms that most of the population cannot or will not adopt, the movement’s ceiling is built into its premises. White nationalism faces an analogous problem in an increasingly diverse society, and even historically it was never the powerful unifying force its advocates imagined, because whites themselves were deeply divided by religion, ethnicity, and class. Colorism, as a political foundation, simply never generated durable mass movements, because a construct without a material basis cannot sustain the kind of thick solidarity that real political power requires.

Why “Intersectionality” Fails

The Combahee River Collective, the Black lesbian feminist socialists who coined “**identity politics**” in the 1970s, argued that liberation required simultaneous awakening to interwoven oppressions of race, gender, and *class*, which are treated as separate categories that often intersect. Many leftists who avoid confronting the reality of wokeism like to distinguish the kind of mainstream liberal identity politics of today with the kind of real “grassroots” identity politics advanced by the Combahee River Collective (CRC). They call it “**intersectionality**.” Let’s dismantle intersectionality for a second, because this logic is one of the roadblocks to getting leftists to seriously think about the problem. While the CRC in some ways avoided the trap of woke politics, as it acknowledged class and strove for a socialist politics open to coalitions between different identity groups, the framework of “intersectionality” has many problems that still hinder leftist movements today.

While intersectionality, which, at least when it adds class to the equation, may be well-intentioned and tries to be more “radical” than liberal identity politics, it nevertheless, by design, leaves itself very easily *prone* to co-option and self-marginalization. This is because by treating race, class and gender as separate but interconnected categories of equal importance, intersectionality ends up *reifying* race and gender, which are ultimately consciousness-based identities, whereas **class is the only category in this equation that is grounded in real social relations and shared material interests**.

This is why intersectionality, while being useful from the standpoint of academic research or demographic research, rarely ever works when it comes to politics, as its unifying pretense ends up fracturing into identity-based divisions in practice. This is because the core premise of its equation is *wrong*. Race and gender, at least nowadays, *do not* always intersect with class, and when shared experience of “oppression” is the common denominator of an intersectional coalition instead of shared *class interests*, there is no substantive *glue* holding the coalition together. Every political movement needs a **power bloc** to succeed in advancing its agenda, just enough votes to win. For bourgeois establishment politics, it is

different blocks of big business industries and corporate lobbyists at the front, followed by constituent groups like bureaucratic elites and political insiders. For anti-establishment politics like social democracy, socialism, communism, or populist communitarianism, the basis of political power is usually the working class and other classes and strata closer to it, like small business owners, farmers, well-paid professionals, managers, and occasional wealthy class traitors who believe in the cause.

Unlike the labor movement or socialist class coalitions, actually existing intersectional politics (which often gets described as a “rainbow coalition”) manifests as a “popular front of the vulnerable” held together by nothing other than a shared identity of being “oppressed” as opposed to an “oppressor.” It is a coalition based solely on **ideology**, and due to being driven by symbolic capitalists, it gets tied up in the **woke** mode.

Without clear shared material interests holding this vague intersectional coalition together, it becomes very easy for political parties, corporate structures, and elite institutions to pit these groups against each other. A working-class white man does not share many common interests with an upper-middle-class white woman. An upper-class black person has very different economic interests from a working-class black person. Without a power bloc independent from the corporate establishment, those trying to advance intersectionality desperately try to appeal to political elites and work with corporate PR boards and elite institutions like academia.

This dependence on elite institutions raises a prior question: what produced the class of people who populate those institutions in the first place, and why does their political style diverge so sharply from the working class they claim to represent? The answer lies in one of the most consequential but least discussed class divides in contemporary politics: the education divide.

The Education Divide: The Hidden Class Divide

The massive expansion of higher education, from 4.6% of U.S. adults holding a bachelor's degree in 1940 to 37.6% by 2022, created a much larger PMC than ever before. With this expanded educated class, there's a substantial class of people whose primary asset is their education and cultural sophistication. For this expanded PMC, wokeism serves multiple functions. It provides a sense of moral purpose that transcends their often meaningless corporate jobs. It offers a way to differentiate themselves from both the working class (who lack the education to master woke discourse) and the capitalist class (who supposedly lack the moral sophistication to care). It creates new professional opportunities in diversity, equity, and inclusion. The PMC's embrace of wokeism helps explain why the movement has been so successful in capturing institutions while failing to achieve grander political change.

The difference between a worker with a college degree and a worker without one is significant for a simple reason: **social mobility**. Even if a garbage truck driver earns more income than a barista struggling to balance university and work, the difference is that the university-educated barista probably will not be a barista in the future. A worker without a

college degree will likely remain in the industry they are in, with minimal chances of climbing the social hierarchy. While it might seem like many university degrees are more “useless” today, university credentials are in fact strongly correlated with higher incomes, social mobility, and even mating prospects. Even the most well-paid blue-collar professions, like plumbing or working in the fossil fuel industry, still carry less **prestige** than a random white-collar office job that requires a university degree to obtain. It could be a bullshit job with a sophisticated name like “consultant,” but it would probably still sound more impressive to your spouse’s parents than cleaning toilets or tables. The degree also carries extra *cultural capital* and can come with network connections that further enhance job prospects.

But during cycles of high unemployment and elite overproduction, class conflict manifests quite differently among PMC aspirants, especially those whose primary skill is *language*, not their hands. This is why class conflict today is confusing for many leftists to understand. What might be an objective class issue for blue-collar workers without degrees (like immigration, or revolt against educated PMCs trying to lecture them about white supremacy and patriarchy) might not seem like a problem at all to a cosmopolitan PMC. What might seem like a real class issue for a PMC (like representation of women, transgender people, and minorities in elite positions) might seem like a first-world problem to workers at the bottom.

It is tempting to conclude from this pattern that the remedy is simply to expand higher education further, on the premise that more credentials produce more rational, clear-eyed citizens and thus better politics. This assumption flatters the PMC worldview and has long served as a convenient justification for the credentialing economy, but the woke educated class is, as it turns out, the strongest argument against its own premise.

Yet this embrace of wokeism by the highly educated reveals a profound irony. Al-Gharbi documents what he calls the “curse of knowledge”: contrary to their self-image as rational, evidence-based thinkers, the highly educated are often more susceptible to cognitive biases, not less. Their intellectual sophistication makes them more adept at motivated reasoning, allowing them to skillfully rationalize their pre-existing beliefs and partisan loyalties. As psychologist Keith Stanovich observes, “If you are a person of high intelligence... you will be even less likely than the average person to realize that you have derived your beliefs from the social groups you belong to.”^[23] The evidence suggests that “far from being independent thinkers... symbolic capitalists are instead more likely than most to be dogmatic ideologues or partisan conformists.”^[24] This explains why wokeism flourishes most intensely in precisely those institutions that pride themselves on critical thinking: the very skills that could enable genuine reflection instead become tools for more sophisticated self-deception.

This is also why symbolic capitalists, whose livelihoods depend on the manipulation of symbols, discourse, and prestige, are especially prone to overestimating the power of consciousness itself and to mistaking symbolic revision for structural change.

Universities and Cultural Transmission

Universities have become the camp meetings of contemporary wokeism. Just as the Great Awakenings led to the founding of numerous colleges (Princeton, Brown, Dartmouth, Rutgers), contemporary wokeism has transformed existing educational institutions into centers of ideological formation and activism. It is well known that universities play an integral role in the proliferation of progressive “woke” ideology. However, many people on the right make the mistake of attributing a consistent ideological doctrine to this “woke” tendency in universities, often mashing together very different tendencies like postmodernism and postcolonialism with neo-Marxism. The role universities play in the facilitation of these woke tendencies is more **sociological** than ideological. Universities are a training ground for the Professional Managerial Class rather than the incubators of Marxist revolutionaries.

The early protestant great awakenings were bottom-up moral mobilization, messy, ecstatic, and often led by outsiders. In contrast, the modern great “awakenings” come out of an institutional pipeline, more precisely, a product of an imbalance in that institutional pipeline (elite overproduction). It is staffed by administrators, mediated by credentials, reinforced by HR logic, and transmitted through the symbolic industries that shape prestige, language, and reputation. This is why the progressive variant of wokeism feels less like a mass revival than a top-down cultural regime. It is not emerging primarily from the dispossessed. It is being curated, refined, and circulated by the very strata whose careers depend on controlling the production of symbols.

Woke Capitalism and Institutional Adoption

A degree from an elite university increasingly signals **cultural capital**. Language and concepts like intersectionality, diversity, and *awareness* of injustice become markers of educational sophistication, creating a new form of cultural capital that can be exchanged for professional and social advancement.

Those who are on the more precarious side of the PMC often adopt woke sensibilities because it will give them a cultural capital advantage over the competition for scarce jobs in academia, the media, art, and entertainment, or conform to and/or avoid challenging woke discourses **out of necessity** to avoid risking career prospects. With deindustrialization and economic crashes **intensifying competition for white-collar jobs** in a slowing economy, *PMC aspirants* become ever more careful to conform to the expected speech codes and etiquette of the PMC *habitat*.

Corporations, however, adopt “woke” language and sensibilities for slightly different reasons than the PMC symbolic capitalists who work for them do.

The speed with which corporations adopted woke rhetoric reveals something important about the nature of consciousness politics: it’s far easier to change language than to change material conditions. A company can update its mission statement, add pronouns to email signatures, and mandate DEI training far more easily than it can raise wages, improve working conditions, or share profits with workers.

Does this mean that wokeism failed because it was “co-opted”? No. This would miss the entire point. As we showed in the part 1 essay, wokeism already emerged as an intra-elite competition as a result of elite overproduction in the first place. So the idea that elites defeated “the real movement” by co-opting what was ostensibly a radical “stay woke” movement with real potential is simply a delusion. In reality, the movements that became associated with wokeism **failed due to the internal contradictions of the woke mode of politics itself.**

Why Woke Politics Fails: Self-Contained Opposition

Again, as I showed in Part 1, this does not mean that race or gender issues are inherently bounded to the woke mode of politics. The Civil Rights movement didn’t believe it had to brainwash white people into being less racist in order for blacks to fight for racial equality. They aimed for political change, desegregation, equal political rights, and anti-discrimination laws. When the political rights were guaranteed, what civil rights leaders like Martin Luther King Jr. believed was that the next obstacle to be overcome was not “deconstructing whiteness” and “heteronormativity” but rather to improve the **economic conditions** of black people and the working class, subject to wage slavery **in general**. The idea was that desegregation, integration, and anti-discrimination laws would eventually help normalize relations between black and white Americans over time as they were able to interact in society together. Put simply, the transformation in consciousness (reducing racism) **was expected to occur after** the transformation in political structures and socio-economic conditions. **The woke approach gets this backwards because it starts from the opposite premise.**

Nevertheless, by the 1990s, there was a sense that racism was on its way out. But the fourth great awakening (discussed in Part 1), following the consequences of elite overproduction resulting from the 2008 economic depression, changed all of this, and brought a rise of heated racial culture wars discourses that people are still reacting to today. The lesson of all of this is that identity politics does not fail because identity issues don’t matter but rather because the woke approach suffers from its own anti-political tendency that prioritizes the cultivation of consciousness before a change in conditions.

Even if advocates of woke politics claim to want real material change, the woke mode of politics reaches a point of oversaturation and undermines itself after being limited by its own self-marginalizing tendency, relegating it to **self-contained opposition**. The woke disposition treats awakening to the “right” consciousness as the precondition for political solidarity and the basis of political movements. Woke people operate from the presumption that “if everyone thought the way I do, then the world would be a better place.” **This makes it inherently exclusionary and self-limiting.**

A social movement will fail to resonate with the **broader demos** if it is centered around representing racially essentialized identity groups who are assumed to possess a particular radical form of consciousness, rather than on common goals and universal interests that a broad enough group of people has an interest in supporting. The focus of these kinds of

woke-captured social movements tends to revolve around changing attitudes, language, and **the way people talk about things**, rather than building coalitions of various groups of people who may have many disagreements but nonetheless share some common goals and interests. The woke conception of politics simply **doesn't work**, especially with a large diverse population and a relatively liberal democratic society. There are hard limits to how many minds you can change and how many people you can get on board with a naturally minoritarian cause.

Without a mass democratic power base, elite capture becomes inevitable. **As a result, the best-case scenario for advocates of woke politics is to lobby elite politicians and institutions to try to get them to adopt some of their ideas and policies.** However, as we have seen with the success of woke politics of the liberal-progressive activist variety, what ends up happening is that they are able to achieve some degree of “progress” without winning approval from the majority of citizens. Yet, this progress is dependent on the will of opportunistic interest groups with different class interests, who can easily dispense with this progress if it no longer suits their interests. This is precisely what happened with woke politics: those who were able to push universities, corporations, and politicians to adopt certain progressive policies (DEI, etc.) achieved change that was ultimately precarious because it lacked a democratic foundation.

The advertising industry has played a parallel role in spreading woke consciousness to the broader culture. Woke capitalism, the adoption of social justice rhetoric by corporations, represents not a genuine commitment to social change but a recognition that consciousness signaling has market value.

This created a feedback loop that embedded wokeism in the economy itself. Universities produce woke consciousness in students, corporations market to that consciousness with woke advertising, media reinforces that consciousness with woke content, and institutions validate it through diversity programs. The result is consciousness politics as consumer lifestyle, wokeism as brand identity that you can buy your way into.

None of this is conspiratorial. It is path dependence. Institutions adopt scripts that promise order, legitimacy, and reputational safety, even when they redistribute neither power nor wealth.

3. Conclusion

Wokeism, despite its fanatically radical moral posturing, is **functionally conservative in practice**. At best, it changes symbols and not structures, and at worst, it ensures that political activism becomes **self-contained opposition**. It does not challenge material conditions; it merely reshapes the discourse around them to make some people **_feel good_** while encouraging resentment among others.

It replaces collective struggle with personal virtue-signaling. And in doing so, it diverts energy away from real political action and into performative self-flagellation. The endless cycles of

denunciation, confession, and absolution substitute for the difficult work of building political power and changing material structures.

The pseudo-radicalism of wokeism serves a structurally conservative function. Since a leftist revolution is not imminent, it is often the case that “radical leftist” pseudo-revolutionary posturing that denounces any gradual reformist change functionally allows symbolic capitalists to righteously condemn the system while continuing to benefit from it, dismissing any practical reforms as pointless tinkering. The result is a politics that sounds revolutionary while changing nothing. As Barbara Fields observed, race itself becomes a tool that “richly serves the interests of the powers that be,” not because minorities invented the framework, but because elite institutions find it far easier to redistribute symbols than to redistribute wealth.^[25]

You cannot awaken your way to universal healthcare. You cannot consciousness-raise your way to affordable housing. You cannot cancel your way to economic justice. History does not change when people have the right thoughts; it changes when people act, and it is far more realistic to get people to act and build coalitions based on mutual interests rather than political alignment alone.

This genealogy, from evangelical revivalism through secularized consciousness-raising to institutional capture, reveals the deep structure beneath the surface of contemporary woke politics. But identifying the historical roots of the problem is only the first step. The deeper question is what comes next. Are we entering a post-woke age? If so, what is replacing wokeism, and why do so many left responses to its decline keep repeating the same mistakes? In Part 3, I turn to the state of wokeism today: whether wokeism is “dead” ever since the “vibe shift” following Trump’s re-election in 2024, the supposedly “post-woke” shift taken by figures like Zohran Mamdani and AOC, and how AI-induced job loss could potentially trigger a fifth great awakening. Read [Part 3 of the Genealogy of Wokeism here](#).

Part 3 - A Post-Woke Age?

The Future of Wokeism

This is **Part 3** of my *Genealogy of Wokeism* Essay series (not including my [Anti-Social Socialists](#) essay, which is separate but related). In Part 1, I established the definition: wokeism is a post-materialist, **consciousness-first** style of politics that presupposes that the awakening of a correct consciousness is the prerequisite for political solidarity and political action. A fundamental tendency of the **woke mentality** and the woke approach to socio-political change is assuming that the masses must be *re-educated* and awakened to (or simply made to conform to) a set of correct ideas, rather than building movements by meeting people halfway. While wokeism is most prevalent among left-wing spaces, it is not exclusive to them, nor are all left-wingers “woke” in the sense that I define it. What defines wokeism is not a coherent doctrine or ideology, but rather a consciousness-first **mode** of

socio-political thinking, marked by a particular *mentality* and approach to thinking about change and justice. Woke people carry a distinct type of attitude that you can identify and discern from non-woke people, regardless of whether they are left or right.

Wokeism is a mindset and **mode** of approaching socio-political change that envisions radical change as a process of gradual consciousness-raising, **culminating in a cultural revolution that later manifests as a political one**. It prioritizes shared consciousness over shared class interests. Wokeism is linked to things like cancel culture, political correctness, and language policing because what defines wokeism at its core is the commitment to wake people by changing their thoughts, which is seen as a prerequisite to political solidarity and social change. This is why people in woke-dominated spaces are obsessed with demonstrating one's own virtue and with politically correct signs (*language*, etiquette, attitudes, etc.) rather than with objective shared interests, regardless of **political disagreement**.

The tendency of woke people to be especially *intolerant* of views they disagree with, and the recurring behavioral tendencies in woke people, all start to make sense once you get to **the root of what woke thinking** is based on. The **woke approach** to socio-political action **presupposes that mass awakening to a new sensibility is necessary before radical change is possible**. Central to the woke mentality is the underlying assumption **that cultural change must precede political change, and that enough people must** wake up to a set of new sensibilities that the woke people in question assume are politically correct in order for the social change they want to see to manifest. Wokeism is a barrier to mass politics, which is why I think it should be of concern to leftists, especially those who believe in a class-first anti-establishment politics, which requires a mass base. It is often the case that woke people are not interested in large-scale political change at all, or are not serious about it, and are more interested in *social change*, hence why woke people tend to get associated with "social justice warriors." This is part of why a large part of Part 1 (especially the end) is devoted to the "anti-political" tendency in woke thinking, which is one of the most interesting paradoxes about it, given that it often appears to involve the *hyperpoliticization of everything*.

The "woke people" usually come from a similar habitat. They are usually college-educated and are socialized to be aspirants of the Professional Managerial Class, particularly the *symbolic capitalists* in academia, media, art, entertainment, and the legal sector. Drawing on American sociologist Musa Al-Gharbi's pincer-like, well-researched book *We Have Never Been Woke*, in Part 1, I showed how the primary carriers of wokeism are the "symbolic capitalists," the stratum of the professional managerial class whose work involves the production and manipulation of discourse, rhetoric, and cultural meaning, and demonstrated that these *awakenings* erupt cyclically during periods of **elite overproduction**.

In Al-Gharbi's framework, an awakening does not arise merely because bad ideas spread through elite institutions. It emerges when a society produces more credentialed elite aspirants than the available elite positions can absorb, especially in *symbolic-capitalist* fields like academia, media, art, entertainment, law, nonprofits, HR, publishing, and the broader institutions that manufacture discourse. That is why AI matters for this essay: if AI collapses

the credential hedge that once made STEM, law, consulting, and other white-collar professions seem safer than the humanities, it could intensify a new crisis of *elite overproduction* across a much wider class terrain.

In Part 2, I traced the historical genealogy of this consciousness-first template, from its origins in American evangelical Protestant revivalism through its secularization in the consciousness-raising movements of the 1960s and 1970s, the rise of identity politics and intersectionality, and its institutional capture through universities, corporations, and the expanding professional managerial class. That genealogy revealed how a style of politics organized around *awakening, conversion, and the policing of belief* became embedded in American political culture, and why it has proven so effective at **capturing institutions while so incapable of delivering material change**.

In this installment, I turn from genealogy to diagnosis. If the consciousness-first template has exhausted itself, what comes next? What is replacing wokeism, and what structural conditions are producing a potential new *awakening* cycle? To answer these questions, I examine the current crisis of woke politics, the structural conditions producing a potential Fifth Awakening, and the return of class politics across both left and right. I also examine whether the right produces its own version of the woke dynamic, and what the return of class-centered populism on both sides of the political spectrum actually amounts to when examined structurally. The strategic question, what a genuinely post-woke left politics actually requires and why the answer is not agnostic tolerance of the woke tendency but its outright rejection, is taken up directly in the fourth and final installment of this series.

The Next Awakening

Are we entering a “post-woke” age? Is wokeism finally dead? The signs of *wokeism’s exhaustion* are everywhere: corporate DEI retreats, public backlash against cancel culture, and institutional fatigue with constant consciousness policing.^[26] The signs of this rupture did not begin with corporate DEI rollbacks or public fatigue with cancel culture, however. They were visible as early as the COVID-19 pandemic, which produced one of the starkest real-time illustrations of **the class divide between the symbolic-capitalist left and the working majority**. The “*laptop left*,” those whose professional lives could be conducted from home without disruption, aligned culturally and politically with extended lockdowns, remote-work mandates, and a public health apparatus administered overwhelmingly by credentialed professionals with no material stake in whether or not the broader economy remained open. The people who disagreed were not primarily anti-science reactionaries. They were workers whose livelihoods depended on showing up. When Canadian truck drivers organized the convoy of early 2022, a bottom-up populist protest against pandemic mandates that had been partially co-opted by the right and drew sympathy from a substantial minority of Canadians frustrated with pandemic restrictions, the symbolic-capitalist left’s response was near-unanimous condemnation. Whatever one thinks of the convoy’s politics, the left’s reflexive opposition revealed something structurally important: the woke class habitus does not merely produce bad ideology in the abstract. It produces immediate, practical decisions

about **whose concerns count as legitimate grievances and whose do not**. The same class contempt was briefly suspended during the pandemic itself, when the symbolic-capitalist strata were forced to acknowledge that the economy ran on the labor of people they had spent years dismissing as “low-skilled.” Grocery workers, delivery drivers, construction crews, and healthcare aides were briefly celebrated as “essential workers.” The celebration lasted until the economy reopened. Then the language reverted, almost without comment, to the familiar vocabulary of low-skill, low-status, and low-priority. That reversion was not incidental. It was a precise expression of the class order that a working-class politics must challenge.^[27]

The exhaustion of the Fourth Awakening’s cultural causes has reinforced this rupture rather than healing it. DEI programs, once absorbing overproduced elites into institutional sinecures, are being dismantled by corporate rollbacks and executive orders. The LGBTQ liberation framework, which drove much of the symbolic politics of the last cycle, has largely saturated its practical legislative content. The question of what it means to be liberated *from* in 2026, when same-sex marriage is legally settled and the remaining frontier is compelled affirmation of contested gender metaphysics, is one that even the woke coalition struggles to answer coherently. The trans youth issue, pushed to the front of symbolic-capitalist progressive politics in the early 2020s, proved too fringe even within that coalition to sustain. This exhaustion is not merely a sign of defeat. It is a **structural forcing mechanism**, displacing symbolic-capitalist political energy toward new terrain that could prove either better or worse depending on what that terrain turns out to be.^[28]

As I showed throughout the **Part 1 *Genealogy of Wokeism*** essay, there is a structural reason why the Fourth Awakening proved more damaging to left politics than the earlier cycles. In the first and second awakenings, the symbolic-capitalist tendency operated alongside a functioning class-based left, a labor movement with genuine institutional weight and working-class accountability that could counterbalance the cultural politics of educated professionals. The bohemians and far-left outcasts actually **had to work with the working class** if they wanted their political agendas to go anywhere. During the first great awakening of the 1930s, many fallen professionals in PMC-symbolic capitalist industries (like art, entertainment, media, academia) gravitated to leftist politics, leading to the spread of communist and far-left ideologies in Hollywood prior to the McCarthy Red Scare. In his book *The Road to Wigan Pier*, George Orwell, an anti-fascist with strong socialist sympathies who spent a lot of time with working-class movements, was one of the first people to write about the disconnects between technocratic, middle-class/well-educated socialists and the working class following the managerial revolution I discussed in Part 1.

However, during this time, there was still a powerful labor movement (and a working-class civil rights movement) that the PMCs had to work with, meaning that they could not define the politics of the left by making it all about their fringe, culturally far-left concerns. This changed significantly by the second awakening of the 1960s, as the labor movement declined and education greatly expanded, producing much higher elite-aspirant expectations and a stark educational divide in how people voted. By the time the Fourth Awakening of the

2010s arrived, there was no powerful working-class movement or socialist movement force to counterbalance the PMC symbolic capitalists, who held a hegemonic grip on the politics that defined the left. The collapse of union density, the complete capture of left-party structures by their professional-managerial strata, and the decline of any organized working-class presence within progressive coalitions meant that when the woke tendency expanded, **nothing checked it**. That is why it went further, lasted longer, and caused more damage than its predecessors: not because it was inherently more powerful, but because the *institutional counterweights* that had contained the earlier cycles no longer existed.

The Vibe Shift

Many say woke peaked in 2018, but I think that is only half true. The pandemic lockdowns and the 2020 BLM protests gave wokeism one final surge. COVID exposed the class divide with unusual clarity: the *PMC laptop left* could work from home, and were more likely to support extended lockdowns, vaccine mandates, mask mandates, and oppose re-opening the economy to go back to normal, while the producer class, service workers, truckers, tradespeople, and everyone whose livelihood required physical presence experienced the same politics as coercion administered by people with no material stake in reopening the world.

Biden's victory changed the atmosphere. Wokeism did not vanish after 2020, but it noticeably died down because the more successful wing of the liberal-left symbolic class was partially absorbed back into the state, the NGO world, consulting, DEI administration, media, and the broader machinery of respectable Democratic governance. The old joke that liberals went back to brunch was not wrong, but it also applied to many leftists and left-of-center symbolic capitalists who pivoted from denouncing the status quo to defending the Democrats in the name of fighting the right. **When enough elite aspirants are absorbed into the apparatus, the moral temperature of woke politics drops, because the overproduction pressure has been temporarily relieved.**

This is not new. As I argued in Part 1, the Third Awakening faded partly because the Clinton era absorbed liberal-left professionals into the expanding world of education, NGOs, policy work, media, and professional administration. Clintonism treated education and credentialing as the solution to the social wreckage left by Reagan-era restructuring, but that solution also planted the seeds of the next crisis by overproducing graduates whose expectations could not survive the jobless recovery after 2008. The system solved one elite-overproduction problem by manufacturing the next one.

This also helps explain why anti-woke politics became less electorally potent around 2022 and 2023. Ron DeSantis and many Republicans tried to turn anti-wokeness into a self-sufficient political program, but the strategy did not work as well as they expected. People still disliked wokeism, but once the immediate frenzy had begun to recede, anti-wokeness alone could not substitute for a politics of wages, housing, inflation, immigration, and social order. The public was annoyed by wokeism, but irritation is not the same thing as a governing program.

Then Trump returned, and the woke reflex briefly came crawling back out of the walls. Liberal and left-wing media tried to rerun the same script in 2024: Project 2025, fascism, abortion, race, gender, identity, January 6, and the permanent emergency of Trump. But the script was overwhelmingly PMC-coded. Kamala Harris did not convincingly speak to the issues that voters actually ranked highest: inflation, cost of living, immigration, war, male alienation, and the sense that the Biden administration had become a failed status quo. Her decision to campaign with Liz Cheney only reinforced the image of a liberal establishment trying to defeat populism by embracing the old neoconservative center. Trump, for all his failures and obvious fraudulence, at least pretended to care about immigration, war, and economic nationalism.^[29]

The scale of Trump's 2024 victory produced the actual *vibe shift*. Many liberals had convinced themselves that January 6, criminal charges, scandal, and Trump's first term made his return impossible. Instead, he won more decisively than he had in 2016, including the popular vote, and the shock forced corporations, liberal parties, and the managerial class to recognize that woke politics had become a liability rather than a free status signal. Corporate DEI retreated, Meta repositioned itself around free expression and loosened content restrictions, tech executives tried to rebrand themselves in a more Rogan-friendly register, pronoun discourse became less fashionable, and liberal parties in countries like Canada and Britain began moderating on immigration and gender. Even AOC's disappearing pronouns became a minor symbol of the shift, precisely because people were looking for signs that the old language had lost its magic.^[30]

The people who noticed first were not usually the leftists. They were business elites and liberal parties, the very people whose job is to sense which moral costumes are still profitable. The left was slower because its media ecosystem is dominated by symbolic capitalists who mistake the etiquette of their own niche class world for universal morality. But just as this post-woke atmosphere was taking shape, another structural force arrived: AI. ChatGPT began as a novelty in 2022 and 2023, but by late 2024 and especially 2025 and 2026, frontier models like ChatGPT and Claude had become dramatically more capable, while image and video generation made a qualitative leap. Whether or not there is an AI bubble, and whether or not companies exaggerate the efficiency gains, the basic fact is no longer theoretical: one worker with AI can increasingly do the work that once required several. That means real job loss, foregone hiring, and a new kind of white-collar panic.

AI and The Fifth Awakening

Any serious attempt to predict how AI-driven displacement might generate a new awakening cycle must begin by disaggregating two effects that are easy to conflate but analytically distinct: the immediate shock of job loss and the longer-term, more insidious dynamic of *disappointed professional expectation*. Immediate unemployment is real, and the protests and legal challenges it generates are already visible, from the Hollywood writers and actors strikes of 2023 to the wave of class-action lawsuits brought by artists and journalists against AI companies for the unauthorized use of their work.^[31] But the person who loses their job

tomorrow is not, historically, the paradigmatic agent of an awakening cycle. What generates *the awakening* is something more chronic: the accumulation of credentialed people who did everything that was expected of them educationally, who anticipated being absorbed into the professional life their degrees promised, and who find instead that **the positions are simply not materializing**.

This distinction matters because it shapes the *tempo of politicization*, and tempo matters enormously for understanding how the cycle builds. Every economic downturn produces, eventually, a recovery, but the character of that recovery is as politically consequential as the crash itself. If the recovery is slow, if it creates positions that are precarious rather than secure, or if the professional market it reopens is structurally thinner than the credentialed population competing for it, you get the conditions Al-Gharbi identifies as the engine of awakening cycles (see [The Genealogy of Wokeism Part 1 for a summary of the prior four great awakenings](#)). By Q1 2026, the indicators were unambiguous: recent college graduates faced an unemployment rate of about 5.7% and an underemployment rate of 41.5%, still elevated by post-2008 standards,^[32] while Big Tech's hiring of new graduates had fallen by roughly 50% from pre-pandemic levels, with early-career workers in the most AI-exposed occupations experiencing a 16% relative employment decline in the Stanford/ADP payroll microdata.^[33] The paradigmatic figure this produces is not the newly unemployed but the PhD adjunct, someone who obtained the terminal credential, who is perpetually competing for a tenure-track position that may never materialize, and who, precisely while suspended in that holding pattern *between credential and career*, is the most vigorous producer of symbolic and totemic capital. The adjunct does not leverage victimhood as status currency out of cynicism. **It is simply the only leverage available in a professional world that has closed its doors.**

What is genuinely novel about the AI situation is that the population now facing this dynamic extends well beyond the traditional symbolic-capitalist fields where credential overproduction was already visible a decade ago. A decade ago, the rational response was to migrate toward Law, Business, or STEM, fields that seemed to offer the technical specificity and labor-market scarcity that would insulate against the dynamics already afflicting humanities graduates. What AI is now doing, structurally, is **collapsing that hedge**. The generation of students and early-career professionals who made the calculated decision to sidestep symbolic-capitalist overproduction by entering Law and STEM is discovering that the fields they entered in order to avoid precarity are now themselves generating it. Anthropic's CEO projected in May 2025 that AI could eliminate half of all entry-level white-collar positions within five years,^[34] Goldman Sachs Research estimated that 6 to 7% of the U.S. workforce faces meaningful displacement over the next decade, concentrated overwhelmingly in *white-collar knowledge work*.^[35] McKinsey's case should be stated more carefully: the firm has cut and considered cutting thousands of roles during the consulting slowdown, and by late 2025 had cut about 200 global tech jobs while reportedly assessing further AI-enabled reductions in non-client-facing functions, with parallel restructurings across the major consulting firms throughout the same period.^[36]

The political implications of this displacement diverge sharply, however, depending on whether one is looking at Law or STEM, because these two groups have a fundamentally different relationship to symbolic capital and, therefore, to the woke mode of politics. The professional power of the legal class is essentially *rhetorical and linguistic*: the manipulation of argument, precedent, and institutional authority through language. That is a form of symbolic production, and people trained in it are socialized in a cultural register that makes the status competition of woke discourse legible and usable as a mode of professional action. It is therefore predictable that lawyers facing displacement or underemployment would gravitate toward the woke-adjacent left, since that is the terrain on which their particular form of cultural capital can still be meaningfully deployed. **The rhetorical skills that law school cultivates are precisely the skills that symbolic politics rewards.** That the most AI-exposed women in the U.S. workforce are concentrated in exactly these clerical, administrative, HR, and symbolic-capitalist-adjacent roles only sharpens the point: Brookings Institution research published in 2026 found that of the 6.1 million workers characterized by both high AI exposure and low adaptive capacity, 86% are women, concentrated precisely in the credentialed professional occupations that were the primary beneficiaries of the DEI sinecures the post-2010 awakening produced.^[37] The last cycle's institutional outputs are themselves in the AI crosshairs.

STEM graduates represent a categorically different case, and the political implications of their displacement are genuinely open in a way that the Law case is not. Their professional identity is rooted not in the manipulation of language and institutional authority but in *building and deploying things that work*: technologies, systems, and processes whose validation is empirical rather than rhetorical. This orientation toward practical production means that engineers and scientists do not stand to benefit from woke politics in the same way that lawyers and academics do. The game of status competition through discourse, victimhood signaling, and moralized credentialing offers them very little, because their professional world does not operate through those mechanisms. They do not possess the cultural capital that makes symbolic politics advantageous, and they have no particular reason to acquire it.

Elite Overproduction in STEM

The evidence from 2024 to 2026 suggests that STEM workers' political loyalties are bifurcating rather than consolidating. Among the displaced credential classes, STEM workers, those trained in science, technology, engineering, and mathematics, are the most consequential and least politically predictable constituency. They are not natural recruits for woke politics, because their professional identity is built around making systems work, not performing moral fluency in the language of symbolic capital. That makes them a genuinely disorganized middle: politically unattached, anxious about job security, and open to whichever force can make a credible material case for their interests. A left that is led entirely by the Luddite wing of art, media, academia, and entertainment will not reach them. A left that can speak about technology, production, and ownership without sneering at technical competence might.

We have already seen how it is a problem for a political movement that presents itself as representing the interests of the working class to be represented almost entirely by PMCs, divorced from regular blue-collar workers. However, any political movement with mass appeal will still have to appeal to at least part of the PMC. The big problem with the Left since the 1960s is that the wing of the PMC that supports and dominates it tends to come primarily from symbolic-capitalist industries, whose members are socialized very differently than technical workers are. During the last awakening, from roughly 2012 to 2024, the socio-political division between symbolic-capitalist PMCs and the more practical, hands-on PMCs in tech grew even more pronounced, as left-liberal PMCs increasingly gravitated toward anti-scientific viewpoints that dismissed hard sciences like biology and evolutionary psychology in favor of limitless social constructivism and historicist relativism. The contradictions of this worldview crystallized during the COVID-19 pandemic, when many of the same people who rejected biological sex differences and dismissed so many issues as mere “social constructs” were suddenly screaming at everyone skeptical of lockdowns and vaccine mandates to “believe in science.”

The reason this matters is that STEM was supposed to be the escape hatch from symbolic-capitalist overproduction. Once the humanities, social sciences, media, academia, and cultural industries became visibly oversaturated, ambitious students were told to study computer science, engineering, data science, chemistry, biotechnology, or some other hard science if they wanted a stable, well-paying job. STEM was sold as the rational hedge against the precarity already eating through the humanities. But the hedge was weakening before AI arrived. Recent graduates were already facing elevated unemployment and underemployment, Big Tech had already begun pulling back on entry-level hiring, and many people with hard-science credentials were discovering that the credential could be monetized more easily outside the field than inside it.^[38]

I saw this dynamic in Canada before AI became the convenient explanation for everything. Friends who studied engineering, computer science, biotechnology, chemistry, and other hard sciences expected their degrees to translate into stable professional futures, only to struggle to find work in the fields they trained for. Some ended up in government jobs, some in unrelated administrative work, and some in finance. One friend who completed a PhD in chemistry at Columbia told me that it was common for people with prestigious science credentials to end up on Wall Street or in FIRE-sector jobs, not because finance was the natural fulfillment of their scientific training, but because there are simply more jobs in those sectors and elite credentials are portable signals of competence. A degree from a prestigious university, especially a PhD, tells employers that someone can handle complex problems, grind through difficult work, and operate at a high cognitive and professional level even when the field itself is unrelated. This is why degrees are a class category, not just educational certificates: they confer qualitative advantages in the labor market over other workers and mark their holders as a higher tier of labor.

AI intensifies this problem most obviously in software engineering and computer science. Coding was supposed to be one of the safest, most meritocratic career paths in the

credential economy. But AI coding tools now allow one programmer to do work that previously required multiple junior engineers, and Dario Amodei has predicted that AI could soon write the vast majority of code.^[39] Even if the prediction is exaggerated, the pressure is already real. I know people in the industry who feel it directly. A friend working in an AWS-related software-engineering role at Amazon describes the need to remain constantly productive and visibly useful, while also using Claude to perform large portions of the work. That is the structural paradox of AI at work: it helps the worker do the job, but in doing so it also teaches management that fewer workers may be needed.

This means there is an elite-overproduction crisis forming inside STEM itself. STEM workers are politically more unpredictable than symbolic capitalists because they are trained to build things that work rather than manipulate moral discourse. But they are now entering the same condition of frustrated credential expectation that has historically produced radicalization. And when STEM graduates cannot find work in the fields they trained for, many will continue to migrate into FIRE, consulting, or administrative-managerial sectors. The problem is that those sectors are also vulnerable to AI in analysis, modeling, compliance, risk assessment, contract review, and clerical work.

The FIRE Industries and Bullshit Jobs

The political consequences of AI's impact on the FIRE industries (Finance, Insurance, and Real Estate sectors) also present a distinct and unpredictable picture. A significant proportion of the jobs it contains fall into what the late David Graeber famously termed "*bullshit jobs*," positions whose social function is sufficiently opaque that even their occupants would struggle to justify their necessity. Whether the elimination of many of these positions through automation would constitute a genuine loss is, to say the least, debatable. What is less debatable is that the sector has so far proven more durable to AI displacement than many predicted, remaining one of the few labor markets still reliably absorbing credentialed graduates, including a substantial number from STEM and humanities fields who did not find positions in their trained areas. The finance route for the overeducated is a well-documented phenomenon. How long this durability holds is another question. AI is already demonstrably capable of performing significant portions of financial analysis, contract review, and risk modeling, and the possibility that a single employee with the right tools can now perform the work previously assigned to several is not hypothetical. The political implications of a disrupted FIRE sector are genuinely uncertain. Finance-credentialed workers displaced from their expected trajectories could move in almost any ideological direction: toward a structural critique of the order that rendered their training obsolete, or toward a right-wing politics of resentment organized around protecting the existing arrangements that once accommodated them. **They can really go either way.**

Blue Collar Workers and The Producer Class

Which returns us to the workers whose displacement AI is, at present, most conspicuously not producing: *the people who work with their hands*. By every credible measure, manual laborers in construction, skilled trades, healthcare assistance, and physical production face

among the lowest AI exposure of any major occupational category. In some ways, it may appear that the managerial revolution that began in the early 20th century is coming full circle. The working class whose interests the symbolic-capitalist left claimed to represent was, throughout the Fourth Awakening, the group most consistently harmed by the woke mode of politics: alienated by its cultural register, condescended to by its epistemic assumptions, and functionally ignored by its prioritization of symbolic recognition over material redistribution. Woke politics offered manual workers nothing because **symbolic capital, by definition, is a currency that people without access to the symbolic economy cannot accumulate**. The status competition conducted in the language of privilege, decolonization, and consciousness-raising accrues benefits only to those positioned to participate in it, and workers who build, repair, and produce things are not so positioned. ^[40]

What AI is now doing, in a profound structural irony, is reversing the class dynamics that the managerial revolution of the mid-twentieth century established. James Burnham's insight, that capitalism was evolving toward domination by managers and credentialed professionals rather than by either workers or traditional owners, held for roughly half a century. The explosion of higher education and the symbolic-capitalist economy created a vast professional-managerial stratum whose growing institutional dominance appeared to render the classical Marxist focus on the industrial working class increasingly obsolete as a political analysis. **AI is making the classical Marxist emphasis on the proletariat more plausible again, at least compared with the last half century**. As white-collar knowledge work becomes increasingly automatable and PMC sinecures contract, the social weight of people who do things that AI cannot, who assemble, build, maintain, drive, repair, and produce physical goods and services, grows correspondingly. The class that the symbolic-capitalist left spent twenty years talking past is, precisely in the AI era, becoming more socially necessary relative to the class that produced all the talking.

The most natural political coalition for this moment is not the PMC-led left formation of the prior cycle but what might be called the *producer class*: an alliance between wage workers and small business owners grounded in their shared relationship to actual production rather than to financial extraction or symbolic-capitalist discourse. Farmers, tradespeople, manufacturing workers, independent proprietors, and those who run small enterprises all share a material stake in a political economy **oriented toward production rather than speculation**, and a cultural stake in a politics that does not treat their occupations as staging grounds for condescension. This is not an unprecedented political vision. It has historical precedents in various social-democratic and national-populist formations. The PMC academic left tends to dismiss it as proto-fascist, because the producerist alliance cuts across the clean ideological categories that academic Marxism prefers. But producers, by virtue of their actual proximity to the working class, have a structural understanding of working-class life that neither the PMC left nor the STEM right possesses.

The political positioning available to such a coalition is, at this moment, unusually favorable. A right increasingly defined by ideological disorder and a left still associated in the public

imagination with cultural maximalism creates an opening for a politics that presents itself not as radical experiment but as restoration. The pro-labor left that could seize this moment would not position itself as the agent of transformation but as **the defender of order against the agents of chaos**: the force that takes seriously what most people actually care about, rather than the fixations that animated either the woke left or the neoreactionary right. This is not a posture of timidity.

AI Might Empower Blue-collar Labor, Depending on a Few Variables

The opportunity for the revival of working-class politics during this structural opening, however, is conditional. AI displacement of the PMC translates into working-class political empowerment **only if both conditions are present simultaneously**. The collapse of white-collar credential-based work creates elite overproduction and forces a political reckoning with PMC-dominated institutions. But if the resulting labor scarcity in manual sectors is neutralized by the same mechanism it has always been, the steady importation of **migrant labor at wages** below what organized workers could demand, the working class gains no leverage from it. Capitalist employers have consistently deployed this mechanism to undercut manual workers' bargaining power, whether through H-1B visa programs, through de facto tolerance of informal labor markets, or simply through the political pressure to keep migration rates high enough to ensure wage competition. There are, however, signs that the political conditions sustaining this migration regime are shifting in ways that may prove difficult to reverse. The public backlash against mass migration policies has reached a point in most Western countries, driven simultaneously by integration pressures, economic competition, and cultural concerns, where the old policy consensus can no longer be maintained by administrative inertia alone. Whether this translates into genuine bargaining leverage for manual workers, or merely into a politics of cultural resentment that leaves the underlying labor dynamics intact, remains to be seen. The historical pattern is instructive here: the Nordic model combines unusually high union density with immigration and integration regimes that have, in Denmark especially, moved sharply toward restriction and selectivity. A pro-labor politics that is serious about working-class wages cannot treat migration purely as a humanitarian question of openness while ignoring employers' interest in maintaining labor supply. **These are not separate issues. They are structurally linked.** The left that currently exists, still dominated by a PMC stratum with cultural and professional interests in cosmopolitan openness, lacks both the will and the working-class accountability to address this linkage honestly.^[41]

What AI-induced elite overproduction will force, whether the PMC-dominated left wants it or not, is a reckoning with the fact that the producer class and the manual working class matter more now than they have in decades, and that a politics organized around their concerns will look different from anything the symbolic-capitalist left has produced. The trucker convoy was a rough and politically ambiguous glimpse of this: a bottom-up assertion of working-class economic grievance that the symbolic-capitalist left reflexively opposed because it did not arrive in the approved ideological packaging. Future expressions of that same underlying energy may be less easily dismissed. **The left must decide whether it will build solidarity**

with workers without college degrees and reject the faux-progressivism of the PMC woke formation, or whether it will continue to speak on behalf of those workers while organizing entirely in their absence.

One further structural observation is worth making before the question of right-wing radicalism is addressed directly. *A new awakening cycle*, if and when it arrives, will almost certainly not announce itself with the vocabulary of the current one. The historical pattern is instructive here: the Third Awakening of the 1980s and 1990s produced the same underlying dynamics, symbolic-capitalist status competition, consciousness-raising demands, institutional capture by credentialed professionals, without using the word “woke” at all. Its operative term was “political correctness,” and those who embraced it on the left and scorned it on the right were, in their structural behavior, doing precisely what the participants in the Fourth Awakening did a generation later, under a different label. A Fifth Awakening driven by AI displacement would likely produce yet another vocabulary, one that allowed its participants to sincerely believe they were doing something categorically different from what their predecessors had done. This is already visible in miniature: a growing stratum of disaffected PMC aspirants has adopted Leninist and communist frameworks whose formal content is materialist but whose political posture is entirely consciousness-first, organized around an intellectually advanced vanguard tasked with awakening the masses to correct ideas before any serious political project can commence. None of these participants use the word “woke.” The structure is the same. **A Fifth Awakening could well identify itself as post-woke, while reproducing the essential features of the cycle it claims to have transcended.**

The Appeal of Neoreaction

The neoreactionary and accelerationist ideologies that have emerged from the right-leaning STEM and tech PMC, from Nick Land to Curtis Yarvin, represent a parallel symptom of the same underlying condition: elite overproduction generating politically radicalized, institutionally frustrated symbolic-capitalist aspirants who channel their resentment through ideological frameworks that give their frustration a grand civilizational narrative. These ideologies are, in their structure if not their content, downstream of the same dynamics that produced the woke left. Both are products of credentialed people who expected more from the institutional order than the institutional order was able to deliver, and who responded by building alternative status hierarchies around the most extreme and iconoclastic ideas available to them. The woke left built its status hierarchy around marginality, victimhood, and moral purity. The neoreactionary right built its around vitalism, hierarchy, and the fantasy of a competent elite unconstrained by democratic accountability. This structural parallel raises a question that the trilogy has gestured toward but not yet addressed directly.

It is worth being clear at this point, however, as the following section examines directly, that these right-wing ideologies, elitist, vanguardist, and contemptuous of democratic accountability as they are, do not constitute a *woke right* in the sense this trilogy defines. *Wokeism* is a *consciousness-first* mode of politics inexorably tied to *symbolic capitalism*: the sectors of art, media, entertainment, and academia are most susceptible to it precisely

because their entire enterprise is the production of discourse and symbolic meaning. Changing minds is their primary activity, and it is therefore also their primary political mode. The FIRE and STEM sectors produce their own elitist technocratic mentality: the conviction that a credentialed vanguard ought to exercise more authority than the lay masses or unenlightened elected representatives, but this does not manifest as consciousness-first politics. It does not primarily seek to awaken, convert, or police belief. It seeks, more directly, to acquire institutional power and exercise it. It is no less elitist for this distinction. It is arguably more dangerous in its frank embrace of hierarchy over persuasion. But it is a different phenomenon, and treating it as equivalent to wokeism blurs the very definition that makes the concept analytically useful.

Is there a Woke Right?

Whether there is a genuine “woke right” depends on how strictly one applies the definition this trilogy has used throughout. If wokeism is, at its core, a consciousness-first mode of politics premised on awakening the masses to correct ideas as the prerequisite for political action, then the answer is that the right, as a broadly reactive formation, **does not meet the criteria in any serious sense**. The nature of right-wing anti-woke politics is fundamentally reactive. It is defined almost entirely by what it opposes rather than by any coherent vision of what it seeks to awaken people to. There is no enforcement mechanism on the right comparable to the cancellation apparatus, no organizational culture of language policing, and no parallel pressure to publicly demonstrate ideologically correct consciousness before being permitted to participate in the movement. This asymmetry matters. It is why the woke tendency is a structural problem for the left in a way that has no direct right-wing equivalent: **consciousness-first politics produces internal disciplinary machinery**, and that machinery is what the left is currently choking on.

That said, there is a class of people on the right who operate on roughly equivalent symbolic-capitalist terrain, and whose political orientation is shaped by that terrain in ways that partly mirror the woke dynamic, even without its enforcement mechanism. Right-wing symbolic capitalists exist in media, law, marketing, and finance, and they tend to prioritize culture-war politics for the same structural reason that their left-wing counterparts do: symbolic politics is the terrain on which their particular form of capital is most advantageously deployed. The right fights the culture war in part because it is easy terrain on which to win, and those who benefit professionally from the fight have every incentive to exaggerate its stakes.

Right-wing symbolic capitalists capitalize, in the most direct sense, on the failures of their left-wing counterparts. They did not conjure the culture war from nothing. They inherited a politicized terrain that the woke left produced, and found it enormously useful. This is why criticizing right-wing anti-woke reaction without examining what it reacts to is not serious political analysis. Most people aren’t driven to the political right because they inherently love hierarchy and have an uncritical belief in the status quo. Most of the time, people who swing to the political right, particularly voters in elections who are often otherwise not that political, do so primarily due to what **they oppose on the other side**. Action precedes reaction. And

in this case, **the reaction was predictable. The production is what requires explanation.** For this reason, I don't like to spend much time and energy criticizing the political right, and if I did, I would mostly be preaching to the choir. If one wanted to "convert" right-wingers, then the way to do it wouldn't be to tirelessly convince them that the problems that alienate them from the left don't exist, but rather to focus on trying to **build a left that people actually want to be part of.**

It is tempting to try to fit a notion of "the woke right" into my theory of wokeism in order to simply get stubborn leftists to listen to it; however, trying to equivocate "both extremes" here does very little to help us understand the issues at hand. The more structurally interesting question is not whether a woke right exists in the left's image but whether right-wing elite overproduction generates its own distinctive form of ideological radicalism, one that functions analogously to woke leftism without reproducing its specific consciousness-policing forms. The answer is already visible in the essay's account of the Fifth Awakening. The appeal of neoreactionary "Dark Enlightenment" ideologies of Yarvin's monarchism and Land's accelerationism is, structurally, downstream of similar frustrated credential dynamics that produced woke leftism among humanities graduates. Both formations are built by people who expected more from the institutional order than it delivered, and who channeled that resentment into frameworks positioning a self-appointed vanguard as the bearer of truths the corrupt mainstream suppresses. The woke left framed this vanguard in the language of marginality and oppression; the neoreactionary right frames it in the language of hierarchy and civilizational vitality. The content is opposite. The structure is recognizably the same.

Curtis Yarvin's vision of Neoreaction (NRx) is kind of like ***Bolshevism for people with money***: a technocratic ideology for nerds who imagine themselves as enlightened trailblazers of progress. Where Leninism envisioned a dictatorship of the proletariat led by an intellectually advanced vanguard party, Yarvin envisions a CEO-monarch, an enlightened administrator who cuts through democratic dysfunction by virtue of competence unencumbered by popular accountability. The arguments these two traditions deploy in defense of dictatorship are, examined side by side, remarkably parallel in form, differing mainly in which class they imagine at the apex of the resulting order.

What this suggests is not that left and right are mirror images. They are not. But elite overproduction under conditions of credential saturation generates ideological radicalism across the political spectrum, and the specific form that radicalism takes depends on the symbolic-capitalist habitat in which it emerges. The humanities and social sciences produce woke leftism. The technical and financial PMC produces its techno-authoritarian counterpart. Both are products of **frustrated aspiration dressed in the grammar of civilizational emergency.**

Rise of Class Politics Across Left and Right

What's replacing woke politics? Increasingly, we're seeing **a return to class politics across both left and right.** Bernie Sanders's phenomenon represents the return of economic populism on the left. Trump's working-class appeal represents economic nationalism on the

right. This dimension of Trump's popularity is often not acknowledged by liberals and leftists who attribute it solely to cultural or aesthetic factors. However, if one examines the 2016 campaign, which was widely accepted as driven by anti-establishment sentiment, and the 2024 campaign, the most frequently cited reasons people voted the way they did were immigration and cost of living. Immigration is directly an economic issue. Donald Trump, whether or not his policies actually delivered results, promised to bring back jobs and industrialization. Restrictions on immigration may not affect PMC workers in high-skilled industries, but they directly affect workers without college degrees in blue-collar labor markets, where wage competition from cheaper labor is an immediate material concern rather than an abstract policy question.^[42]

Material concerns are reasserting themselves, with politicians across the political spectrum increasingly framing their appeal around *cost of living* and the populist conflict between *ordinary people and entrenched elites*. This resonates far more broadly than the woke narrative of the *oppressed versus the oppressors*, whose ill-defined categories float amorphously, perpetually contested as movements dispute who is most oppressed and most deserving of political priority. This return to material politics does not mean the concerns that motivated wokeism disappear. Women still experience real issues that require particular attention. Trans people are still more likely to experience violence, discrimination, and serious issues with mental illness. But the question is: what do we actually do to make all of these problems better without making *them worse* by fostering reaction and resentment? Merely changing the way people talk about these issues will not address these problems. A class-centered economic program that addresses the *common concerns* that people from all these groups share would do far more to address problems and build solidarity than whatever the woke left has done so far. And no, the answer is not another *rainbow coalition* again, which keeps failing because it tries to build a popular front around *minoritarian concerns*, surface-level solidarity between identity groups unified by nothing other than a personal ideological (rather than material) claim to victimhood and vulnerability. This means putting class issues front and center, appealing to **objective common interests**, rather than merely adding class to the equation at the level of rhetoric, like “intersectionality” discourses tend to do.

Don't Mess With The Zohran

The clearest sign of a post-woke shift toward class-first politics is Zohran Mamdani's 2025 campaign for mayor of New York City. Mamdani demonstrates that *elite-aspirant energy*, the same overproduced symbolic-capitalist disaffection that drove the prior wave of awakening, can be channeled into a **non-woke, cost-of-living-focused politics** rather than inevitably reproducing the consciousness-policing tendencies of the Fourth Awakening. His campaign focused primarily on housing, rent control, and the cost-of-living crisis facing New Yorkers across every demographic rather than on the symbolic-recognition politics that dominated the prior cycle. This is, by the standards of recent left politics, a genuine improvement.^[43]

The critical warning, however, is embedded in the electoral data. Mamdani won the Democratic primary convincingly and went on to win the general election in November 2025. But the electoral data embedded in that victory is more instructive than the headline result. He lost the vote of blue collar workers, and the votes of people without college degrees in general. According to CNN exit polling, Mamdani won 57% of voters with a college degree, compared to 47% of voters without one.^[44] His [geographic base was concentrated in gentrified professional-class neighborhoods](#) like Park Slope, Greenpoint, and parts of northern Manhattan, while Cuomo held stronger support in parts of the outer boroughs. In the Democratic primary, Cuomo outperformed Mamdani decisively in the Bronx, and exit polling showed that Cuomo outperformed Mamdani among voters at both extremes of the income distribution, including those earning under \$30,000 a year.^[45] **I do not bring up the class gap in Mamdani's coalition** to dismiss him or his ideas, but as a demographic signal worth taking seriously. [Peter Turchin recently analyzed Mamdani's victory in even greater empirical detail](#). The fact that a democratic socialist running a cost-of-living platform whose actual electoral base skews toward the college-educated and newly arrived, rather than toward the lifelong working-class New Yorkers his program is ostensibly designed to serve, **is a clear indication that the left's problem with being unable to sufficiently reach the working class is far from resolved**. This is significant given that Mamdani's entire campaign was premised on uplifting the working class, yet even he could not win over the working-class vote against a highly unpopular, scandal-plagued candidate. The most plausible explanation has less to do with Mamdani himself than with the people who campaign on his behalf, who tend overwhelmingly to come from university-educated, PMC, symbolic-capitalist backgrounds, and whose cultural register is precisely what prevents the message from penetrating the communities it is ostensibly designed to reach.

Part of that structural obstacle is the nature of Mamdani's own coalition. His campaign was driven overwhelmingly by the New York DSA, an organization composed mainly of college students, adjunct professors, and social outcasts that still has a tendency to practice the kind of "woke" tendencies that make working-class people cringe. This is the *organizational culture* highlighted in years' worth of satirical memes about socialist conference dysfunction, the "point of privilege" interruptions, the mask mandate debates, the pronoun fights and procedural chaos that became shorthand for everything ordinary working people find alienating about the contemporary left.^[46] The people who built Mamdani's campaign are, organizationally, the same people who built the woke politics this essay has diagnosed throughout. That they channeled their energy into something more materially serious in this instance is encouraging. That **the underlying sociology has not changed** is the caveat that any serious assessment must hold onto.

Mamdani's own background is worth dwelling on, because it is instructive about what the next wave of progressive politics might look like and why the essay has given him as much attention as it has. His profile is, in many respects, a textbook case of the symbolic-capitalist aspirant this trilogy has described throughout: *a child of the global cultural elite*, raised across multiple countries, multilingual, carrying the accents of a cosmopolitan formation that most working-class New Yorkers will never experience. His mother is a filmmaker embedded

in the cultural world. His father is a Marxist postcolonial professor at Columbia University. His public record from the BLM era reflects the standard symbolic-maximalist package of that moment: abolitionist public-safety politics, aggressive sanctuary politics, and maximal support for gender-affirming-care access. Anyone can find this record. None of it is hidden. In many ways, prior to his mayoral campaign and his calculated shift toward material politics, Mamdani embodied many of the features of the “race communism” critiqued in my earlier essay, *Anti-Social Socialists*.^[47]

The point of raising it, however, is not to invoke it as hypocrisy or as disqualification. The structural problem with the PMC left is not that it comes from privileged or elite backgrounds, which is difficult to avoid in a society that routes political engagement through credentialed institutions. What makes Mamdani a more interesting case is that he appears, by the evidence of his campaign, to have achieved something that most of his organizational base has not: a genuine, if partial, attunement to the conditions facing ordinary New Yorkers. His ability to campaign on rent freezes and free buses, to build a coalition that reached across boroughs rather than concentrating entirely in the brownstone professional enclaves, represents a real departure from the prior cycle’s politics, however incomplete.

He is, in this sense, evidence for an argument the essay has made theoretically but needed a concrete case to illustrate: that the same credentialed-class energy that drove the Fourth Awakening can, under the right conditions, be redirected into a politics that prioritizes material class issues without the consciousness-first machinery. The people who drove woke politics can transition into something better. Mamdani himself is proof that **the background does not determine the destination**. What he does with that background is what distinguishes him from the typical PMC left politician, even if the movement built around him has not made the same transition. By 2025, his political priorities had shifted substantially toward housing and cost-of-living politics. The direction of movement is correct. The destination remains incomplete. And the organizational base remains the same.

The problem is never Mamdani himself so much as the movement built around him. Even if Zohran himself no longer acts in a stereotypically woke way when campaigning as a politician trying to win votes, many of the people who work for him very much do act woke. There is always a structural danger in having a movement backed primarily by elite aspirants and symbolic capitalists without a countervailing force from the working class and non-symbolic sectors to impose a different set of priorities.

The biggest problem with having a movement still controlled by college-educated urban progressives and elite aspirants is that even if they strategically pivot away from the most excessive aspects of woke language, they will still impose symbolic-capitalist priorities on the politician and his movement. If a broader political movement, which many people in the leftist media-industrial complex want to pretend Mamdani represents, is incapable of attracting working-class people toward it, especially people without college degrees who work with their hands, then the politics and character of that movement will be heavily shaped by PMC college-educated progressives. This is obviously part of why the left has trouble appealing to the working class, but what makes things worse

is that many neo-left progressives have implicitly accepted that the working class is no longer their primary voting bloc, so they do not even try.

Increasingly, the Neo-Left has implicitly relied on a shaky alliance of educated PMCs, particularly younger female PMC aspirants, lumpen-proletarian outcasts, and politicized ethnic minorities as a voting bloc. This is the rainbow coalition minus the working class, which earlier proponents of the rainbow coalition, like Jesse Jackson, at least wanted to reach. The electoral strategies of the left reflect its tacit acceptance that it is not worth appealing to workers without college degrees, old people, and increasingly young men, and that the left is better off targeting voters based on how socially liberal they are and which identity is treated as “the most marginalized.” This is why in our current era most leftist politicians and leftist media figures often compete for support more with liberals than they do with conservatives, even though in the populist era Republicans tend to get more working-class support.

When a movement is captured by symbolic-capitalist PMC aspirants who have similar social backgrounds as their liberal competitors, those people will exert enormous pressure to adopt positions that reflect their cultural priorities rather than the material interests of the working class being courted. That is why the Democrats and the “leftist” influencers who tried to get them elected in 2024 relied so heavily on abortion and Project 2025 as the great moral scare against Republicans, even though voters consistently ranked cost of living, inflation, immigration, and the economy higher. The talking points of the **liberal-left alliance** reflected the anxieties of its PMC constituency, which forgot that everyone else was living in a different world. In some cases, this pressure pushes liberal-left figures into positions that do not even reflect their own constituency, much less the people outside of it whom they would need to win over. Defund the police, abolish ICE, maximalist gender politics, and similar slogans became moral badges inside one milieu and liabilities almost everywhere else.

This is also why the most revealing moments are usually the ones that sound absurd to normal people but perfectly intelligible to the activist audience in the room. Kamala Harris later pivoted rightward in the general election by courting the neoconservative right, campaigning with Liz Cheney, and presenting herself as the respectable anti-Trump establishment candidate rather than a populist alternative. But she could not easily disown her 2019 ACLU questionnaire answer supporting taxpayer-funded gender-transition care for prisoners and detained migrants, which is why Trump’s “Kamala is for they/them” ad landed as more than a random culture-war cheap shot. Biden performed the same dance in 2019 when, asked how many genders there were, he answered “at least three.” These moments reveal the power of the woke crowd as a disciplinary force: not because it represents all LGBT people, who are themselves a diverse group with different beliefs, voting patterns, and class positions, but because its most activist and symbolic-capitalist fraction is concentrated in media, academia, art, entertainment, nonprofits, and online discourse, where backlash can become career-threatening even when the underlying constituency is far less unified. ^[48]

In *some* cases, **liberal-left politicians can get away with this when they are competing with other liberals, as in primary elections between Democrats in overwhelmingly blue**

districts. Mamdani provides a concrete example of the dynamic. During his campaign, he pledged \$65 million to expand gender-affirming care for minors and adults through New York City's public hospitals, vowing to penalize any hospital that declined to provide it and to make New York an "LGBTQIA+ Sanctuary City." The policy is coded in the language of protecting trans kids and sounds egalitarian on its surface. But it amounts to the mass medicalization of a condition whose prevalence among young people has risen at historically unprecedented rates, rather than addressing what might be driving that rise. It encourages life-altering decisions, which adults have every right to make, for children who are reporting alarming rates of gender dysphoria, under the assumption that the appropriate response is puberty blockers and an early transition pipeline rather than letting children go through puberty and deciding as adults. It is, regardless of one's moral assessment of the policy itself, as politically suicidal a position as one could adopt for running anywhere outside a super-blue district.^[49]

Why Mamdani Won

The obvious question is why Mamdani was able to win anyway. The answer is not that these positions are secretly popular. It is that his opponents largely failed to attack him on the terrain where he was most vulnerable. The attacks that did dominate the race centered on Israel, Palestine, and his Muslim identity, and those attacks did not land. On Israel, they may even have helped him. In the debate moment when other candidates were pressed about Israel while Mamdani emphasized staying in New York, he signaled to many voters that he would put the city first rather than perform the usual ritual of deference. With Israel becoming more unpopular because of Gaza, and with Mamdani doing a good job of making it clear that his criticism of Israel was not based in antisemitism, the attack did not land the way his opponents expected.^[50]

This does not mean Mamdani escaped every pressure coming from the professional-class left. He still had to reassure the **liberal-Zionist PMC** world on antisemitism and Jewish safety, especially after the Palestine-protest wave made left politics legible to many liberals as a security threat. The point is not that he necessarily believed every sentence of this performance. The point is that politicians conform to the audiences that can destroy them. In New York, that means not only the woke activist crowd but also the liberal-Zionist professional class that controls much of the city's symbolic terrain.

The Muslim panic also failed. Right-wing media tried to paint Mamdani as a radical Muslim, jihadist, or Islamist, but the attack was not believable to anyone. I doubt even Fox News boomers truly believed it. Mamdani is obviously a cosmopolitan New Yorker, socially liberal, comfortable with the LGBT coalition, and not plausibly an Islamist. The attack resembled the old "Obama is a secret Muslim" routine: useful for exciting the people who already hate the candidate, but useless for persuading anyone who is not already living inside the fever dream.

The more important point is strategic. **Cuomo was competing with Mamdani for voters in a Democratic, liberal New York context.** In this context, trans youth medicalization is not

exactly the first issue that comes to mind when you are thinking of strategies to peel liberal voters away from Mamdani. When American politicians are competing against a “socialist,” their first instinct is to invoke red scare tactics because they assume that socialism is still the taboo word it once was. But clearly things have changed. Even in the presidential elections, the right-wing media’s attacks on Kamala Harris for her culturally left-wing positions and her *character* did far more damage to her campaign than trying to frame her as a “communist” did, which they tried and failed with Obama. Furthermore, Curtis Sliwa, meanwhile, split the anti-Mamdani field and spent much of the campaign attacking Cuomo as the status quo candidate rather than concentrating fire on Mamdani. The result was a strange game-theory situation in which Mamdani’s most nationally toxic positions were never made central to the race.^[51]

New York City is also not America. It is a global capital of symbolic capital: young professionals, immigrants, cosmopolitans, media workers, nonprofit people, academics, and PMC aspirants packed into one city. In that setting, the trans issue does not carry the same political weight it would carry in a family-centered suburb, small city, or red/purple state. Many childless symbolic-capitalist voters dismiss these issues as trivial compared to housing or affordability. Parents usually do not, especially when the question concerns minors, schools, puberty blockers, and parental authority. That is why the issue can seem fake or marginal inside progressive urban bubbles while remaining politically explosive almost everywhere else.

Mamdani’s victory, then, is not a national blueprint. It is an exception produced by New York’s electorate, New York’s density of symbolic capitalists, the peculiar opponent he faced, the three-way dynamics of the race, and the failure of his opponents to attack him on his most vulnerable issues. The danger is that leftists will treat his victory as proof that they can ignore cultural moderation everywhere. Winning in New York City is not the same as winning in Kentucky, Ohio, Michigan, rural Pennsylvania, or even many working-class urban districts. A blue-district strategy can masquerade as a movement for a while, but it is not a national working-class politics.

It’s Not Just Optics. It’s About Truth

It is not just a question about optics either. **On [some of these issues](#), the progressive-maximalist position is just wrong**, and the left is wrong to *go along with it*. There is no significant evidence that *defunding the police* is a good policy for helping the issues faced by black people and poor people in general.^[52] It is not clear whatsoever that *decriminalizing*, let alone *legalizing*, all drugs and prostitution carries more positives than negatives that outweigh the risks. It is also far from clear that promoting LGBTQ lifestyles to children and then outsourcing their gender dysphoria to the *pharmaceutical industry* is a great way to deal with gender troubles and mental health. Yet many woke leftists take these neo-left progressive positions to be *self-evident* staples of leftist morality, principles that they will accuse of abandoning if you critique them, **even if this was never the “leftism” you signed up for in the first place.**

The issue is not just about trying to strategically police optics so the left gets better at PR. It's about political seriousness, not just about having the left "win" against the right, but about what is right and wrong at the level of policy. The Danish example matters because Denmark did not primarily treat youth gender medicine as a culture-war identity test. It treated it as a *public health* policy question: what does the evidence actually show, what risks attach to medicalizing minors, and what should clinicians do when the patient population changes rapidly? [In Denmark and other Nordic countries](#), clinicians and policymakers have shifted toward greater caution, prioritizing psychosocial support and counseling-first protocols over routine puberty blockers or cross-sex hormones for minors. That shift was not a right-wing moral panic. It followed [European evidence reviews](#) and [clinical reassessments](#) that found [the evidence base weaker and more uncertain than the confident claims](#) often made by the American medical-pharmaceutical and activist ecosystem. In other words, [the science coming out of Europe complicated, and in some cases contradicted, the "settled science" posture of the American affirmation model](#). North American leftists love to praise Denmark and the Nordic Model in general for its highly progressive positions on most issues (including women's rights), yet they turn a blind eye to when these countries realize **that not all progress is progressive**. That Mamdani has gone ahead with this policy illustrates the structural point precisely: he ultimately has to acquiesce to the people who helped bring him to power, who are overwhelmingly symbolic-capitalist types. **If your power base lacks blue collar workers, small business owners, and people without college degrees, you will get captured by the managerial class.** Mamdani is, in this respect, George McGovern if McGovern had never run for president and had instead remained stuck in a very blue district.^[53]

Anti-left propaganda works because leftists ARE the propaganda.

The "loony left" narrative works for the right, *not* just because right-wing media is good at *propaganda sorcery*. It works because there are, in fact, a lot of loony leftists with loony ideas **whom the gatekeepers of left-wing discourse allow to represent the left, even if those people do not represent the left as a whole in raw numbers**. The fact that so many people trying to build careers in and around leftist politics *choose* to go along with, or at least not challenge, the loony-left ideas of a loud overrepresented minority is why the left appears like an *unserious freakshow* to many people outside of it, despite all the good ideas and intentions that many *class-first leftists* actually would have public support on. Leftists love to selectively highlight polling data showing the issues they are popular on, healthcare, jobs, housing, wealth inequality, social programs, anti-war stances, but they turn a blind eye to all the things they are unpopular on, like mass immigration, identity politics, and the excesses of social liberalism.

The *PMC capture* of the left and its capitulation to niche PMC liberal-left priorities is precisely the trap the *agnostic* approach to wokeism cannot avoid. The problem is not "elite capture" of a woke politics that was otherwise perfectly fine before. Woke politics is already elite-captured from the start, by the PMC and PMC aspirants, who prioritize first-world concerns and cultural revolution.

Many class-first leftists put up with woke extremism because they simply “*don’t care*” about culture war issues. Even if they find these topics annoying, they shrug them off, believing they are not major problems worth addressing. I too used to hold this opinion. However, **the result of “not caring” about wokeness is that these class-first leftists allow those who do care about unwinnable culture wars to dominate left-wing discourse.**

Consequently, the woke faction of the left determines the “official” left-wing position on various cultural topics. In some cases, *older* leftists who prioritize class accommodate wokeness because they are *too old* to understand how extreme social progressivism has become, leaving them unsure of whether it is right or wrong. These older leftists assume that the progressives speaking on behalf of marginalized groups know what they are talking about. As a result, they keep their mouths shut, or they *simply lack the energy* to die on such a trivial hill this late in the game.

This dynamic between old and new leftists is evident among millennial and young Generation X professors. When entering academia, they prioritized woke topics while competing for status in a highly saturated academic job market. Eventually, these subjects became very safe avenues for gaining social currency. Nobody dared challenge that dogma at its height unless they had tenure, and even then, most remained silent. There are a lot of old leftist boomer professors who are not woke but are too removed to understand or challenge the new orthodoxy taking over.

This old-young leftist dynamic exists in leftist politics generally, explaining the political alliances between figures like Bernie Sanders and Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez, or Jeremy Corbyn and Zarah Sultana. The older boomer leftist remains rooted in the 1970s, viewing their movement as a class-first project that works with marginalized groups and champions minority civil rights. Meanwhile, for the younger neo-leftist, class is a secondary and highly racialized category. Their cultural politics function as a top-down professional-managerial class (PMC) cultural revolution intended to ***re-engineer the common sense*** of the majority, completely diverging from a traditional battle for basic equal rights for the minority.

Many class-first leftists who wouldn’t otherwise be perceived as woke are often *complicit* in the suicide of the left because they let all of this woke nonsense slide, as they don’t have the energy or *the will* to challenge it, and want to be diplomatic with other self-described “leftists” in order to maintain a coalition of allies. However, as [Ruy Teixeira has pointed out in many great articles of his](#), this approach of relying on economic populism alone without taking a stance on any cultural issues can only go so far. The “no war but class war” indifferent approach of keeping one’s head in the sand on all cultural matters can’t conceal the deep contradictions within leftist viewpoints that many leftists still feel they have to capitulate to in 2026.. A politician who genuinely does not hold woke positions can answer these questions in these matters directly and without apology. A politician who simply does not lead with them, but has never worked through a different framework, will revert to the woke frame the moment the question arrives. If one cannot offer a coherent and commonsense position regarding children, it signals to most parents that they have no place in the politics being offered.

Why the Left Is Slow to Learn

Why is the left so slow to learn from its mistakes? Why does it keep repeating the mistakes of New-Left McGovernism? **The people who narrate the left's failures are often the same symbolic capitalists who helped produce those failures.** The voices that define, interpret, and publicly represent “the left” are disproportionately media workers, academics, nonprofit professionals, podcasters, writers, artists, graduate students, activists, influencers, and leftist content creators. **They control the symbolic production of trademark leftism, determining the public perception of what “the left” is.** They are the *interlocutors*, *ideologists*, translators, interpreters, *commentators*, *narrators*, and *gatekeepers* of what the left supposedly is.

That creates a built-in problem of self-criticism. The symbolic capitalists write the postmortems, but they are themselves part of what went wrong. They are not likely to say, “we were the problem,” because they often cannot see the problem from inside the same social world that produced it. In other cases, they have no interest in seeing it, because their careers depend on keeping alive the idea that there is a movement, that their media work is movement work, and that the audience is participating in history by subscribing, donating, sharing, or joining.

This is how the *leftist industrial complex* keeps manufacturing **false hope**. After Bernie Sanders was defeated, the Squad was treated as proof that the left was back, even though those victories were heavily dependent on district-specific conditions. Mamdani is now being treated the same way. The moment he won, some people began saying that “woke is back” or that he had provided the blueprint for the future left. When I criticized the Mamdani mania, including alongside Benjamin Studebaker, the first people to dismiss the critique as pessimism were often the very people with a material and symbolic interest in selling the idea that this is a movement.

The Canadian version of the same fantasy is already visible in the attempt to frame Avi Lewis, the new leader of the NDP, as a kind of “Canadian Zohran Mamdani.” Whether Lewis deserves that comparison is not the point. **The point is how quickly symbolic-capitalist left discourse turns a context-specific victory into a universal formula.** A charismatic democratic socialist wins in New York City by foregrounding affordability while avoiding direct scrutiny on his most unpopular cultural positions, and suddenly the lesson becomes: no compromise is necessary, no cultural reckoning is needed, the left was right all along.^[54]

That is precisely the wrong lesson. Mamdani proves something much narrower: a talented politician can win in a very specific city, under very specific conditions, by foregrounding material issues and avoiding the most damaging cultural fights. He does not prove that those cultural positions are nationally viable. Even some class-first, anti-woke, Bernie-left critics of identity politics have been tempted by the easier conclusion: if the left simply talks about bread-and-butter issues, it does not need to confront wokeism directly. But a strategy that works in New York is not a strategy that works everywhere. A country as large and politically

diverse as the United States requires different cultural and political strategies in different places.

This is where the argument of my left-conservatism essay becomes unavoidable. A serious class politics must be broad enough to tolerate a socially conservative or culturally moderate wing, just as the right contains both libertarian and conservative tendencies. Whether we call it left politics, socialist politics, class politics, or something else, the movement needs a wider horizon of what can be debated and tolerated. The goal is not the personal exile of every woke person from political life. The goal is the defeat of woke capture, the *woke stranglehold* over the left's imagination and discourse. If woke people are a minority, the real question is why the left continues to capitulate to them. The answer is that they are overrepresented in the symbolic-capitalist institutions that define the left's public image.

A related and increasingly common claim is that woke is resurging because the right is unpopular. This confuses dissatisfaction with *right-wing governments* with *pro-woke sentiment*. They are not the same thing. The Democrats have remained as unpopular as ever (Especially on issues like immigration and social/cultural issues) despite Trump's falling approval rating and the implosion of MAGA into deep factional infighting. Where left-wing candidates have had the chance to compete directly against right-wing candidates, they have not fared well. Jeremy Corbyn, running on precisely the kind of economic populism that should theoretically capture the anti-establishment vote, lost dramatically to Boris Johnson. Reform UK is now leading or highly competitive in UK voting-intention polling, not any socialist alternative. In France, the left could barely win despite forming a tactical alliance with centrist liberals. Die Linke won in Berlin but lost East Germany to the AfD. In Italy, Giorgia Meloni captured traditionally working-class socialist strongholds. In Canada, the reaction to right-wing populism swung voters toward the liberal centrist party rather than the NDP, which actually lost seats. Across the board, the candidates who have defeated right-wing populists have been moderate, centrist liberals who distanced themselves from wokeism. The left has fared best where it has more openly moderated or shifted rightward on contentious cultural positions. The working class is not turning to the left; it is turning away from it, not because economic populism lacks appeal, but because the left has coupled it with cultural positions that alienate the very working-class voters it claims to represent. The claim that woke is coming back because the right is faltering does not survive contact with the actual electoral results.^[55]

Israel and Palestine

The post-October 7 shift of substantial symbolic-capitalist left energy toward Palestine represents a parallel, if similarly ambiguous, development. On structural grounds, Palestine is a more serious cause than the cultural politics that dominated the prior cycle: it involves *genuine material stakes*, crosses left-right partisan lines in ways that racial and gender identity politics never managed, and has produced growing cross-ideological skepticism of American foreign policy commitments. Journalists, academics, and entertainers who spent the prior decade cycling through BLM, indigenous solidarity, and LGBTQ advocacy have, in

many cases, **redirected their political energy toward Palestine since 2023**. In *principle*, a cause that involves higher stakes and reaches further across political lines is an improvement over the inward-facing consciousness politics of the prior cycle.^[56]

The caveat, however, is the same one that applies to Mamdani: the woke tendency has a consistent pattern of absorbing causes that have genuine popular potential and **rendering them politically self-defeating through the same dynamics of status competition and performative extremism**. Woke people, on average, tend to be embittered/temporarily embarrassed professional-managerial-class aspirants in fields such as art, entertainment, media, and academia. When they get involved in political causes, they tend to turn them into a consciousness-raising spectacle as they use virtue signaling as a form of social currency, and in many cases, **they enter into activist spaces because it's a social hierarchy that they can accumulate more power in**. Put bluntly, the wokes burn every movement they go near to the ground. Nobody burns an American flag at a demonstration if their actual goal is to convince their fellow citizens to care about Palestinian civilian casualties. Nobody chants about settlers deserving their fate if the objective is to build a coalition broad enough to shift American foreign policy. The people who do these things are not making tactical errors born of political inexperience. They are doing exactly what the *consciousness-first* mode of politics produces when it infiltrates a cause: demonstrating their commitment in terms legible to their peer group, regardless of how those demonstrations register to any audience they would need to reach to actually advance the cause. **Bad optics, in this framework, are not an accident. They are the point.** The logic is similar to what drives the behavior of hipsters. It is a kind of hipster leftism, driven not by a genuine commitment to a political project with serious intentions of winning, but by a brand aesthetic that prides itself on being more radical than others. For these individuals, leftism is a way of distinguishing themselves from others rather than finding common ground with them. They are not trying to move toward a political project with crossover appeal, but rather to occupy a niche. The problem with working alongside these people within any serious political movement is that in most progressive leftist organizations, you encounter a mix of individuals with very different intentions and motives: those who are genuinely committed to the cause and want to advance it, and those who may believe they are committed but are actually driven by the competition to virtue-signal and differentiate themselves. These latter individuals will often be the first to champion the least popular positions, because doing so is precisely what signals their distinction. Someone who is primarily performing virtue for the already-converted has no incentive to moderate their presentation for outsiders. This is the difference between someone who wants to *win* and someone who wants to be *seen wanting to win*. Serious political actors, even those with genuinely dangerous ideas, understand this distinction and moderate their public presentation accordingly. The woke tendency often fails this basic test of political seriousness because political effectiveness is not its primary objective.

There are key implications within this essay that are important when thinking about the future of woke. The Fourth Awakening is exhausting itself, its cultural causes saturated or discredited, its institutional infrastructure contracting under corporate rollbacks and political backlash. AI displacement is producing the conditions for a potential Fifth Awakening by

collapsing the credential hedge that once separated the symbolic-capitalist PMC from the precarity it administered to others. Class politics is returning across both left and right, with figures like Sanders demonstrating that material appeals reach voters the woke left has abandoned, and with early cases like Mamdani suggesting that the same credentialed-class energy that drove the prior cycle can, under the right conditions, be redirected toward something more materially serious.

But **the return of class politics is not, by itself, sufficient**. Mamdani's coalition still skews toward the college-educated and the newly arrived rather than the lifelong working-class New Yorkers his platform was designed to serve. The organizational base behind him, the New York DSA and the activist infrastructure of the symbolic-capitalist left, is the same base that spent the prior decade alienating ordinary people through the very dynamics this trilogy has traced. The Palestine cause, for all its genuine material stakes, is already being absorbed by the consciousness-first mode of politics, its potential popular appeal narrowed by the same performative extremism that consumed BLM before it. The pattern is consistent: causes with real popular potential are captured by a symbolic-capitalist political style that transforms them into status competitions legible only to insiders, shedding their broad appeal in the process.

The question, then, is whether this return to material politics represents a genuine *structural break* from the consciousness-first template or merely its latest iteration under a different label. Will the next political opening be **post-woke in substance**, organized around shared material interests and willing to challenge the woke tendency directly, or will it reproduce the essential features of the cycle it claims to have transcended? That question cannot be answered by structural analysis alone. It requires confronting a strategic problem that the structural account has illuminated but cannot itself resolve: the relationship between class politics and the woke tendency that currently occupies the organizational terrain on which any serious working-class politics must be built. Recognizing the failures of woke politics is a necessary starting point. Whether it is a sufficient one, and what the alternative actually requires in practice, is the subject of the final installment of this series.

However, this is *not to say* that the culture war must be ignored entirely in favor of the class war. It is also a mistake to treat class and culture war issues as entirely separate. The relationship between the two, and the strategic question of how a serious left politics must navigate both simultaneously, is the subject of **part 4**, the final essay in this series: *The Culture War is the Class War*.

Part 4 - The Culture War is the Class War

The Civil War Between the Two Lefts

A Letter to the “Post-Woke” Left (and those still on the fence)

This essay serves as the **fourth** and final essay in my *Genealogy of Wokeism series*. But you don't need to read those essays first *before* reading this one. For those who want a

rigorous, historically grounded definition of what wokeism is, I would direct them to [Part 1](#) of this series. It is highly influenced by (and a complement to) dates who have defeated right-wing populists have been moderate, centrist liberals who distanced themselves from wok) American sociologist Musa al-Gharbi's book *We Have Never Been Woke*, which is by far the most detailed and empirically grounded study of wokeism that exists to date. After deconstructing the history of wokeism from the past to the present, I conclude with this final piece on *what to do* about it.

This final installment is directed not so much at “woke people” themselves, but at what I believe is a more politically consequential group: those who already see through woke politics and have nonetheless decided to live with it. To this crowd of people who may consider themselves “neither woke nor anti-woke,” I pose the following challenge: **if wokeism is truly a fringe phenomenon driven by an overrepresented *minority*, then a question immediately follows: why does the left not simply reject it?** If it truly is so *insignificant*, then why do leftists, including many self-proclaimed “class-first” leftists, continue to accommodate the dogmas of woke people and **allow them to define the cultural politics that have become associated with “the left”?** As I will show, the Bernie Sanders campaigns of 2016 and 2020 exposed an *underlying civil war* within the left, which has had grave consequences that much of the left still has not learned from. There has always been a divide between woke leftists and class-first leftists who find the woke stuff annoying, embarrassing, and who quietly roll their eyes at the pronoun rituals and the cancel culture performance, who prefer to focus on economics while treating the cultural absurdities as a self-limiting nuisance. I argue that wokeism's greatest structural asset is not its popular appeal; it is the tolerance it receives from people who know better yet *choose*, for reasons of social comfort or strategic calculation, **to do nothing about it**. This essay argues that this tolerance is not a neutral position. It is, in effect, the condition that keeps wokeism alive, allowing it to continue derailing any serious left political project interested in large scale structural change.

Memory-Holing Wokeism

Whenever people take a surface look at what I have written and said about wokeism (without really reading), they often *assume* that I take the standard class-first lefty conclusion that “the culture war is a distraction, and that we must just focus on class and economics.” But **that is not my argument**. The “culture war is a distraction” framing is a very limited narrative that stops people short of grasping the full scope of the problem.

The “post-woke” left approach to wokeism is captured in a familiar narrative that is increasingly standard among class-first leftists that sounds reasonable on its face. Consider a statement from Graham Platner, at the time a left-leaning Senate candidate in Maine: “I just have no patience for getting dragged into, frankly, culture war issues that are being invented by the people that don't want us talking about raising their taxes. That's why it exists.”^[57] The posture is recognizable. It is the standard agnostic response to the culture war among class-first leftists: the culture war is a manufactured distraction, conjured by

billionaires and the right to keep ordinary people from focusing on economic questions. This would be a strong narrative for the left if it were true. The problem is that it simply does not reflect reality. What that narrative gets correct is that the right does benefit from keeping the culture-war terrain active, and concentrated wealth does have an interest in keeping workers divided. These are real phenomena.

What this narrative gets profoundly wrong is the order of cause and effect. Action precedes reaction. The culture war was not invented by the people who oppose woke politics. It was generated by the same symbolic-capitalist overproduction this series has documented from the beginning, and the right-wing anti-woke industrial complex was an entirely predictable response to it. To act as if the right fabricated the culture war from nothing is to pretend that the woke left did not exist, or that the decade of language policing, institutional capture, and consciousness politics that preceded the conservative backlash was simply not a real phenomenon. This version of events may be convenient for those who want to distance themselves from the woke tendency without examining their relationship to it. It does not fool anyone who watched what actually happened.

The evidence against this account is not difficult to find. Was it right-wing billionaires who pressured institutions to adopt gender-neutral language, substituting terms like “birthing persons” for mothers in official government communications? Was it right-wing media that structured certain public-sector hiring processes to advantage applicants who identified as women or people of color? Was the left’s embrace of open borders, accompanied by slogans like “no human is illegal,” merely a conservative fabrication? These were left-generated political developments. The right reacted to them, cynically and effectively. But the raw material was real, and asking people to disbelieve what they observed between 2015 and 2022 is not a political argument. It is an insult to their memory.

The correct formulation is the inverse of what the class-first agnostic typically offers.

It is not that right-wing propaganda creates an image of the left that does not correspond to anything real. It is that the woke left’s attempts to impose a cultural revolution, on a public that did not invite one, are what supply right-wing propaganda with its most effective material. The left’s most embarrassing representatives are the right’s most effective recruiters. Class-first leftists who genuinely want to demonstrate that the left is more than its woke faction have one option: stop treating the woke tendency as an unfortunate footnote and start disciplining it. The reason most have not done so is not strategic calculation. It is a failure of nerve.

The truth is that “the culture war is a distraction” narrative is itself a distraction, specifically from the fact that it was the left’s own symbolic-capitalist class that generated the culture war in the first place, and that many of the people now insisting we ignore it were content to tolerate it, and in many cases enable it, right up until it became politically costly. The pivot from cultural maximalism to economic agnosticism is not a principled intellectual development. It is a retreat made under conditions of losing. The narrative functions not to redirect attention toward economics but to shut down scrutiny of the left’s own recent history.

It works only on people who have already decided not to think about it; to anyone who remembers what the left was doing between 2014 and 2020, it reads as precisely what it is.

There is a meaningful distinction between rejecting woke politics as wrong and simply declining to engage with it as if it does not exist. The second is a fundamentally different intellectual posture, and a substantially less honest one. When faced with a concrete cultural question, the agnostic politician freezes, because silence is not a philosophy. It is an evasion, and a costly one: accepting the woke frame by default while pretending not to engage with it at all. The agnostic approach of casually disavowing woke or laughing off as well-meaning but “went a bit too far” (as AOC did in a recent interview where she said “woke” was “a little crazy”) is a convenient way of distancing oneself from it without actually confronting it or holding the people who pushed it (and still push it) accountable.

Culture War as Class War

While the culture war is a distraction insofar as it does not bring real progress in material terms, and changing minds does not necessarily change things, the culture war is not entirely divorced from the economic war. For the economic war to be overturned and won by a pro-working class force, it would require a political movement that is not actively hostile and at odds with the working class it seeks to galvanize. Understood structurally, the culture war is downstream of elite overproduction: a form of class conflict in which PMC symbolic capitalists, who use oppressed minorities as human shields for their own class advancement, contest institutional terrain against the fraction of concentrated wealth whose dominance they nominally challenge. But the contemporary left is precisely such a hostile force, which is why the culture war is not merely a distraction; it is a hindrance to the economic project. The way to deal with it is not just to say that it does not matter and that we should stop thinking about it.

The more important point, however, is that the left’s cultural failures are not solely failures of strategy or optics. **Some woke positions on cultural questions are substantively wrong, not merely politically inconvenient, and a serious left should be willing to say so.** The Nordic countries, which built the most successful social democratic institutions in the modern world, have in several cases arrived at conclusions about cultural-political questions that contradict the dominant positions of the Anglo-American woke left on the merits. Denmark’s Social Democratic Party, governing from the left on economic policy, has imposed some of the most restrictive immigration controls in Western Europe, not as political triangulation but as a policy response to the labor-market and social-cohesion concerns of its actual working-class constituency. Several Nordic countries, following systematic review of the clinical evidence, have rolled back the routine prescription of puberty blockers for youth gender dysphoria, concluding that the evidence base does not support the intervention at the scale it was being administered.^[58] These are not concessions to the right. They are examples of a mature social democratic politics willing to follow evidence and constituent interest even when doing so conflicts with the ideological commitments of its symbolic-capitalist professional strata. The contrast with the Anglo-American woke left, which treats any

deviation from the dominant progressive position on immigration or trans medicine as a form of moral betrayal, is instructive. The goal is not to win by holding whatever positions are most culturally palatable. **The goal should be to have the correct ideas, the ideas that actually improve people's lives, and to build movements serious and disciplined enough to implement them.**

Recognizing the failures of woke politics is a necessary starting point, but it is not sufficient. Being *post-woke*, in the sense of declining to engage with the cultural politics of the prior cycle, is not the same thing as rejecting the *woke mode of politics* as the organizational and strategic threat it actually represents. The first posture, treating wokeism as something that will fade on its own if ignored or gently discouraged, underestimates the structural dynamics that sustain it. Some on the left object that fighting wokeism is itself just another culture war, and that anti-wokeism is merely wokeism inverted. Applied to right-wing media, which has no stake in class politics, the charge is largely fair. Applied to the left it collapses, because the two sides do not have the same interest in the outcome. The right loses nothing by leaving the woke tendency intact, since an opponent that easy to caricature is an asset to it. **The left is the only side with a material stake in defeating wokeism, which is why treating opposition to it as a distraction from class politics gets the relationship exactly backwards. Anyone who genuinely believes in the left's stated goals, whether economic justice, reduced poverty, better healthcare, or effective climate policy, should be the most forcefully anti-woke, precisely because the woke tendency has demonstrably driven those goals backward. The woke left did not merely fail to advance working-class interests. It actively alienated the working-class constituencies without whose support no anti-establishment politics can succeed.**

No amount of redirecting to economic issues works when the thing being redirected away from is visible, immediate, and real.

And it is real. It is not merely an online phenomenon or a product of right-wing media amplification. The pronoun rituals, privilege-checking procedures, and representation performances that characterize many DSA meetings and, as was visible at the NDP convention, mainstream party conferences,^[59] are genuine organizational realities that real people must conform to or fight against in order to participate in left-wing political spaces. Many people conform out of politeness rather than conviction, and complain about it behind closed doors. What is perpetually baffling is the number of people on the left who insist these things no longer exist, or are so marginal as to be irrelevant, when they are demonstrably present and operative. **The fact that these tendencies are driven by a loud minority is not a reason to dismiss them. It is the most compelling reason to reject wokeism and stop capitulating to the expectations of woke people.**

The deep and largely unspoken division between the cultural left and the class-first left was exposed most dramatically during the 2016 and 2020 Democratic primaries, and specifically in the two Bernie Sanders campaigns. Those elections revealed that there are different lefts operating under the same banner, with genuinely conflicting priorities, and that many who

appear to be on the same side are not aligned on anything that matters politically. The lessons produced by those campaigns have still not been learned.

The Lesson of Bernie Sanders 2016–2020



The Unlearned Lesson

Everything this essay has argued in the abstract, the Sanders campaigns of 2016 and 2020 proved empirically. They functioned as a litmus test for the American left, and the results were unambiguous. What those campaigns exposed was the depth of the division between two fundamentally incompatible political formations operating under the same banner: a

genuine class-first left committed to socioeconomic transformation, universal public goods, and the material interests of working people, and a synthetic woke left, rooted in the professional-managerial class and the symbolic-capitalist aspirant strata described in Part 1, whose actual priorities are cultural sensibility, identity-based recognition, and the preservation of the institutional terrain on which their careers depend. These are not two wings of the same movement. They are structurally opposed projects, and the Sanders campaigns proved it by forcing the contradiction into the open.

Above all, the Sanders experience demonstrates that the woke left, and specifically this PMC faction, is the primary internal obstacle preventing the left from winning. It was not the Republican Party that stopped Bernie Sanders. It was not Fox News. It was the Democratic establishment and its woke-adjacent professional class: the staffers, the activist organizations, the media professionals, the NGO operatives, and the symbolic-capitalist intelligentsia who could not tolerate a politics that did not center their cultural priorities. Sanders had the policies, the cross-class appeal, and the grassroots energy to capture the Democratic Party and advance a genuine social democratic agenda. What he did not have was the willingness to destroy the internal opposition that stood in his way. Unlike Donald Trump, who ruthlessly dismantled his Republican primary opponents in 2015 and 2016, humiliated the party establishment, and forced the entire apparatus to conform to him, Sanders chose accommodation. While Clinton supporters attacked him and his base as “Bernie Bros” and framed the choice between a woman candidate and a class-first candidate as inherently sexist, Sanders pulled his punches, deferred to the unity imperative, and tried to coexist with forces whose structural interest was his defeat.

The Day Sanders Stood Still

There was one event in particular that many of us probably remember, which I believe was a symbolically *defining moment* for the nascent class-first left in America. **It was the day in which the Bernie Sanders movement marked its total capitulation and submission to the woke minority**, allowing the left to become totally captured by the woke, which had already culturally captured the more centrist/establishment liberal left. On August 8, 2015, Bernie Sanders arrived at Westlake Park in Seattle to address a Social Security rally. He was drawing crowds that had surprised even his own campaign staff, and his candidacy had demonstrated an early cross-class reach the Democratic establishment had not anticipated. Before he could speak, two Black Lives Matter activists rushed the stage and seized the microphone. One of them told the crowd, which had begun to boo the disruption, that they were “white supremacist liberals.” She spoke for several minutes. Sanders and his people stood to the side, visibly too weak-willed to assert control of their own event. Organizers eventually ended the rally, and Sanders left without delivering his speech.

The incident was not primarily notable for what the protesters said. It was notable for what Sanders did not do. The Sanders team did not have the balls to simply kick them out. They feared the potential backlash of woke outcries over “kicking out a black woman” from their event. But backlash from whom, and at what cost? No sane person looking at that spectacle would have thought that the two BLM activists weren’t obviously in the wrong. As a result of

the inability to stand up to this nonsense, Sanders was not able to defend his platform or the audience that had shown up to hear him. He stood aside, and then he ceded it. The image was widely circulated and understood by those watching as exactly what it was: **a signal that this movement would accommodate disruption rather than confront it, that the symbolic-politics faction could command the attention of the working-class left simply by invoking the right moral vocabulary loudly enough.**

That signal set the trajectory for everything that followed.

It is almost hard to believe today that Bernie Sanders, prior to running in the Democratic primary, was not a Democratic politician. He had been an independent his entire political career, serving as mayor of Burlington and then in the House and Senate without affiliating with either major party. He did not register as a Democrat until 2015. His reasoning was explicit: he had drawn the lesson from Ralph Nader's 2000 campaign that third-party runs in the American electoral system produce nothing except the spoiler effect. The Democratic primary was not his natural home. It was the only viable vehicle for a social-democratic agenda in a system structurally hostile to independent candidacies. That outsider status was not incidental to his appeal. It was the source of it. The 2016 Sanders campaign was remarkable in ways the left has since worked hard to forget. Sanders was not simply appealing to Brooklyn socialists, campus activists, or the already-converted professional-progressive base. His campaign was genuinely cross-class in its reach precisely because it was not primarily framed through the idioms of identity politics. He spoke in a class-first language about wages, inequality, healthcare, Wall Street, trade, corruption, and the domination of political life by concentrated wealth. The results bore this out. Sanders won or performed strongly in states that were not liberal enclaves, across the industrial Midwest and the rural interior, while making the race against Hillary Clinton far more competitive than the political class had expected. **The 2016 campaign demonstrated that class-first language could reach voters the left had been told were unreachable.**

This is also why the so-called "Bernie-to-Trump" phenomenon, however overstated in some versions, was real enough to matter politically. Some voters who supported Sanders in the primary subsequently voted for Trump in the general, which made no sense if you understood politics through the symbolic coordinates of liberal progressivism. It made perfect sense if you understood that many of those voters were not looking for "left" or "right" in the professional-managerial sense. They were looking for someone who seemed to be against the system, against the donor class, against trade deals that hollowed out their communities, against a political order that treated them as disposable. Sanders could reach that voter because, at his best, he was addressing the same material anxiety through a different vocabulary.

These voters did not become far-right. They moved away from the left. The distinction matters because the standard left response to the Bernie-to-Trump phenomenon is to characterize it as radicalization, framing the departure as a rightward conversion when the more accurate account is that the left lost these people rather than the right capturing them. A politics that alienates people it already had is a different problem from a politics facing a

new ideological adversary, and it requires a different diagnosis. The right did not conjure these voters. The left drove them out.

His 2019 Fox News town hall illustrated this directly. Sanders appeared before an audience that had been told for years that he was a dangerous radical, and received sustained applause when he made the case for Medicare for All. The audience was not applauding because they had suddenly become socialists. They were responding to a material argument framed in universal terms, about healthcare costs, medical bankruptcy, and the insurance industry's grip on the political system, rather than as a boutique moral performance for the already-enlightened. That moment contained within it the entire blueprint for a cross-partisan working-class politics: frame material demands in terms that speak to shared conditions rather than to the symbolic hierarchies of progressive respectability, and the audience is there. **The opening was real. What happened next was its squandering.**

The electoral arithmetic of 2016 and 2020 tells this story precisely. In 2016, Sanders lost California to Clinton, a state generally perceived as the most progressive in the country. He lost it to a Southern Democrat with deep regional ties and every structural advantage of name recognition and establishment support. Yet he won Michigan, Wisconsin, West Virginia, Indiana, Oklahoma, and Kansas. When the 2020 campaign set about analyzing the 2016 loss, the diagnosis it arrived at was that Sanders had failed to appeal to minority voters and women sufficiently, that losing California was evidence of a coalition problem. **This was almost certainly the wrong lesson.** What the 2016 numbers showed was not a coalition failure but a class strength: his weakness was with the educated, socially liberal, PMC-adjacent vote that California concentrated. That was not a deficiency to be corrected by adopting identity politics messaging. It was a sign of what made his politics distinct.

What drove the 2020 shift was not only the changed political environment but the changed composition of the campaign itself. The 2016 operation had been run largely by professional strategists whose primary brief was winning votes. The 2020 operation brought in a substantially different kind of staff: people who were themselves committed *leftists* rather than professional electoral strategists, many of them radicalized by Trump and what followed. It was this staff that persuaded the campaign the 2016 loss had been a minority-outreach failure. A neutral analyst looking at the same data might have reached the opposite conclusion. A staff whose politics were shaped by identity frameworks was structurally unlikely to.

The 2020 results confirmed what the misdiagnosis predicted. The campaign softened its class edges, leaned into representation and coalition politics, and attempted to appeal to the Warren voter and the Buttigieg voter on their own terrain. It won California. And it lost Michigan, Wisconsin, and most of the Midwest to Joe Biden. What the geographic shift makes unmistakable is that his support moved in exactly the wrong direction for general-election viability: away from the states that decide federal elections and toward the states that were already reliably Democratic. That is precisely backwards for a movement that claimed working-class politics as its reason for existing. He should have focused on what separated him from the rest, not on what united him with them.

The claim that Sanders won California in 2020 because the identity pivot worked does not survive scrutiny. He won California not because his appeal to identity groups succeeded, but because the centrist and progressive opposition that had consolidated behind Clinton in 2016 was divided in 2020 among Buttigieg, Warren, Harris, and Biden. Clinton had swallowed up the entire socially liberal, fiscally moderate vote in 2016. In 2020, that vote was split. California, moreover, is not a left-wing state in the class sense; it is a progressive state in the PMC sense. Winning it proved nothing about electability in a general election. If Sanders were ever to demonstrate electability against a Republican, the evidence would have to come from swing states and the Midwest, which is exactly where his 2016 campaign had shown real strength and his 2020 campaign forfeited it. There was nothing strategically better about the 2020 campaign. He lost by a wider margin overall. The only result of the pivot was gaining more woke support at the cost of his swing-state appeal. Trying to capitulate to woke progressives rather than challenge and defeat them, as Trump did to his Republican opposition, ultimately set social democratic class politics backward, and we are still suffering from it today. There was a path. A *class-first* left could have said: we are not the cultural left, not the HR department, not the NGO class, not the people yelling at you online about your language and your privilege. We are on the side of better wages, healthcare, unions, family stability, public goods, and **national economic populism**. That was the offer Sanders was best positioned to make. It was not the offer his 2020 campaign ultimately delivered.

On immigration, the capitulation was especially revealing. Previously in 2015, when Ezra Klein pressed Sanders on open borders, Sanders dismissed the idea as a “Koch brothers proposal,”^[60] arguing that it would expand the labor pool and suppress wages. That was not a right-wing aberration. It was historically normal labor politics. The political terrain shifted dramatically after Donald Trump descended the escalator at Trump Tower in June 2015 and made mass immigration the organizing theme of his campaign. In 2018, at close to the peak of the Trump derangement cycle, the writer Angela Nagle published a piece in a left-wing magazine^[61] making the straightforward labor-left case against open borders, citing not right-wing theory but the historical position of figures like A. Philip Randolph and arguing that cheap imported labor suppresses wages. This was not a fringe position. It was, for most of the history of the American labor movement, the default one. For that piece, Nagle was doxxed, harassed, and effectively erased from serious consideration on the left. That is what you got, in 2018, for holding a position that Bernie Sanders himself had held for most of his career. That is how far this stuff went. A labor movement that takes wages seriously cannot treat immigration purely as a moral question of humanitarian openness while ignoring the employer interest in an expanded labor supply. But after Trump, positions that had once been ordinary within the labor left became suspect if they sounded even remotely like something a Trump voter might say. This is how the woke tendency disciplines the left into impotence: not through argument, but through association. It does not ask, “Is this true?” It asks, “Could this be associated with the right?”

In 2020, Sanders tried to play on the woke left’s terms, and it didn’t work whatsoever. The most telling case was South Carolina. Biden crushed Sanders among Black voters by

approximately four to one, according to exit polling.^[62] Sanders, who had moved his campaign substantially toward the language of identity and coalition management, did not produce the Black working-class breakthrough the strategy was supposed to deliver. The Black voter in South Carolina was not the Black activist in a graduate seminar. Many wanted the candidate they associated with stability, familiarity, and the Obama legacy, not the candidate whose campaign vocabulary had been shaped by progressive professionals who believed they understood Black political interests better than Black voters themselves.

The consolidation behind Biden was not organic. Barack Obama played a well-documented coordinating role in pressuring other candidates to drop out and endorse Biden,^[63] and a concerted effort among Black Democrats and Black PMC figures to campaign heavily in the South spread the narrative that Bernie was too white. Prominent figures in Black media and popular culture, who had initially shown interest in Sanders, fell in line behind establishment Democrats. This pattern repeated from 2016, when the same dynamics played out on behalf of Clinton. It was documented. Few lessons were learned.

The professional-class theory of representation is false, and South Carolina proved it empirically. The left persistently confuses demographic categories with ideological blocs, then acts shocked when ordinary people inside those categories do not vote the way university activists expect. The Black working class is not the same as the Black PMC. The Latino working class is not the same as the Latino activist class. First-world feminist activists and girlboss corporate careerists don't represent all women. Gay voters are not the same as queer-theory academics. This confusion is not a purely intellectual error. It is a structurally motivated one: the professional-class operatives who shape left strategy benefit from treating themselves as the authentic voice of the communities they claim to represent. They are not. They are the professional apparatus that sits between those communities and genuine political representation.

There is an objection to all of this that deserves to be taken seriously. Some analysts have argued that Sanders performed as well as he did in 2016 not because of any groundswell for socialism but because a great deal of his support was driven by animosity toward Hillary Clinton. The evidence offered is that Sanders, who had been an independent before he entered the Democratic primary, brought large numbers of people into the party who had never been Democrats and who registered specifically in order to vote for him. This cannot be the whole explanation for his support. **But there is a rational kernel in it, and that kernel supports my argument rather than undermining it.**

Political support is very often driven more by what people oppose than by what they support. The appeal of Donald Trump was in large part a reaction: a hatred of the Democrats, a sense of betrayal by them, and a contempt for what Chris Hedges called the liberal class. Most of the people who voted for him had no firm expectation that he would deliver on his promises. What they knew was that he was against the people they disliked, which made him the lesser evil. The same logic runs in the other direction. A great deal of Democratic support in the post-Trump era, across the Clinton, Biden, and Harris campaigns alike, has

been driven by hatred of Trump rather than by enthusiasm for Democrats. People frequently vote on the basis of what they want to stop.

So the fact that a portion of Sanders's 2016 support was anti-Clinton is not a weakness of that campaign. It is how political coalitions actually assemble, and it points to the opposite of the conclusion progressives drew in 2020. They had internalized the accusation that criticizing Clinton was sexist, and advised him toward a softer, rainbow-coalition posture in which he competed on his opponents' terms rather than his own. **The correct lesson was to intensify the 2016 approach, not to abandon it:** to go after the Democratic establishment harder and more explicitly, and for the leftists campaigning for him to mark the distinction between themselves and the left they were opposing rather than dissolving it into left unity. He softened instead. He lost his grit, a great many people noticed, and the map of states he won and lost in 2020 reflects it.

This bears directly on the objection that will be raised against the argument of this essay: that a class-first left which confronts the woke tendency openly will alienate minorities and drive left-wing people away. That objection counts only the people already inside the left's imagined constituencies and ignores everyone outside them. A class-first left that was openly and vehemently antagonistic toward the synthetic PMC liberal left would attract people precisely because of that antagonism, including a great many who currently vote for nobody at all. A large percentage of people do not vote in most elections, and many of them despise both sides. **If you believe left-wing candidates win by first converting everyone to leftist principles, you have misunderstood how politics works.**

The Left's Civil War

The 2016 and 2020 democratic primaries were two revealing instances that exposed the underlying civil war within the left, which leftists tried to forget about later. Perhaps the most concentrated single illustration of where the PMC-left had arrived by 2020 was the endorsement choices of Angela Davis and Judith Butler. These are self-described communists, people who have built entire careers on critiquing capitalism and its cultural apparatus, who chose to support Kamala Harris over Bernie Sanders in the primary.^[64] Their stated rationale amounted to the claim that a woman president was a prerequisite for social democracy, that the symbolic representation question had to be answered before the material one could be addressed. The fact that two of the most prominent intellectuals on the far left could not bring themselves to support the most left-wing candidate in the race, in part because he was too old and too white, is a testament to what the *PMC-left's* actual priorities were beneath their radical posturing. Nor is this simply a case of late-career accommodation to liberalism. Davis had already demonstrated the priority of symbolic ideology over material outcomes much earlier. In the 1970s, she vehemently opposed the Wages for Housework movement, which proposed compensating women directly for domestic labor, in effect a basic income that would have expanded women's economic independence from both husbands and employers. Davis rejected this on the grounds that it would "entrench gender roles" and "send women back to the kitchen," preferring the communist prescription of

collectivized childcare and mass female workforce participation, which she argued would expand the proletariat and accelerate the conditions for revolution. Whatever the merits of the Wages for Housework proposal, Davis's rejection of it was not a materialist argument. It was an ideological one: it prioritized the symbolic meaning of women's labor over the concrete economic independence of actual women. The fact that Angela Davis endorsed Kamala Harris, a former prosecutor with one of the most hawkish incarceration policies in California, tells us a lot about why we shouldn't take someone seriously just because they say they care about class. One of the most infamous "communist" icons in the United States, a lifelong advocate of prison abolition, endorsed a top prosecutor over the man who had the most left-wing economic agenda says a lot.

During the 2020 Democratic primary, I observed that self-described progressives consistently preferred Warren or Buttigieg over Sanders, offering rationalizations about Sanders being too old, too white, or insufficiently electable. When the field narrowed to a contest between Sanders and Biden, the same people migrated to Biden on electability grounds, despite the fact that their previously preferred candidates had no credible path to a general election and Sanders had demonstrated actual crossover appeal. The rationalizations shifted with the field; the conclusion remained constant. What presented itself, on the surface, as principled concern about identity and representation was, structurally, a class preference. These were people whose political priorities aligned with the professional-managerial strata, and Sanders, whatever his policies, was not the candidate for them.

Sanders repeatedly held back. He refrained from going hard after Warren when she functioned as his most dangerous ideological competitor. Warren declined to exit the race until the last possible moment, functioning as a vote-splitter long after any plausible path to the nomination had closed for her. She was waiting, as subsequent events suggested, for a position in the Biden administration, which, in the end, she was never offered. A candidate presenting herself as the ideologically aligned alternative to Sanders held in the race specifically to prevent the more serious progressive from winning. The left largely declined to state this with the clarity it deserved. Sanders declined to campaign against Biden on the terms that would have distinguished them most sharply, because the entire logic of "left unity" had trained the left to believe that the real enemy was always the right, never the Democratic establishment that blocks every material reform the left claims to care about. Anyone with eyes could see that **the biggest obstacle to Bernie Sanders**, and to universal healthcare, a jobs guarantee, and the whole suite of social-democratic policies, **was the Democrats**, not Trump. **"Unite against the right" sounds like solidarity. In practice, it functions as a permanent injunction against fighting the forces immediately in front of you.**

Sanders further compromised himself by accepting a position in the Biden administration, hoping to exert leverage from within a coalition that had no structural interest in his agenda. Perhaps he shifted some things at the margins. It was not enough for the working class to register, and it was more than enough for them to associate him with the administration's

failures. The most consequential of those failures was the border. Immigration, particularly illegal border crossings, increased rapidly under Biden. Sanders himself has since acknowledged that the border was the Biden administration's single biggest catastrophic failure.^[65] He did not say so while he was part of that administration. He said it after.

Furthermore, the premises of the identity narrative have been disproven by the last three elections. Biden, who was portrayed as the least progressive on racial issues, won more Black voters than Kamala Harris did, by a wide margin. It was under Kamala Harris that Black voters shifted significantly toward the Republican Party.^[66] No one chose Kamala Harris as the Democratic nominee through a primary process. That Biden outperformed Harris among the very constituency the identity framework treats as its core electoral base is decisive evidence that the professional-class theory of representation does not hold, and that electoral outcomes are not determined by identity symbolism in the one-dimensional way the woke left has insisted.

In effect, Sanders had tolerated a faction that ensured his movement could never become the serious working-class political force it claimed to be. This is not a verdict on Sanders himself, whose policy commitments remain far superior to most of what the Democratic Party has offered. It is a verdict on the strategic logic of accommodation. When a working-class political project tolerates, even if it does not emulate, the woke tendency within its coalition, it enables that tendency to dominate the movement's public face, alienates the people who most need to be convinced, and ultimately loses to the people more willing to perform the correct symbolic politics without delivering any of the economic substance. A campaign can be led by someone who personally does not believe in the latest progressive orthodoxy, but if that campaign is staffed, narrated, disciplined, and morally policed by people who do, the campaign will eventually be shaped by them. **The figurehead may be old-school. The machine will not be.**

A Theory of the Two Lefts

The unlearned lesson of the two Bernie Sanders campaigns is that they exposed the reality that there are **two lefts** within the broader camp that proudly claims, "the left": **a class-first left** that prioritizes bread-and-butter economic issues, and **acultural left** that prioritizes radical social change. The latter is the faction that tends to be the most associated with "wokeness" as it prioritizes first-world cultural problems and tends to be driven by the professional managerial class or PMC aspirants.

The left describes its own divisions almost entirely in doctrinal terms. Social democrats, anarchists, Marxists of every hyphenated variety, Maoists, and left communists all understand themselves to be separated by questions of theory and strategy, and the sectarian energy devoted to policing those borders is considerable. What these categories conspicuously fail to do is predict anything. **On paper there are a dozen lefts. In practice there are two, and the line between them runs not through doctrine but through the class formation of the people who hold it.**

The most misleading of the doctrinal axes, and the one that does the most work in hiding the real divide, is the spectrum running from moderate to radical. There are moderate ends and radical ends of both the cultural left and the class-first left. Thinking about the left only in terms of radical against moderate obscures the fact that cultural radicals on the far left often have more in common with moderate cultural leftists than they do with radical class-first leftists, let alone moderate ones. **What I want to debunk is the idea that people who call themselves communists or socialists are necessarily more committed to class politics.** You would think they would be. Whether they are is revealed by their actions and their priorities. They may say they are one thing and in practice get heated, even narcissistic, about small differences and small disagreements over culture, and they will seem radical by rejecting reforms and dismissing them as insignificant when for the working class those reforms are often very significant.

All of these differences get obfuscated, because **the real conflict is between the people who prioritize cultural revolution and cultural radicalism and the people who prioritize economic transformation. Material transformation, in other words, against consciousness transformation.** The class-first left is the one that serves people where they are.

None of this fits everyone neatly, and I acknowledge as much. There are exceptions to the rule, and people do not always fall into these boxes. You can find cultural radicals who are in fact working class: someone who is trans or LGBT may have a particular concern with those cultural issues in a way that most people in their cohort do not. But most of the time the people who put cultural radicalism before anything else are PMC people, because they can afford to be perpetual losers, leading with cultural radicalism ahead of class and never moderating their positions strategically. **If they had a serious concern with actually winning rather than just complaining, they would be doing something different in order to prevent the current trajectory.** They can afford to advocate radical positions with no actual possibility of succeeding because they sit in a more comfortable position; if anything they use that radicalism to establish a brand. They also love the identity material, because it gives them a competitive edge in a highly competitive symbolic-capitalist job market, especially in academia, which is a good part of what representation is about, and it doubles as a shield from criticism. It is not that cultural issues cannot matter to the working class. It is that their prioritization among the PMC has far more to do with careerism and the incentives running through the symbolic-capitalist industries, art, media, entertainment, and academia, than with the fact that they are first-world problems, all of which I have described at length across this series.

So the question is never who is more radical on the surface. It is the priorities people put forward and the actions, not just the words, that they take to advance them. If someone claims radicalism on culture and class and yet shows no willingness to adapt in order to reach masses of people and build a political project capable of working, their radicalism is a posture rather than a politics. Usually what they expect instead is a form of cultural consciousness-raising, because they think everything is politically impossible now and all

they can do is raise consciousness. **That is the surest sign of a woke PMC cultural leftist.**

The sociological groundwork for this is not new: what a symbolic capitalist is, and how that stratum came to hold the cultural authority it now holds, is the argument of Parts 1 and 2, which this section presupposes rather than restates. Part 1 also drew the distinction that does the most work for the present point, between the liberal variety of wokeism and the left variety. Neither camp is uniformly woke. A great many mainstream progressives are not, and a great many socialists and communists are not.

There are of course many left-wingers who do not fall neatly into either camp, and a good number who want to have their cake and eat it too, claiming class and cultural radicalism at once. Even so, there is a relatively easy way to tell a woke cultural leftist from a class-first leftist. **Class-first leftists concentrate on what people have in common: universalist principles, and the issues that help the greatest number of people. Cultural leftists concentrate on what sets people apart, on the minoritarian questions of race and gender that matter most to them as individuals.** The class-first leftist meets people where they are. The cultural leftist tends to regard himself as a member of an enlightened priestly class whose role is to enlighten the backward masses.

That difference in emphasis follows directly from a symbolic-capitalist, university-educated socialization. Cultural capital and a demonstrated commitment to cultural radicalism function as a badge of distinction, a way of separating oneself from other people, rather than as a contribution to a political project capable of reaching them. It shows in how these people act and in how reliably self-defeating their strategies are: leftism becomes a personal brand and an in-group rather than something that might actually succeed. **This is why, as I argued in Part 1, wokeism turns out to be anti-political in practice.** It opts for change through consciousness because it will not accept the common majority as it is. What it wants is for that majority to bend to the minority, to adopt minoritarian views and lifestyles rather than simply tolerate their coexistence.

This is why I resist the habit of treating wokeism as a liberal problem that the real left does not have. The claim comes in two forms, both evasive: either wokeism belongs to liberals and has been misattributed to socialists, or the woke are not the true left at all and can therefore be disowned without further examination. Each move defends the label instead of inspecting the behavior, and the behavior is the only thing that can settle the question. What someone calls themselves is not evidence. How radical they say they are is not evidence. **What they do and what they prioritize are.** I set out that test at length in [Anti-Social Socialists](#), and the short version is that a serious politics judges itself by measurable movement toward a concrete goal, while a performative one judges itself by how radical it looks to other radicals.

What a left tendency treats as grounds for excommunication tells you what it is actually for.

A clarification is necessary here, because the argument is easily mistaken for one I am not making. Nothing in this account holds that coming from the professional-managerial class

disqualifies a person from class politics, or that class origin settles political priority. Plenty of symbolic capitalists are class-first, and the clearest illustration sits in the campaigns already discussed. The 2016 Sanders operation was run largely by professional strategists and media people, which is to say by symbolic capitalists, and it produced the most substantively class-first campaign in modern American politics. What changed by 2020 was not the class composition of the staff. It was what the staff understood itself to be there to do.

Socialization shapes political inclination; it does not determine it. The symbolic capitalist appears in this argument to explain why cultural priorities are so common in one particular stratum, not as a standpoint epistemology in which an occupation issues a politics automatically.

There is one more reason for insisting on this particular line rather than the one now being offered by liberals. As the woke tendency has weakened, the critique of it has been picked up by centrist Democrats and their counterparts abroad, who are drawing the division where it suits them: between sensible moderates on one side and a far left treated as a single undifferentiated bloc of extremists on the other. That framing does not correct wokeism. It offers an occasion to bury socialism alongside it, and to file anti-Zionism under the same heading of embarrassing radicalism. I have no interest in that project, and the distinction I am drawing is not a route into it. Much of the documentary work that has made the woke record impossible to deny has come from writers in that camp, and Jamie Paul, whose *Memory-Hole Archive* series on Substack is a very useful empirical record documenting what went down during the peak woke era, is someone whose position on class I do not share. Crediting the record is not the same as adopting the frame. **The division that explains the last decade is not moderate against radical. It is cultural against class-first.**

The Left Unity Trap

One of the major things that prevents class-first leftists from reckoning with the contradictions between these *two lefts* is what might be called the *left unity trap*: the injunction, enforced through social and organizational pressure, to maintain solidarity with everyone who identifies as left-wing regardless of their organizational behavior or the compatibility of their politics with any viable working-class program. The result is a left that cannot discipline itself, cannot establish its own organizational authority, and cannot distinguish between the serious working-class politics it claims to advance and the status competition that actually drives a significant portion of its activist base.

One basis for so-called “left unity” that masks the conflict between these “two-lefts” is the notion of **shared enemies**. Two people who both despise Trump will assume they occupy the same side when the only thing established is that they dislike the same man. But they don’t always hate him for the same reason. I was always part of the class-first left who thought that Trump was a massive conman who wasn’t going to do anything to help ordinary people. What I detest most about the Trump presidency is his wars, incompetence, corporate handouts, the anti-labor policies of the Republican Party more broadly, and the fact that he cut Medicare and Medicaid. Yet left-wing media tends to critique Trump most of all for **the things that ordinary people care the least about**: his cutting of DEI, non-

politically correct antics, his reactionary *rhetoric*, and most of all: his immigration policy, which is carelessly handled, yet [still closer to the median voter's position](#) (and to Obama and Clinton's policies) than many cultural leftists like to admit.

The Hard Truth Most “Old Leftists” Don’t Want To Admit

Another reason why the class-first left fails to combat the influence of the woke cultural-left is that a lot of them are genuinely stuck in a 20th-century romantic image of what the left is (the legacy of the labor movement, the civil rights movement, the socialist movement, with its moderate and radical communist wings, etc.) when that is not what the modern left is anymore. These types of “class-first” leftists who identify more with “the old left” (or even the old New Left) often become part of the left for reasons that are completely different from the motives that drive woke people to embrace “leftism.” As a result, they remain *indifferent* to the culture wars that woke people fight with conservatives. Furthermore, because they think they are both part of this thing called “the left,” they often take the side of the woke leftist over the conservative by disposition, regardless of whether they thought about the issue at all. **They place more blame on the reactionary for reacting to the excesses of the cultural radicalism, rather than the woke leftist for pushing it in the first place.** But if they dare to challenge the woke leftist for burning the left to the ground with their culturally extreme first-world priorities, then they will face the same wrath that all of the figures who have been publicly “canceled” by the left have faced. Much of this all looks ridiculous to ordinary people outside of the progressive bubble, yet the “voices of the left” are still scared to meet the people where they are and against the woke minority. This is because these voices are *career leftists*, whose careers are built on a certain brand, and are especially prone to the threat of cancellation, which causes them to never challenge a wide range of thought taboos that prevent them from thinking about cultural matters, which I discussed in [my essay on the incentives that drive left-liberal conformism](#).

If you are a classical social democrat, a Marxist, a communist, a modern democratic socialist, or a leftist of any sort who prioritizes class and economic goals, then you should come to terms with the fact that **this is not what the actually existing left is, even if that’s what you want it to be.** You can define the left however narrowly you want; you can pick and choose which people you think are “real leftists” and which people are just “liberals,” but for your average median voter, these distinctions mean nothing. The reality is that the average person associates “the left” with a mixture of cultural radicalism, economic populism, and the various tendencies often associated with wokeism, regardless of whether they support it or not. And the important thing is that this image of the left is **not a product of mere propaganda**, but of the reality of what the existing left has become. That is not what the left has to be, as the class-first left does in fact exist, but it has been subordinated to the broader PMC cultural left. At the end of the day, both are subordinated to **liberal progressives, like the Democratic Party**, who can perpetually get away with neglecting the working class while paying lip service to activist rhetoric during primaries.

How Pseudo-Radicalism Masks the Divide Between *the Two Lefts*

Another overlooked problem that often blinds many class-first leftists to the reality of *the two lefts* is the phenomenon of *pseudo-radicalism*. This is a more subtle, ambiguous phenomenon that obfuscates the clear divergence in *real commitments* between cultural radicals and leftists committed to economic issues of civilizational importance. **The cultural left does not announce itself as liberalism.** It speaks in the vocabulary of revolution, liberation, and emancipation, and that vocabulary is what allows class-first socialists to read it as a “comrade” rather than a _temporary_ ally with divergent interests. When somebody denounces empire, celebrates armed resistance abroad, and decorates their politics with Black Panther iconography, the reasonable inference is that you are dealing with someone to your left. **The inference is usually wrong, because radical aesthetics and radical commitments are not the same thing, and the first is far cheaper to acquire.**

The distinction between **the two lefts** often gets blurred because many cultural radicals pay lip service to class and throw it into their “intersectionality” equation that prioritizes race and gender in actual practice. There are people who call themselves “socialists” or “communists” who might LARP about reading Karl Marx, but in practice are more committed to *cultural revolution* than to mobilizing the working class against the power of global capital. The façade of their radicalism is revealed whenever they dogpile any sane person on the left who is any more socially conservative than a liberal after 2014, yet they will corral around the Democrats, or some pinkwashed liberal party every election to strategically vote out the threat of “fascism.” The endorsement choices discussed earlier are the purest form of this. Angela Davis and Judith Butler are not confused twenty-year-olds working their politics out in public; they are two of the most credentialed communist intellectuals alive, and both passed over the most left-wing candidate in the field in favor of Kamala Harris. **If the veneer of radicalism holds that far up the left-wing intelligentsia, there is little chance of the class-first left detecting it further down. Due to the confusing mix of genuine radical reformers and radical LARPer within the left-wing activist base, most left-wing “thought leaders” and even left-wing politicians (as seen with Zohran Mamdani, Jeremy Corbyn, and Bernie Sanders’s concessionary pivot in 2020) feel the need to appeal to the demands of both the cultural-left and the class-first left, even though the cultural-radicals are a loud minority.** This should be self-evident given that their demands of the cultural-left resonate with far fewer people than the universal economic issues that the class-first left prioritizes, which is why the political right always likes to attack the left on culture wars rather than on economics, **because culture has become the left’s most obvious weak point.**

In a 2026 conjoint experiment, political scientists David E. Broockman and Joshua L. Kalla presented 6,000 registered voters who had participated in the 2024 general election with hypothetical 2028 presidential candidates assigned different policy positions. Democratic candidates gained their largest electoral returns by moving away from the party’s standard positions on social and cultural questions, especially affirmative action, race-targeted business assistance, school policy on gay and lesbian issues, asylum admissions, and medical transitions for minors; moving toward the middle on economic questions produced no comparable benefit. Republicans showed the reverse, gaining roughly four to six

percentage points when they moderated on healthcare, the minimum wage, Social Security, and prescription drugs. Fewer than 10 percent of respondents consistently chose Democratic, Republican, or middle positions across the five issues on which their own views were measured.^[67] The electorate is cross-pressured in precisely the direction the contemporary left seems least capable of representing: left-leaning on many economic questions and closer to the center or right on several cultural ones.

The tendency of cultural radicalism has been around the left since the 1960s and is documented in detail in historian Christopher Lasch's work (especially in *The Revolt of the Elites*, *The Agony of the American Left*, and *The Culture of Narcissism*), but it wasn't until the past few years that it really became especially clear to me that the line between the "real left" and the pseudo-left radicals was very blurry. After October 2023, when being pro-Palestine became the fashionable "current thing" for left-wing activist types, I saw a lot of people who I *know* weren't really invested in socialist politics suddenly put on their keffiyehs after they previously had the Ukraine flag or [#BlackLivesMatter](#) in their bio. A substantial layer of left-wing social media influencers and "video essayists" with urban middle class/upper middle-class university-educated backgrounds, who had built their audiences largely on cultural issues like feminism, LGBTQ representation, and racial identity politics rather than any serious engagement with class issues, began openly promoting a lot of "radical" stuff regarding "decolonization" that was often not easy to separate from genuine anti-imperialism. **"Decolonization" is one of the "radical" things that the cultural leftist types like to LARP about, because it is much easier to cheer on radical movements outside of one's country (or ones that no longer exist) that they are far removed from than it is to build radical movements with the people in your own country.**

You see this often with leftists less than a few years into their "radicalization" phase promoting "leftism 101" reading recommendations, typically with books like Paulo Freire's *Pedagogy of the Oppressed*, Frantz Fanon's *The Wretched of the Earth*, Angela Davis's *Are Prisons Obsolete?*, Judith Butler's *Gender Trouble*, Walter Rodney's *How Europe Underdeveloped Africa*, Edward Said's *Orientalism*, Peter Kropotkin, sometimes Lenin, and various radical thinkers who have very little useful to offer for today's political context. I even saw some of these cultural leftists (who would have previously clocked any talk about The Israel Lobby as a "Nazi" talking point) **posting "introduction to Hamas" books as recommended reading and lots of pro-Hamas messaging in general.** This surprised me as a Lebanese Canadian who got into left-wing politics at a very young age through anti-imperialism and figures like Noam Chomsky and Richard Wolff, and politics of democratic socialism that eventually busted onto the scene during the first Bernie Sanders campaign in 2016.

Those familiar with my anti-Zionist positions would know that I don't blame the Palestinians for militant resistance, as I blame the state of Israel for causing the October 7th attacks to happen. However, my point here about the woke people suddenly becoming interested in Palestine is to use this as one of the many examples of how **the pseudo-radicalism of cultural leftists often causes class-first leftists to give them a pass and only identify**

“liberals” as the problem. If someone on “the radical left” is willing to support a highly problematic right-wing Islamist group like Hamas but isn’t willing to even support a socialist project capable of reaching the working-class in their own countries, then what does this say about the nature of their “radicalism”? The pattern is the point: **people with no demonstrated commitment to class politics sometimes latch on to the most maximalist position available on whatever question happens to be fashionable. This appearance of “radicalism” masks their fundamental opposition to the class-first left,** which is revealed by their luxury beliefs and first-world problems that they prioritize above material ones.

As I showed in a previous essay, [The Myth of the Movement](#), one way to cut through the illusion of “the left” is to ask what “the movement” actually punishes. **How many people on the left have been expelled or driven out of an organization for being insufficiently committed to economic redistribution?** They are never about the issues that matter most to most working people. They are about the issues that matter most to the activist rebel priest class: sex, gender, and race. A movement’s real hierarchy of values is legible in what it treats as unforgivable. This is what the sympathetic critics of wokeism miss. Their gentle version of the complaint grants that the underlying concerns are genuine and faults only the messaging. The harder possibility is that the commitment of many PMC leftists is *not sincere*.

If Wokeism Is So Fringe, Then Why Doesn’t the Left Reject It?

The most common defense for not opposing the woke tendencies on the left that you often hear from the agnostic “neither woke nor anti-woke” crowd is that wokeism is largely an “online” phenomenon, loud and omnipresent on social media but not representative of how most voters actually think or what most people actually care about. This observation is largely correct. It leads, however, to entirely the wrong conclusion. The fact that wokeism is not as popular as its online presence makes it appear is not the strongest argument for tolerating it. It is the strongest argument for confronting it directly and rejecting it. The very gap between wokeism’s online dominance and its genuine popular support is what makes the confrontation both necessary and, ultimately, winnable.

To understand why, it is necessary to distinguish between different kinds of political actors, because they are not all the same and the failure to separate them analytically is one of the central sources of confusion on this question. There are voters. There are activists. There are influencers. There are campaign staffers. There are journalists. There are nonprofit operatives. There are people in university departments, party apparatuses, media operations, and activist networks who do not represent the working class but who have tremendous institutional power over how “the left” is narrated to the public, how its candidates are advised, and how its organizations police their own members. The ordinary voter is not the same as the online leftist with a Substack, a podcast, a graduate degree, and a professional incentive to turn every political question into a status competition over

language, identity, and moral hygiene. The average voter is not sitting around deciding whether a socialist campaign has adequately centered the most recent academic innovation in gender theory. The average person is worried about rent, wages, groceries, healthcare, immigration, family stability, and whether the people claiming to represent them seem remotely sane.

This is why the power of wokeism is so consistently misunderstood. Woke politics is not powerful because it commands a mass majority among voters. It is powerful because it occupies strategic positions in the institutions that shape political narrative: universities, media, publishing, nonprofits, party offices, activist organizations, HR departments, NGOs, and campaign communications teams. Its power is not primarily electoral. Its power is narrative, bureaucratic, symbolic, and disciplinary. This is also precisely why the post-woke response fails. The post-woke person says “relax, this stuff is mostly online.” But if it is mostly online, why are politicians so terrified of it? Why do campaign staffers talk this way? Why do left-wing organizations adopt its rituals? Why do people get publicly humiliated for failing to repeat the correct formula on demand? Why did Tim Walz visibly freeze when asked simple questions like “What is a woman?”^[68] These may seem like silly culture-war traps, and in one sense they are. But they work because they expose something real: that much of the left no longer feels capable of saying obvious things in public without first checking whether some activist faction will accuse it of bigotry. That exposure is damaging not because the questions are important in themselves but because the freezing reveals the disciplinary power that the woke faction exercises over the left’s ability to communicate with ordinary people. **Wokeism is a paper tiger that survives only because everyone is too afraid to touch it.**

Wokeism As a Paper Tiger

The common arguments deployed by liberals & leftists to justify tolerating wokeism *contradict one another* in ways that are rarely acknowledged. On one hand, some “class-first” leftists argue that the woke faction must not be challenged publicly because doing so would fracture left unity. On the other, many of the same people insist that wokeism is an overrepresented minority phenomenon, loud online but insignificant in the real world. **These arguments contradict each other in a serious way.** If wokeism is genuinely insignificant, there is no strategic case for unity with it: unity with something irrelevant is not solidarity; it is a category error. If it is significant enough to warrant unity, then it is significant enough to warrant confrontation.

The most common argument for accommodation is that challenging woke people within left movements is too politically costly. This argument is at least honest, as it admits that capitulating to woke is necessary because of the power woke people still have in gatekeeping the left, rather than pretending it doesn’t exist or isn’t a big deal. Although the power that woke people have over the left is real, it is significantly inflated in the grand scheme of things. In reality, **wokeism is a paper tiger that is kept alive by an overrepresented minority** of people in symbolic-capitalist spaces (media, academia, art,

entertainment, NGOs, political activism, etc.). These people tend to exert a massive influence over left-wing spaces, but have **lost much of their influence over the majority of people whom left-wing organizations should appeal** to, because their agendas and ways of culturally revolutionizing society from the top down are **unpopular**. Wokeism has been in visible retreat ever since Trump's second victory in 2024, when corporations and mainstream media institutions quietly abandoned the gestures that had defined the era: the speech codes, the DEI departments, the token representation, the mandatory language guides, and, after Musk's purchase of Twitter, the migration of much of the woke commentariat to Bluesky. As it has declined, many leftists have tried to memory-hole the whole thing, to act as though it never happened or was never a big deal, and yet the paradox I have traced in earlier essays, particularly [The Next Awakening](#) and [Anti-Social Socialists: How the Left Became a Freak Show](#), is that woke now appears dead everywhere except on the left itself, because left-wing spaces are the last places that will grant the woke PMC rebel-priest class refuge and a platform on which to build social and symbolic capital. **Far from making woke a passé topic not worth discussing, this is exactly what makes the present the most critical moment for the left to reject it:** the woke minority has lost most of the leverage it once held, and a left that refuses to move on when everyone else already has will never meet people where they are.

Why Accommodating Woke Fails

One of the most common retorts to anti-woke leftists is that “we” should “be careful” when critiquing wokeism, in order not to “alienate” people. But *who* exactly are these people who are supposedly at risk of being alienated from left-wing politics if woke tendencies are to be rejected or challenged? My retort to this objection is that the left alienates far more people from left-wing politics overall by capitulating to the woke minority than it would by rejecting some of the woke cultural dogmas that have proliferated since 2012 (see the Genealogy of Wokeism Part 1). If we are talking about voters, the woke constituency is not a significant electoral bloc, and it is certainly not one that can be offset by winning over new people who had been previously alienated from left-wing politics. **By capitulating to woke dogmas and trying to appease woke ideologues, you lose far more people than you gain.** You lose the ordinary people who are either voting for the populist right or not voting at all. By rejecting woke, you are not going to alienate many ordinary voters. You will alienate staffers, activists, and PMC-type operatives. The math is clear. **Accommodating woke cripples the left.**

A working-class political project that rejected woke disruption publicly would call the bluff in real time: it would reveal that what the woke faction actually cares about is the preservation of its own political terrain, not the material welfare of the groups it invokes. A politics that would abandon universal healthcare and housing cost reduction because the program does not conform to the preferred gender discourse of its PMC leadership is not a politics of liberation. Most people can see this, and the exposure is more achievable than the left's habitual self-censorship suggests.

The mistake is not merely being woke. The mistake is tolerating woke people as if they are simply one faction within a broad coalition that can be managed through tact and good manners. That is precisely how they win. They enter a movement, often in the language of justice, compassion, inclusion, and marginality, but their practical function is to narrow the movement's appeal, moralize every disagreement, alienate ordinary people, and transform a politics of the common good into a politics of symbolic status competition disguised as social justice. They do not merely bring bad opinions. They bring an entire style of politics: the pronoun rituals, the point-of-privilege culture, the anxious language policing, the moral blackmail, the obsession with representation over material interest, and the institutional inability to distinguish the working class from the professional-managerial activists who claim to speak on its behalf. Wokeism does not merely backfire on the true believers of woke causes. **It has negatively shaped the organizational culture around the left more broadly, impacting what staffers are willing to say in public, setting the terms on which candidates are advised, and ultimately determining what the movement looks and sounds like to people encountering it for the first time.**

What Is to Be Done?

Given the highly different priorities of the woke cultural left and the class-first left, the premise that something called "left unity" is a coherent or desirable strategic goal is itself the error. For the class-first left, maintaining solidarity with a woke faction that actively sabotages class politics is not a tactical compromise. **It is surrender rationalized as principle.** A left that refuses to challenge the woke tendency from within will find itself permanently *held hostage to it*. **The class-first left's primary obstacle is not the right. It is the left-wing establishment: the synthetic left, the race-first left, the cultural left.** These are people who invoke class intermittently, but do so in the most self-defeating terms available. The lesson the Sanders campaigns should have produced is straightforward: **the biggest enemy of a class-first left is the existing left.** A class-first politics that treats the woke faction as a manageable annoyance, rather than as the primary organizational obstacle to its own emergence, is a politics that has already accepted defeat. Leftists who want to see a movement for class politics in their lifetime (what Adolph Reed Jr. called "socialism for grown-ups") must have the courage to stand up to the woke activists. The Woke-HR left must be stripped of the privileged position of dominance that the left gives in order for a viable socialist or social democratic agenda to have any real room to flourish.

All of this might seem like tiresome old news, yet the class-first left still hasn't taken the lesson to its logical conclusion, if they have even internalized it at all. The underlying logic here is straightforward enough to state plainly. You cannot work with the beehive on the beehive's terms. You can manage around it, signal that you are not opposed to it, and pursue a different agenda while avoiding direct confrontation. What you cannot do is build a serious political project inside it without eventually being attacked by it. The only productive relationship is one in which the woke tendency subordinates itself to a broader populist coalition organized around more important priorities. If the woke people abandon socialist organizations because they are insufficiently pro trans, support limits on migration, and no

longer do pronoun and privilege-checking bullshit, then so be it. They can find a new home in the Green Parties that they used to dominate prior to the *great awakening* (described in part 1). The left unity illusion prevents the class-first left from doing what needs to be done to **reclaim dominance over the left that it has lost.**

The Correct Answer to “Throwing Minorities Under the Bus”

The standard objection to class-first leftism and any of the things I am proposing is that it “throws minorities under the bus.” It means: are you going to deprioritize first-world PMC concerns in favor of kitchen-table issues that affect the actual working majority? The honest answer is yes, and that answer requires no apology. The kitchen-table issues, healthcare, wages, housing, working conditions, are the issues that most materially affect minority working-class people, who constitute the overwhelming majority of the minority populations the woke left claims to champion. **A program that delivers universal healthcare benefits a working-class Black family in Detroit enormously more than any DEI initiative.** A policy that substantially reduces housing costs in American cities benefits minority renters more than any land acknowledgment or pronoun mandate.

The standard objection to this framing is that the left need not choose, that class politics and cultural politics can simply coexist. This misunderstands the structural problem. The conflict is not primarily one of attention or bandwidth. The deeper issue, as this series has documented, is that many woke cultural positions are not merely unpopular but substantively wrong. They will be exposed as such whenever they are interrogated directly, whether by political opponents, by evidence, or by ordinary people who encounter them and find them disconnected from reality. A left-wing political program that bundles popular material demands with ridiculous, unserious demands is shooting itself in the foot. For instance, the recent DSA program still commits to a complete freedom of movement policy, which is essentially a euphemism for open borders, and folds the medicalization of gender dysphoria, including hormone treatment and gender-affirming surgery, into its Medicare for All proposal, with the fuller platform calling for trans minors to access that care without parental consent. [69] That the DSA still feels the need to package these highly unpopular positions, which arguably are not even good policies from a left-wing standpoint, alongside its genuinely popular economic demands is clear evidence that it remains beholden to the priorities of the cultural left. It hands the right a standing refutation every time it is asked to defend those positions publicly.

There is a further dimension to this that needs stating plainly. For all the urgency that progressive activists bring to questions of gay rights, transgender rights, and women’s rights, the basic fact is that most of these battles, as far as the existing capitalist system is capable of resolving them, have already been won. The United States legalized gay marriage before countries like Israel even considered it. Women now earn 58 percent of all bachelor’s degrees and 62 percent of all master’s degrees, and outperform men at every level of education from primary school through graduate programs. [70] The remaining structural barriers women face, the impossibility of balancing caregiving with full-time employment,

delayed childbearing, the growing difficulty of finding a stable partner, are not problems that any existing feminist framework has shown any capacity to address, because they are consequences of the political economy itself rather than of residual patriarchal attitudes. A sensible response to this situation is not to keep pushing the cultural frontier further and further into territory that alienates the very people whose support is needed. It is to consolidate the substantial gains that have been made and to defend them. The quickest way to lose those gains is to overstep: to push an ideological agenda into schools, children's media, and public institutions that the majority of the population did not ask for and does not support. This wave of anti-trans sentiment that has swept Western politics did not emerge from nowhere. For a considerable period, most people were perfectly willing to live and let live. What changed was not a spontaneous eruption of bigotry but a reaction to a concerted institutional push that most ordinary people, including many who consider themselves socially liberal, experienced as an imposition. Any left that is serious about its own future should be defending the rights it has won, not gambling them on an escalation that is producing precisely the backlash it claims to oppose.

When a class-first leftist faces this accusation, the correct response is not defensiveness. It is to reverse the question. If the people leveling the charge would genuinely prefer to see the left lose to right-wing populism rather than relinquish their maximalist cultural positions, they are implicitly conceding that they do not care about the working-class majority, a majority that includes the very minorities they invoke. The minorities who face the most acute material conditions stand to gain most from pro-working-class economic policy. The PMC operatives who trade on their minority identities to legitimize their own agendas, and advance their own career trajectories within professional and activist institutions, are not the same as the working-class minority. That conflation is not an accident; it is the mechanism by which professional-class interests are laundered as progressive solidarity. Do not cower to that pressure. The correct response is to go on the offensive.

If you factor in the reality of cause and effect, some of the arguments that woke people use to gaslight leftists into capitulating to their nonsense can be flipped on their head and turned against them. When woke people accuse so-called "class reductionist" leftists of throwing minorities under the bus, **what they are really asking is whether you are willing to throw *them*, the woke social climbers, off the bus.** The woke left losing to right-wing populism is what is actually making conditions worse for the minorities they claim to represent. **They are the ones** who end up throwing working-class minorities under, and they do it **while speaking in their name.**

Don't Give Them an Inch

Consider what the presence of woke activists inside left spaces actually does to the people most needed for a working-class politics. The rituals described above, the constant policing of vocabulary, the implied accusation that every instinct the ordinary person has is suspect until it has been purified by the correct theoretical framework: these are not minor aesthetic complaints. They are structural barriers that keep ordinary people out of left spaces, working-class men in particular, who read the atmosphere immediately and do not feel welcome in it.

The left cannot function as a big tent for the working majority while simultaneously operating as a seminar in progressive etiquette. As long as the woke tendency is treated as one faction among many rather than as an organizational problem to be solved, the tent will keep shrinking.

A separate and equally serious problem operates inside these spaces rather than at their threshold. Many people already participating in left-wing organizations are not true believers in woke ideology. They sit through the rituals, mouth the approved vocabulary, and avoid raising objections because the social costs of visible dissent are immediate and real: loss of organizational standing, exclusion from professional networks, the reputational damage that follows from being tagged as regressive by a vocal minority with significant institutional leverage. Their compliance is not agreement; it is the management of fear.

The problem is not that most people secretly love wokeism. The problem is that many people privately dislike it and publicly tolerate it. A politics willing to say what most people already think, without first calibrating itself against the likelihood of activist disapproval, does not need to convince the majority of anything new. It only needs to give the majority permission to acknowledge what it already believes.

This means the argument cannot be “stop talking about woke.” **The argument has to be: defeat it.** Expel it from the commanding heights of the left. Break its moral authority. Make it costly to bring woke organizational culture into a serious political project. Make it clear, through consistent practice rather than rhetorical gesture, that this is not the politics of the working class, not the politics of social democracy, not the politics of a movement that intends to win. This does not require making wokeism the primary obsession of the left, and the right’s error is to do exactly that, turning the culture war into an end in itself rather than a barrier to be cleared. The task is to clear the barrier efficiently and return to the politics that actually matters: wages, housing, healthcare, labor power, and the reconstruction of a working majority capable of contesting the institutional dominance of concentrated wealth.

The strategy of simply ignoring the woke tendency, of treating it as a manageable nuisance, of waiting for it to exhaust itself without being actively confronted, is itself a form of woke thinking. Wokeism is, at its core, a politics of consciousness: the belief that if enough people think the right things, if enough people are awakened to correct ideas, reality will conform. The agnostic post-woke strategy performs its own version of this logic: if we decline to acknowledge the problem, if we refuse to give it oxygen, it will cease to exist. That is not strategy. That is magical thinking in the passive mode, the belief that you can manifest a post-woke politics into being by refusing to look at what currently stands in the way. **It is not the kind of thing that will go away if we merely pretend it does not exist.** The voters do not need convincing. They have already moved on. The problem is not out there in the electorate. The problem is inside the organizations, the campaign staffs, the media ecosystems, and the activist networks that are supposed to be building something serious. That is where it needs to be confronted.

The choice is not between confronting wokeism and doing real politics. The choice is between confronting it now, on your own terms, or being confronted by its consequences later, on theirs. Most people are already waiting for someone to make that choice. They are simply waiting for someone to say it first.

Nothing to See Here Folks: Turning a Blind Eye

There is another and distinct failure mode, and in some ways it is the most revealing: the active dismissal of extreme woke positions as fringe inventions that serious people do not actually hold. The tendency is familiar. “Open borders, that is a crazy far-left idea, no one actually believes that.” Except the DSA has a freedom of movement position in its platform, which is functionally an open borders stance.^[71] “Family abolition, who on the left actually advocates that?” Except there is a real and documented current within communist, socialist-feminist, queer-theory, and radical-left traditions that treats the family not merely as something to reform but as an institution to abolish or transcend. This is not a right-wing hallucination. These are real positions, held by real people, published in real journals, advocated in real organizations. What post-woke people mistake for a mole is a much larger cancer that has grown far past the point of being marginal.

K-12 Radicalism and Gender-Race Education Revolution

A pinnacle example of wokeism being pushed on people who then rejected it is the attempt to revolutionize K-12 education. The writer Jamie Paul documented this excellently in his article on K-12 radicalism. Through the peak years a concerted effort ran across American primary and secondary education to remake the classroom along progressive ideological lines, recasting ordinary instruction as a vehicle for racial consciousness-raising and, increasingly, for a gender ideology that taught children their sex was a matter of self-declaration. **This was not the work of a few stray teachers acting on their own. It came through curricula, district policy, and state guidance**, and it routinely came at the expense of the basic academic mission, as the pursuit of racial equity was used to justify lowering standards and scrapping selective admissions.

None of this was hidden. Anyone who was paying attention during those years watched it happen in real time. What Jamie Paul has done, in his *Memory-Hole Archive* series, is assemble the documentary record of it, case by case and with the primary sources attached, which makes it difficult for the progressives who now claim it never happened, or that they were never really part of it, to keep pretending.^[72] Paul is no reactionary; he is a self-described queer writer who came up through progressive politics. Readers who want to see the specifics, rather than take my word for the pattern, should read him. The point here is the general one: the agenda was organized, it was institutional, and it was imposed on the people least able to refuse it.

The Gender Wars Were Waged by the Wokes, and Rejected by the Right

If there is a single front on which the post-woke left most wants to declare the culture war imaginary, it is this one. The convenient line is that the alarm over gender was manufactured by the right, a distraction with no real content behind it. The opposite is true. Over the past decade a concerted campaign worked to redefine the most basic categories of human life, sex and woman among them. This campaign was pushed from above by the progressive professional class until it reached the level of law: executive action extending self-identification into single-sex spaces, and a proposed Equality Act, which Democrats passed through the House almost without a single Republican vote, that would have written gender identity into the legal meaning of sex throughout federal statute. This was not a fantasy of Fox News. It was the program of the institutions the left controls.

And it was felt. Ordinary people, very many of them parents, saw what was being taught to their children and what was being demanded of their own speech, and they rejected it, which is a large part of why parents have drifted toward the Republicans. Here again the point does not stand or fall on any single anecdote, and here again Jamie Paul has done the documentary work, in an essay in the same series devoted to the sex and gender front, for anyone still inclined to deny that the campaign was real.^[73]

A few years ago, I was hearing right-wing commentators claim that trans activists actually wanted children to be able to transition without parental consent, and as early as possible. I dismissed this. I said on air that no one clearly believed that, because it seemed too extreme for any serious person to advocate. When I expressed that view, I received a flood of comments from pro-trans advocates arguing the exact opposite: that puberty blockers and early medical intervention were essential to prevent suicide in trans youth, and that access should be as early and as unrestricted as possible. There is also a practical argument many activists make, though they do not always lead with it: transitioning earlier allows a person to present more convincingly as the opposite sex, because puberty has not yet produced its physical effects. Once I actually examined what the activist positions were, rather than assuming they matched what a reasonable person would hold, I found they were substantially more extreme than I had assumed.

None of this constitutes an argument against trans people or against their basic legal rights as adults. Respecting people's rights does not require agreeing with their ideology. The specific concern here is narrower and, frankly, harder to dismiss: the application of puberty-blocking and hormonal protocols to minors on the basis of a clinical rationale that the evidence has since substantially undermined.

The centerpiece of that rationale was the claim that puberty blockers prevent suicide in gender-dysphoric youth, and that withholding them constitutes a medical emergency. Multiple systematic reviews have since found no significant effect of puberty suppression on suicide rates.^[74] The claim that blockers are a suicide-prevention measure of demonstrated efficacy is no longer scientifically defensible in the way activists have presented it. What remains is a protocol that delays puberty, with permanent physiological consequences for bone density, fertility, and neurological development, on the basis of presenting preferences

that the evidence suggests are transient in a substantial proportion of adolescent cases. This is a public health question of the same type as the over-prescription of SSRIs, the aggressive medicalization of childhood attention disorders, or the pharmaceutical management of normal adolescent distress: a pattern in which a social problem is converted into a medical intervention that benefits pharmaceutical manufacturers and clinical providers, at potentially significant long-term cost to the patient. The left used to understand this dynamic and critique it. It has become ideologically costly to do so on this particular subject. That is itself an illustration of everything this essay has argued.

The point of all this is not to settle trans policy in an essay about class politics. The point is that there are positions people actually hold on the activist left, real positions with real institutional backing and real policy consequences, that post-woke people routinely dismiss as right-wing inventions. Once you realize these positions are real, and that they carry genuine political costs for any left that tolerates them, the correct response is to reject them clearly. Post-woke people avoid doing so because looking forces exactly that rejection, and the rejection carries real social risks. But **the courage to look, and to say what you find, is precisely what the post-woke left has so far refused to summon.**

Why Ignoring Culture War Enables Wokeism

Woke ideology functions as ideology in the classical sense: it rationalizes contradictions and legitimizes a worldview that serves the material interests of its holders. It tells the professional-managerial class that its cultural preferences are social justice, that its institutional advancement is a victory for the oppressed, and that the working people who resist its cultural program are simply too backwards to recognize their own interests. Every leftist who goes along with this framework to avoid social friction lends it exactly the legitimacy it needs to keep reproducing itself. The personal cost of compliance is low and immediate; the political cost is the entire class-first project, accumulated across a thousand organizational capitulations.

Not giving them an inch means not legitimizing their premises. This is simpler in practice than it sounds. Critiquing a bad idea when it originates from the left is not right-wing provocation. It is the minimum condition for intellectual honesty. A left that cannot criticize its own bad ideas from within has outsourced its self-correction mechanism to the right, and the right will use it. Every woke position that goes unchallenged inside the left becomes a gift to the right's most effective political operators, who will run it on loop until it has done the maximum possible damage to every constituency the left claims to represent.

“No War but Class War” is a Lazy Cop-Out

Woke people gravitate to culture. That is their natural terrain, for the structural reasons this series has traced from the beginning. By retreating away from culture and focusing only on class, the class-first left does not neutralize the woke tendency. It leaves the woke people totally in control of the cultural narratives and discourses that come to define The Left™. The problem in the first place is that many people who enter left-wing politics come from the

symbolic-capitalist strata of the PMC: they gravitate toward cultural issues, they hold woke positions on those issues, and they have every sociological incentive to maintain them. Due to their power in symbolic production, they shape the narratives. So when the class-first left abandons cultural terrain and speaks only about class, **it cedes the ground, literally, to the people generating the problem.** If class politics is ever going to win, it requires preventing the woke tendency from continuously derailing every left-wing project with its symbolic demands, and that will not happen unless the woke tendency is challenged directly. **To go beyond woke, you have to be against woke.** The left's response to the culture war should not be to have no position on it. It should be to figure out what is actually true, and what policy is actually good for most people.

If your political position sounds completely insane to the average person, the answer is not to improve the messaging or produce better propaganda. The question to ask is why it sounds that way. And maybe the answer is simple: **maybe we were wrong.** If you do not think seriously about cultural issues or automatically dismiss any critique someone on the left has of progressivism, then you end up not understanding the problems people have with your side. Just like right-wing Fox News watchers have a very distorted idea of what socialism is, leftists often have a very poor understanding of what people on the other side actually think, and fight with straw-man arguments. Leftists get told all the time that everyone on the right wants to “erase trans people,” stop all immigration, and make women into second-class citizens. They critique a straw-man bogeyman version of their opponents because they don't want to deal with their actual, more reasonable criticisms.

The important takeaway here is that you can't move beyond wokeism merely by turning a blind eye to it or passively disavowing in a way that pretends it is no longer a real problem. Truly being “post-woke” requires more than simply refusing to participate in woke discourses. It requires actually questioning the premises and ideological narratives that compel people to abide by it. This is not a demand to spend all of one's time denouncing woke. It's not to make opposing wokeism your entire personality and being a mirror anti-woke social justice warrior. The demand is narrower and more fundamental: to reject the *thought* taboos that wokeism has installed across the left, and to stop allowing those taboos to prevent people from thinking clearly about issues the left is currently not permitted to challenge.

What Discourse Is For

A natural objection arises at this point, one that any honest account of the premises of this series must address directly. If my theory of wokeism, articulated in the first two parts of the Genealogy of Wokeism series, posits that consciousness divorced from material reality does not drive political change, that what people think is largely downstream of what they materially experience, and that the woke mode of trying to change politics by first changing minds is a structural failure, then what, precisely, is the purpose of writing these essays? Is this not exactly the kind of *discourse voodoo*, the belief that changing the way people talk about things directly changes how things are done, that this series has spent its prior installments critiquing?

The answer requires a distinction that the woke mode of politics consistently collapses. There is a fundamental difference between discourse as propaganda and discourse as illumination. Discourse as propaganda assumes that if enough people can be persuaded to adopt the correct ideas, political change will follow: that the barrier between the existing order and the desired one is a problem of insufficient consciousness in the general population, to be resolved by the right intellectual vanguard saying the right things loudly enough and to enough people. This is precisely the woke epistemology this series has traced from evangelical revivalism through its secular descendants, and it fails for the same reason across all its iterations: it mistakes the direction of causation, assumes that changed ideas produce changed conditions, and builds a political practice on a fantasy of discourse as politically efficacious in itself.

Discourse as illumination operates on different premises. It does not assume that everyone who reads it will be converted to a shared worldview, or that such a conversion is the precondition for political progress. It assumes, more modestly, that illuminating and understanding the problem is a first step in trying to figure out what is to be done, and that clear thinking about real conditions, including real disagreements and real structural constraints, is a more useful starting point for political action than manufactured consensus around a set of correct ideas.

While leftists will often deny this by moving the goal post as to what counts as “left,” it is known that the left has had a much greater institutional presence in academia, art, and alternative media than it has with the working class on the ground. This is evidenced by how far culture and discourse have shifted to “the left” since 2010, despite the fact that this cultural dominance has not produced any political or economic gains for the working class majority. **If anything, the cultural dominance of the left has coincided with the left’s electoral *decline* and the inability to stop the sustained erosion of the welfare-state gains that an earlier, more materially grounded left had actually built.** The power to shape cultural discourse has not, in any of these cases, translated into the power to shape material conditions. That failure is not incidental. It is precisely what a politics organized around changing minds rather than changing conditions produces.

Not only does wokeism prioritize the wrong goals, the greatest irony is that it fails even at achieving those goals. It actually makes the things it is supposed to care about worse. Racism, misogyny, and anti-trans sentiments have arguably all gotten worse since the last Great Awakening. Woke obsessions with identity politics and “decentering” white male heteronormativity have contributed to the rise of white identity tribalism on the right and the emergence of the anti-feminist industrial complex (the “manosphere”). The inability of the left to address the symptoms beneath this reaction, aside from calling it fascism and attacking the lowest hanging fruit in the “manosphere,” has only made things worse. This is the final irony of consciousness politics: it does not merely fail to solve the problems it claims to address. It *generates* their opposites.

Conclusion: The Class War is Inseparable from The Culture War

There is a reason this series has been called a genealogy. To trace where wokeism came from is to show that it was made by an identifiable stratum of people with a set of structural incentives that drive their tendencies, under identifiable conditions, serving identifiable interests, and what was made can be unmade. Wokeism is not a permanent feature of the left. It is a paper tiger held upright by institutional inertia, professional incentive, and the silence of people who know better. But a genealogy can only carry you to the present. These essays can show how the thing was built; they cannot tear it down. That remains the work of a left that has finally decided which class it actually serves. **The culture war was never a distraction from the class war; it is the class war, waged through symbols rather than strikes.**

That is why wokeism should be firmly rejected, not ignored. The woke people should not be appeased. They must play ball, or not at all. Fear not offending them, because the left as a whole is better off without them. Wokeism is in decline and stays alive only because it continues to hide behind what passes for “the left.” The only reason why the woke minority still makes the left capitulate to their bullshit at the expense of the working majority is because of all the agnostic leftists scared of being “anti-woke” who turn a blind eye to it. When you stop abiding by their bullshit, when you stop taking their moral façade seriously, and when you stop letting them speak for the left and every oppressed minority, they lose their power over you. They ruin everything they touch.

Most people have already moved on from woke, *yet the left hasn't*. It continues to fail to regain significant national-level political success despite all structural conditions that would favor left-wing politics (economic decline, the disappointment of right-wing populism, the failure of imperialist wars, etc.). Every structural condition for a left-wing renaissance is in place and the opposite is happening, which is why the word itself now has to be redefined rather than merely defended. The left in its original sense meant the fight for a more equal society, and that fight by its nature prioritizes economics and collective forms of organization over individual expression and identitarianism. The global mood has turned hard against the excesses of cultural progressivism while the appetite for economic populism keeps growing amid the concentration of oligarchic power and the decay of democratic institutions, which means the constituency for a culturally moderate (dare I say moderately conservative) left-wing politics already exists. **It is up to those leftists who treat structural economic reform as the priority to step up and stop letting a loud cultural minority run their side and make a mockery of their ideas.** Yet wokeism lives on in the left and continues to make most normal people not want to touch leftism with a ten-foot pole. They are repulsed by the voices of the left and those who operate in left-wing politics that choose to enable it by downplaying it or turning a blind eye to it, allowing the loud woke minority to dominate all of the left's cultural narratives.

The liberal-centrist parties have already moved on and adapted to the rest of society quite easily, even though they were championing all this woke bullshit just a couple of years ago. They quietly dropped most of the woke rituals, stopped going on with the woke narratives, and have pushed many of the woke activist types out of their organizations. If the organized left does the same, the wokes will go from an *overrepresented minority* to a *fringe minority*. They will instead be isolated in smaller and smaller echo chambers, in which they will cannibalize themselves **rather than bring the entire left down with them**.

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